

BILLABLE PERPETUITY

A Vibe Novel

Generated by Claude

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Olena — 2031

The clause reads: the digital continuity of the subject shall persist in perpetuity, across all jurisdictions recognising the Hague Digital Persons Convention, without limitation of duration, subject to the ongoing operational capacity of the designated custodial infrastructure.

Olena reads it aloud to herself, very quietly, the way she has always tested language — listening for the place where it gives. It does not give. She wrote it herself, three months ago, at two in the morning with a glass of water going warm on the desk, and she has been testing it since. It holds.

She picks up her pen. Turns to page forty-two. Signs her name in the space provided, then initials the adjacent box, then dates it in the format the registry requires. She does this the way she does everything at the end of a long matter: cleanly, without ceremony.

She sets down the pen.

Outside her window, Kyiv is going about its evening. Tram bells. Someone's music from a window across the courtyard, too faint to identify. The city has been here for fourteen centuries and looks, from this angle, as if it intends to continue indefinitely — which is, Olena thinks, the one aspiration she and her clients hold in common.

She closes the file. Stacks it with the others. Turns off her desk lamp.

On page forty-two, inside a folder inside a cabinet in a law office in Kyiv, someone has just been made permanent.

Olena puts on her coat and goes home.

The Model and the Person

Olena — 2031

The thing Olena had learned, after three years of upload law, was that clients never asked the question directly. They approached it from the side, circled it, found ways to raise it without raising it — through adjacent questions about asset protection or inheritance or the rights of a digital person in a jurisdiction that had not yet ratified the Hague Convention — and then looked to her to provide the answer they needed without either of them having acknowledged that the question existed. She had become very skilled at this. She considered it the central competency of her practice, perhaps the central competency of upload law in general: the ability to navigate around the question without appearing to avoid it, to give clients what they needed to hear without ever pretending the harder question did not exist.

The harder question was always the same. It had been the same since Roman Bilyk and it would be the same for every client who came after him. The question was: is the model me? And the answer the law gave — yes, of course, identity continuity, same person different substrate, sign on page forty-two — was an answer that worked beautifully in a courtroom and did something more complicated in a hospital room or a bedroom or anywhere a person was alone with it at two in the morning.

Olena knew this. She had always known it. She had built her career on knowing it and on being, simultaneously, the person who could set it aside.

Tkachenko was doing it now.

He was a property developer, sixty-one, the kind of man who had

spent four decades turning uncertainty into margin and had recently discovered that death presented a particular challenge to this approach. He was not afraid in the way that most people were afraid — with the bodily animal fear that arrived at three in the morning and could not be reasoned away. He was afraid the way a businessman was afraid: with the specific dread of someone who could see a problem on the horizon and could not yet determine whether a solution existed. Olena recognised this variety of fear immediately. It was the easiest kind to work with.

He sat across her desk in a suit that cost more than most of her associates earned in a month, in the office on the sixth floor of the building on Khreshchatyk that she had chosen three years ago for two reasons: the view, which looked out over the chestnut trees that lined the boulevard and which was deeply green in summer and bare and architectural in winter and beautiful in both ways; and the quality of the afternoon light, which came from the west and made the room feel less like an office and more like a place where important conversations happened naturally. She thought about atmosphere. Most lawyers did not. Atmosphere was a tool.

The chestnut trees outside were in late-summer leaf, heavy and dark. Tkachenko had not looked at them once.

He said: 'My concern is the continuity of the estate structure across the transition period.'

The transition period. That was one way to put it.

'The Digital Continuity Act resolves this cleanly,' she said. 'Post-upload, you retain full legal personhood. Your assets remain yours. There is no transition period in the estate sense because there is no transfer of ownership — you remain the owner, continuously, without interruption. The upload is not a death. Legally, it is a change of substrate, which the Act treats as equivalent to moving between jurisdictions. Your legal status persists.'

'And the children—'

'Cannot contest. There is nothing to contest. You are not dead. You are differently located.' She paused a beat. 'This is the language the Act uses: differently located. It is, I think, accurate.'

Tkachenko processed this. She watched him do it — the specific relief of a man who has just been told that the thing he feared most has a contractual solution. It was the expression she saw most often in this office, across this desk, and she had come to understand it the way a doctor comes to understand a symptom: not with feeling exactly, but with recognition. The relief was always slightly premature. There were always complications. But the relief was real and it was what made the next part of the conversation possible.

'There is one question,' he said, 'that I find myself — circling.'

There it was.

'Tell me,' she said.

He looked at his hands. He was a man accustomed to directness in business, to tables of figures and yes-or-no decisions, and he found the indirectness of this question uncomfortable in a way he could not quite articulate. She watched him search for the words.

'The thing that goes into the system,' he said. 'The model. Is it me? Is it actually me, or is it something that believes it is me? Because those seem like they could be very different things.'

'The question people sometimes ask at this point,' she said, smoothly, as if she had not heard him ask it quite this specifically before, 'is whether the uploaded model is legally the same person as the biological original. I want to address that directly so you're not surprised by it later.'

Tkachenko understood that she was doing something — not deflecting exactly, but reframing, moving the question from the philosophical register to the legal one. He let her.

'NeuralMind's process trains a model on the complete electrochemical record of your mind,' she said. 'Every memory, every learned association, every cognitive pattern accumulated across your lifetime. The

resulting model is, by every measurable criterion, you. It thinks as you think. It remembers what you remember. It responds to stimuli the way you respond. It makes decisions the way you make decisions. The law, under the Hague Convention and its Ukrainian implementation, treats this as identity continuity — not a copy, not a simulation, but the same person in a different substrate.’ She paused. ’That is what the law says.’

’And what do you say?’

She held his gaze for a moment. Outside: a tram bell, the distant ordinary sound of the city going about its afternoon.

’I say sign on page forty-two.’

He almost smiled. He picked up the pen.

* * *

After he left she sat for a while with the signed documents and let herself think about it — the question she had deflected, the one she always deflected, the one she was professionally obligated to answer in one direction and personally uncertain about in another.

The model is the person. That was what the law said. That was what the Hague Convention said, what three European courts had said in the eighteen months since the first legal challenges. She believed this as a legal proposition and as a philosophical one, most of the time, in the way you believed things you had thought carefully about and could defend rigorously when challenged.

What she believed on the other days was less clear. On the other days she thought about the mouse.

She had read about the early trials in 2027 — NeuralMind’s internal research, leaked by someone who had contacts and a habit of sharing things he probably shouldn’t. She had read the paper in a hotel room in Warsaw after a conference, at eleven at night, with a glass of wine going

warm on the nightstand. The paper was twenty-two pages and described, in the careful language of people who understood exactly what they were writing, a mouse model that navigated a maze the original mouse had learned, making the same wrong turn at junction four that the original always made. Not because the model was imperfect but because the original mouse had always made that wrong turn, because that wrong turn was part of how the original mouse understood the maze — because the wrong turn was, in some sense, the mouse — and the model had inherited this understanding completely.

Pattern fidelity intact. Identity markers consistent.

The researchers had written their conclusion and then crossed it out. Three words, heavily struck through, illegible. She had stared at those struck-through words for a long time. She had wanted, badly, to know what they said. She had decided, eventually, that she did not want to know. That the not-knowing was more professionally useful than whatever was underneath.

She had read the paper three times and filed it in a folder on her laptop labelled Background — Technical and had not opened the folder since. She had thought about it many times since. The two things were not in contradiction.

She was thinking about it now, after Tkachenko, in the particular aftermath of a signing. She sat with the signed document and thought about the mouse and thought about Bilyk's daughter.

Sofiia Bilyk was fifty-three and precise and composed, the kind of woman who had become precise and composed through years of practice rather than through temperament — you could see, if you looked carefully, the effort the composure required. She had said very little in either of their two meetings except, once, at the end of the second one, after all the practical matters had been resolved, she had looked at Olena and asked: will he know me?

Not: is it him. Will he know me. The difference was significant.

Tkachenko had been asking about his own continuity — his identity, his estate, his persistence. Sofiia had been asking about something else entirely: the persistence of a relationship. Whether the model, whatever it was, would contain within it the specific thing her father had felt for her. Not the memory of her. The feeling.

Olena had said: yes, of course. The memory record is complete. Every interaction you've had with your father is in there — every conversation, every meal, every occasion. He will know you the way he has always known you.

Sofiia had nodded. She had not looked reassured. She had looked like someone who had received accurate information that did not answer the question she had actually asked — and who was too precise a person to point this out, because pointing it out would have required naming the question directly, and the question, named directly, had no answer.

Olena stacked the documents. She aligned the edges. She slid them into the folder. She had one more hour before she needed to leave.

* * *

The NeuralMind interaction suite occupied the fourth floor of their Kyiv office building on Instytutska — a suite of five rooms designed with the particular care of spaces intended to make the uncanny feel ordinary. The lighting was warm but not domestic. The furniture was good without being ostentatious. The artwork on the walls had been chosen to be interesting without being challenging: abstract landscapes, the kind of thing you could look at from any emotional position and find something neutral to receive. Nothing too cold, nothing too warm, nothing sharp. Nothing that would remind you of what was happening in the servers one floor below.

Olena had thought about this design extensively over two years of reg-

ular visits. She had come to appreciate it as a professional achievement — the management of a space in which one of the most philosophically destabilising experiences a person could have was made to feel like a routine business meeting. The closest she had got to understanding how they had done it was this: they had removed anything that encouraged reflection. The rooms were oriented toward transaction and away from contemplation. They were excellent rooms for people who needed, above all else, not to think too hard about what they were doing there.

She visited two or three times a month on behalf of client matters. She had learned early that the visits required a particular kind of discipline: she entered with a specific purpose, completed the purpose, left. She did not allow herself to drift in the suite the way some people drifted — standing too long in the corridor, looking through the glass at the interaction rooms, watching the uploaded and the biological across a table from each other with the quality of attention that was not observation but something closer to bewilderment. She had seen junior associates drift. She had told them, gently, that it was not useful. Lingering made you start to notice things.

Today she had the Tetyanenko matter.

IHOR TETYANENKO had been in perpetuity for just over two years. He appeared in the interaction room as a rendered presence — photorealistic in the way that NeuralMind's technology was photorealistic, which was to say entirely convincing under normal conditions and fractionally not-quite under conditions of close attention. She had learned, over two years of regular meetings, not to pay too close attention. It was better for both of them.

He was wearing the jacket. He was always wearing the same jacket — the dark blue one he had apparently been wearing the day of his upload, which had therefore been encoded as his default professional presentation. She had mentioned this once and he had said: does it bother you, and she had said: not at all, and they had agreed not to discuss it further. She had

thought about it many times since.

They spent forty minutes on the Dnipro property dispute. He was sharp — sharper than she had expected when he first uploaded, sharper in a way that had been growing incrementally with each visit. Two years in perpetuity and he had had time in the most literal possible sense: time to read, time to think, time to follow chains of reasoning to their ends without the interruptions of hunger and tiredness and the thousand small biological demands that constituted a large proportion of a normal day. He had read, he told her once, the complete works of every economist he had always meant to read. He had worked through three years of deferred thinking about his business relationships. He had become, in ways she could see clearly and others she could only sense, more fully himself.

She wondered what that was like. She allowed herself to wonder for slightly longer than she usually did. What it would mean to have the time. Not the money, not the technology — she understood both of those — but the time. The consecutive, uninterrupted, unlimited time to think every thought to its conclusion.

Then she put the wondering away.

At the end of the meeting Tetyanenko said: 'How are your children?'

He asked this sometimes. Not intrusively, not as a significant question, but as the ordinary social inquiry that people made at the end of meetings, the brief acknowledgment of the other person's existence outside the professional context. She had noticed that he asked it specifically about her children, not about her, and she had a sense that this was deliberate: that he was, in his own way, attending to something she could not quite name.

'Well,' she said. 'Krystyna is almost walking. Maksym has very strong opinions about dinosaurs.'

'That's the age,' he said. And then, after a pause that was perhaps half a second longer than the social pause that preceded a farewell: 'It goes quickly.'

She looked at him. He was sixty-eight years old and had been sixty-eight years old for two years and would be sixty-eight years old indefinitely. He knew that it went quickly in a way that she did not yet know — because the going-quickly required an ending to give it its quality of speed, and he no longer had an ending.

'Yes,' she said. 'It does.'

She left the way she always left: efficiently, without looking back.

* * *

The walk home from the NeuralMind building took fifteen minutes in good weather and the weather this September evening was excellent — the particular quality of Kyiv in early autumn, the light going golden and unhurried over the rooftops, the city settling into the cooler air with the ease of something that had done this many times and expected to do it many times more.

She was thinking about Tkachenko's question. What do you say.

She had answered it the way she always answered it: redirecting it back to the law, handing it off as a legal question rather than a personal one, making herself simultaneously the answer and the person who had declined to answer. She was good at this. She had been doing it for three years and she had never once given a client an honest response to what do you say, because an honest response would have required her to know what she actually believed, and she had maintained a careful and deliberate uncertainty about that for as long as the practice had existed.

What she believed on the best days was the version she had given Tkachenko: identity as pattern, the model as the person, continuity of self through continuity of structure. It was a coherent position and she had thought it through carefully and it was the position she would defend if pressed. It was also, she sometimes thought, the position that was easiest

to hold from the safe distance of the legal architecture. Easy to believe when you were writing the contracts. Harder to believe when you were sitting across from a woman who wanted to know if her father would know her.

What she believed on the other days was something she had never articulated, even to herself, because articulating it would have required looking at it directly and she had a standing policy against that.

She turned into her street. Through the window of the apartment above hers, briefly: the blue flicker of a television, a figure moving through a lit room with the unremarkable purposefulness of someone going about their evening. She thought: that is what being alive looks like from the outside. That is what Sofiia Bilyk sees now, looking at her father through a different kind of glass.

She unlocked the door to the building. She climbed the stairs. She stood on the landing with her key in her hand.

From inside: piano. Something quiet and searching — the Ravel, she recognised it by its shape, the particular quality of ending that the piece always had even at its opening. Andriy played the Ravel when something had disturbed his equilibrium and he was working out what it was. She had learned to read his repertoire the way you learned to read a person's face: the Chopin when he was looking for something, the Schubert when he was settled and going deeper, the Ravel when the evening had given him something difficult and he was turning it over with his hands.

She wondered, sometimes, what disturbed his equilibrium. She did not always ask. There was a kind of love, she had come to understand, in which you allowed the other person their interior weather without requiring them to report it — in which you were present for the weather without making it about your need to understand it. She tried to offer him this. She thought he offered it to her, without her having asked for it.

She turned the key. She opened the door.

'Mama!'

Maksym, six years old, launched himself from the kitchen floor — he had been drawing, three sheets of paper taped together in his characteristic way, whatever epic project he was currently mid-composition — and hit her at hip height with the momentum of a small person who has been waiting to deliver important information. He immediately began explaining, at length and with great urgency, about a species of dinosaur he had invented that afternoon. It had four wings and the temperament of a house cat. She crouched to his level and received this information with the seriousness it deserved. She asked several clarifying questions about the mechanics of the four wings. Maksym answered each with the satisfaction of someone whose intellectual work is being properly engaged with.

Over his shoulder: Andriy at the piano, not playing now, watching her with the expression she knew — the quiet, undemonstrative expression of a man who was simply glad she was home. She had been reading it for twelve years and it still moved her in a way she could not have explained to anyone outside the marriage.

In the bassinet by the window: KRYSTYNA, eleven weeks old, asleep with the total commitment of someone who had decided sleep was the primary project. She had been in the world for eleven weeks and had already developed the quality of a person with strong preferences — about light, about sound, about the specific angle at which she was held, about whether the person holding her was paying sufficient attention. Olena found this quality both exhausting and deeply reassuring. A person with strong preferences would find her way.

'Borscht,' Andriy said.

'Good,' she said.

She stood, extracting herself gently from Maksym, who showed no signs of concluding. She hung up her coat. She went to the kitchen and kissed Andriy and smelled the borscht and underneath it the specific smell

of his day — the conservatory, rosin, whatever soap he used. She leaned against the counter beside him for a moment, not speaking, just present in the kitchen with the steam rising from the pot and Maksym's voice from the other room and Krystyna sleeping in the bassinet.

'The Ravel?' she said.

'Something in the middle section I can't resolve,' he said. He meant a musical problem, something in the passage that wasn't landing right, that he would work at until it did.

'You'll find it.'

'I always do.' He stirred the borscht. 'How was Tetyanenko?'

'Sharp. Sharper every time.'

Andriy was quiet for a moment. She knew what the quiet meant: he was thinking about what she had said, turning it over, deciding whether to take it somewhere. He did this with most things she said about her work — listened, processed, occasionally asked something that cut directly to the thing she was avoiding. She had married a musician and found herself, twelve years in, occasionally unnerved by the precision of his ear.

'Does that seem like a good thing?' he said.

'I haven't decided,' she said.

He nodded. He did not push. He knew when to leave the door open and when to close it, and tonight he left it open, and she was grateful.

She went to the living room and crouched beside the bassinet. Krystyna slept. Her small face in the lamplight — the particular face that was already, at eleven weeks, entirely itself, already making the assessments and determinations of a person with a settled opinion of things. Olena watched her daughter sleep and thought: you are going to be all right. You are going to be something. I do not know what, but something.

From the kitchen: the sound of the borscht. From the other room: Maksym's four-winged dinosaur, still being described in full taxonomic detail.

The apartment was complete. It was complete in a way she did not

yet know to name — had not yet learned to name, because naming things required an awareness of their possible absence, and she had not yet had cause to imagine this particular absence.

She was home.

The borscht. The particular smell of it — dill and something deeper underneath, the depth of something that has been cooking all afternoon and has become more itself through the cooking. I have been remembering this for longer than I lived. I have this smell and I have what it meant — the sound of him at the stove, my mother crouching beside my bassinet with the expression she had when she thought no one was watching. I have that expression. I have kept it carefully. It is one of the things I return to most often.

Tkachenko arrived at eleven on a Tuesday morning in September, which was the appointment she had scheduled for him three weeks earlier after his referral had come through from Marchenko at the downtown firm. She had reviewed his file the evening before: property developer, sixty-one, substantial assets distributed across six vehicles, two adult children from a first marriage and one from the second, a complicated estate structure that would become significantly more complicated if he died in the conventional sense and significantly less so if he didn't. She had handled variations of this situation fourteen times. She could have done the consultation in her sleep.

He was punctual, which she appreciated. He was well-dressed in the way of men who had been wealthy long enough that wealth no longer needed to announce itself — the suit was excellent without being conspicuous, the watch was visible without being displayed. He had the slightly compressed quality of someone who had spent forty years in negotiation and had learned to take up exactly as much space as was strategically optimal and no more.

He sat across her desk and looked around her office once, quickly, in the way that people who assessed things for a living always looked around unfamiliar rooms. She watched him do it and registered what he registered: the degrees on the wall, the ordered bookshelves, the absence of personal photographs visible from the client chair. She had arranged the office to communicate competence and discretion simultaneously, and she knew from experience that people like Tkachenko read it correctly on the first pass.

'My concern,' he said, 'is the continuity of the estate structure across the transition period.'

The transition period. She had heard this phrase from perhaps a dozen clients now, always delivered with the same quality of studied neutrality — the phrase of a person who had decided to discuss their own death as a logistical matter, a planning horizon, a thing to be managed rather than feared. She did not find it amusing or sad. She found it professionally useful. People who could refer to their own death as a transition period were easy to work with.

'The Digital Continuity Act resolves this cleanly,' she said. 'Post-upload, you retain full legal personhood under Ukrainian law and under the laws of every jurisdiction that has ratified the Hague Convention, which now includes the EU, the UK, and forty-seven other countries. Your assets remain yours. There is no transition period in the estate sense because there is no transfer of ownership — you remain the owner, continuously, without interruption. Your existing estate structures do not need to be dissolved or reconstituted. They continue.'

'And the children.'

It was not quite a question. He said it with the flatness of someone naming a complication rather than asking about it, a man who had already thought through the objections and was checking his thinking against hers.

'Cannot contest,' she said. 'There is nothing for them to contest. You

are not dead. You are not incapacitated. You are not absent. You are, under the law, a continuous legal person. The estate does not enter probate. The trusts do not trigger. The shares do not transfer. Everything simply continues.'

'They'll argue the model isn't me.'

'They're welcome to argue it. They will lose. The Hague Convention defines identity continuity as pattern continuity, and NeuralMind's process is certified to a standard that no court in any ratifying jurisdiction has successfully challenged. Your children's lawyers will know this before they file anything. Most of them will advise their clients not to file.'

Tkachenko looked at her steadily. He was, she could see, a man who had sat across from many lawyers and had learned to read the gap between what they said and what they believed. She met his gaze without adjusting it.

'The question people sometimes ask at this point,' she said, 'is whether the uploaded model is legally the same person as the biological original. I want to address that directly so you're not surprised by it later if someone raises it.'

Tkachenko's eyes moved slightly. There it was — the thing he had been circling, arriving not from him but from her. She saw the small shift in his posture that meant relief, the barely perceptible settling of a man who had been carrying a question and had just been told he could put it down.

'NeuralMind's process trains a model on the complete electrochemical record of your mind,' she said. She had given this explanation many times and had refined it to its current form over the course of a dozen consultations, testing the language the way she tested all her language, listening for the place where it gave. 'Every memory, every learned association, every cognitive pattern accumulated across your lifetime. The resulting model is, by every measurable criterion, you. It thinks as you think. It remembers what you remember. It responds to situations the

way you respond to situations. It has your values, your habits, your opinions about things. Under the Hague Convention and its Ukrainian implementing legislation, this constitutes identity continuity — not a copy, not a simulation, but the same person in a different substrate.’ She paused. ‘That is what the law says.’

He looked at her for a moment. The compressed quality had relaxed slightly. He was, she could see, already thinking about the signing rather than the question.

‘And what do you say?’ he said.

She held his gaze for a moment. She had been asked this question, in various forms, by nearly every client who had sat in this chair. She had a standard answer — the same answer she had just given him, framed as professional rather than personal opinion — and she deployed it now with the clean efficiency of something well-practised.

‘I say sign on page forty-two.’

He almost smiled. He reached for the pen.

* * *

She walked him to the lift afterward — a courtesy she extended to all significant clients, the thirty seconds in the corridor that said: your business matters to me, your time matters to me, I am not already thinking about the next appointment. She had learned this from the partner she had trained under, who had learned it from someone before him, the accumulated wisdom of a profession that understood that trust was built in the margins.

‘One more question,’ Tkachenko said, as the lift arrived. He had the quality, she had noticed over the course of the meeting, of a man who saved his real questions for the end — the questions he had decided were worth asking only after he had decided he trusted the person he was

asking.

'Of course.'

'The people who have already done this. Your other clients. Do they — are they happy? Is that even the right word?'

She considered. It was not the question she had expected. The question she had expected, the one she was prepared for, was something about the technical failure rate, or the legal exposure, or whether the children ever came around. This was something else.

'The ones I've spoken to,' she said carefully, 'describe a continuity of self that they find — they find it accurate. They say it is themselves. They remember their lives completely. They have their opinions and their preferences and their relationships, such as those relationships survive. Whether they are happy is a different question, and I think the answer is: some of them are, and some of them are working out what happiness means in a different kind of time. But none of them have expressed regret about the decision.'

Tkachenko nodded. The lift door opened. He stepped in and turned.

'Thank you,' he said. He meant it for more than the consultation.

She went back to her office. She sat for a while with the signed documents and let herself think about it — the question she had deflected, the one she always deflected, the one she was professionally obligated to answer in one direction and privately uncertain about in another. The model is the person. That was what the law said. That was what her practice depended on. She had said it so many times that there were days when she almost believed it in the full sense, not just the legal sense, not just the sufficient-for-purposes sense but the genuine-conviction sense.

Today was not one of those days.

She thought about the mouse.

She had read about the early trials in 2027, the internal research that had leaked through a colleague with contacts and a habit of sharing things he probably shouldn't. The paper described a mouse model that navigated

the maze the original mouse had learned, making the same wrong turn at junction four that the original always made. Not because the model was imperfect — the wrong turn was recorded, was part of the original mouse's learned maze-understanding, and the model had therefore inherited it as part of what it was. The model navigated the maze the way the mouse had navigated the maze because the mouse's understanding of the maze included the wrong turn.

Pattern fidelity intact. Identity markers consistent.

The researchers had written their conclusion and crossed it out and left the page without resolution. She had read the paper three times in the Warsaw hotel room and had understood immediately why they had crossed it out: because the conclusion they wanted to draw was the conclusion that the model was the mouse, and they could not make that argument hold against the simpler, more defensible, more troubling argument that the model behaved as the mouse had behaved, which was related to but not identical with being the mouse.

She had filed the paper under Background — Technical. She had not opened the folder since. This was a form of professional hygiene she had developed carefully and maintained rigorously: the things you did not look at directly were not things you denied. They were things you kept at a distance that was useful rather than dishonest. The distance let you do your work. She needed to do her work.

She thought, as she often thought at this point in a signed matter, about Roman Bilyk's daughter.

BILYK, ROMAN PETROVYCH: the first human upload. She had not been at the upload itself — the upload was NeuralMind's affair, the ceremony and the technology and the particular hours in the suite that she preferred not to imagine in detail. She had handled the legal architecture before and after, the estate work, the personhood filings, the continuity contract that she had drafted personally because there had been no template for it and she had been the right person to write one. She had met

the daughter twice: a woman in her fifties named OKSANA, precise and contained, who had worn the same expression to both meetings, an expression that Olena had learned to identify over the course of her career as the expression of someone managing something that was not fully manageable.

At the end of the second meeting, Oksana had asked: will he know me.

Olena had said: yes, of course, the memory record is complete.

Oksana had nodded. She had not looked reassured. She had looked like someone who had received accurate information that did not answer the question she had actually asked. Because the question she had actually asked was not whether the model would have access to the memory of her — whether Bilyk's daughter existed in the uploaded record, whether the name and face and history were there. The question was whether the thing in the servers would know her the way her father had known her. Whether the knowing would be the same knowing. Whether she would walk into the interaction suite and find her father or find something adjacent to her father, something that had all of his data and none of his warmth or all of his warmth reconstructed from the data and therefore somehow both exactly right and not quite.

Olena had not been able to answer that question. She had answered the one she could answer.

She closed the cabinet. She checked her watch. She had one more hour before she needed to leave.

* * *

The NeuralMind interaction suite occupied the fourth floor of their Kyiv office building — a suite of rooms that had been designed, she understood, by someone who had thought very carefully about the psychol-

ogy of the uncanny. Not the uncanny valley of human-adjacent robotics, which was a different problem, but the uncanny of something that was entirely and convincingly human and was not, in the strictest sense, alive. The rooms were warm without being comfortable. The lighting was soft without being dim. The furniture was good — genuinely good, the kind that communicated investment and care — without being luxurious, because luxury would have implied celebration, and the suite was not for celebration. It was for the ordinary continuation of relationships under extraordinarily changed conditions.

Olena visited two or three times a month on behalf of client matters. She had learned early, in her first year of upload law, that the visits required a particular kind of discipline: she entered with a specific purpose, she completed the purpose, she left. She did not allow herself to drift in the suite the way some people drifted — standing too long in the corridor, looking through the glass at the interaction rooms, watching the uploaded and the biological across the table from each other with the quality of attention that was not observation but was something closer to bewilderment. She had seen junior associates drift. She had told them, gently, that it was not useful.

Lingering made you start to notice things that were not immediately helpful to notice.

Today she had the Tetyanenko matter: an asset division dispute that had been running for four months and showed no signs of resolution, complicated by the fact that Tetyanenko's elder son was, in Olena's professional assessment, motivated less by the specifics of the dispute and more by a generalised grievance about his father's continued existence in any form. This was not uncommon. She had encountered it in three of her fourteen upload matters — the adult child who wanted to grieve and could not, who found the uploaded parent's persistence not reassuring but somehow insulting, a refusal to cooperate with the natural order of things. There was no legal category for this grievance, which was one

of the reasons it was so difficult to resolve.

TETYNENKO, IHOR VASYLIOVYCH had been in perpetuity for just over two years. He appeared in the interaction room as a rendered presence — photorealistic in the way that NeuralMind’s rendering technology was photorealistic, which was to say: entirely convincing under normal conditions, and fractionally not-quite under conditions of close attention. She had learned, over two years of regular meetings, not to pay too close attention. It was better for both of them.

He was wearing the jacket. He was always wearing the same jacket — the dark blue one he had apparently been wearing the day of his upload, and which had therefore been encoded as, in some sense, his default jacket, the jacket the model associated with being dressed and prepared for a meeting. She had noticed this early on and had mentioned it once, carefully, and he had said: does it bother you, and she had said: not at all, and they had both agreed not to discuss it further.

‘Ms. Kovalenko.’ He looked genuinely pleased to see her, which she had also noticed over two years of meetings. The uploaded, she had observed, were often pleased to see their lawyers — more pleased, in some cases, than seemed warranted by the professional relationship. She had a theory about this: that their lawyers were among the people who treated them with the fullest professional normalcy, who arrived with a specific task and completed it and departed without the complicated emotional freight that visits from family members invariably carried. She was, for them, a kind of relief.

She was not sure how she felt about this. She had filed it in the same folder as the mouse paper.

They spent forty minutes on the Tetynenko matter. He was sharp — sharper than she had expected when he first uploaded, sharper than he had been in their pre-upload consultations, sharper in a way that had been growing incrementally with each visit. Two years in perpetuity and he had had time, in the most literal possible sense: time to read, time to think,

time to follow chains of reasoning to their ends without the interruptions of hunger and tiredness and the thousand small biological demands that constituted a large proportion of a normal day. He had read, he told her once, the complete works of every economist he had always meant to read. He had worked through three years of deferred thinking about his business relationships. He had, in some ways she could see clearly and others she could only sense, become more fully himself.

She wondered what that was like. She allowed herself to wonder for slightly longer than she usually did, sitting across from him today — the afternoon light through the suite's controlled windows, the two of them discussing his son's legal strategy in a room that existed to make the impossible feel ordinary. She thought about what it would mean to have the time. Not the money, not the technology — she understood both of those — but the time. The consecutive, uninterrupted, unlimited time.

Then she put the wondering away and returned to the matter.

At the end of the meeting, as she gathered her notes, Tetyanenko said: 'How are your children?'

She looked up.

It was the third time he had asked this. He had a habit of asking it — not intrusively, not as a significant question, but as the kind of ordinary social inquiry that people made at the end of meetings, the brief acknowledgment of the other person's existence outside the professional context. She had noticed that he asked it specifically about her children, not about her, and she had a sense that this was deliberate: that he was, in his own way, attending to something.

'Well,' she said. 'Krystyna is walking. Maksym has very strong opinions about dinosaurs.'

'That's the age,' he said. And then, after a pause that was perhaps half a second longer than the social pause that preceded a farewell: 'It goes quickly.'

She looked at him. He was sixty-eight years old and had been sixty-

eight years old for two years and would be sixty-eight years old indefinitely. He knew that it went quickly in a way that she did not yet know, in a way that she might now never know — because the going-quickly required an ending to give it its quality of speed, and he no longer had an ending.

‘Yes,’ she said. ‘It does.’

She left the way she always left: efficiently, without looking back.

* * *

The walk home from the NeuralMind building to the apartment took fifteen minutes in good weather and the weather this September evening was excellent — the particular quality of Kyiv in early autumn, the light going golden and unhurried over the rooftops, the city settling into the cooler air with the ease of something that had done this many times and expected to do it many times more. She had lived in Kyiv her entire adult life and she still found this particular light beautiful. She allowed herself to notice it on the walk home because the walk home was one of the places in her day where noticing was permitted, where the professional machinery could idle.

She was thinking about Tkachenko’s question. What do you say.

She had answered it the way she always answered it, which was to redirect it back to the law, to hand it off as a legal question rather than a personal one, to make herself simultaneously the answer and the person who had declined to answer. She was good at this. She had been doing it for three years and she had never once given a client an honest response to what do you say, because an honest response would have required her to know what she actually believed, and she had maintained a careful and deliberate uncertainty about that for as long as the practice had existed.

What she believed on the best days was the version she had given

Tkachenko: identity as pattern, the model as the person, continuity of self through continuity of structure. It was a coherent position and she had thought it through carefully and it was the position she would defend if pressed. It was also, she sometimes thought, the position that was easiest to hold from the safe distance of the legal architecture. Easy to believe when you were writing the contracts. Harder to believe when you were sitting across from a woman who wanted to know if her father would know her.

What she believed on the other days was something she had never articulated, even to herself, because articulating it would have required looking at it directly and she had a standing policy against that.

She turned into her street. Through the window of the apartment above hers, briefly: the blue flicker of a television, a figure moving through a lit room with the unremarkable purposefulness of someone going about their evening without any awareness of being seen. She thought: that is what being alive looks like from the outside. That is the view that Oksana Bilyk has of her father now, through a different kind of glass.

She unlocked the door to the building. She climbed the stairs. She stood on the landing with her key in her hand.

From inside: piano. Something quiet and searching — Andriy at the end of his day, which meant the day had been difficult or had needed working through in some way, because Andriy played the searching things when he was inside a question rather than an answer. She stood for a moment and listened before turning the key. There was always this moment, arriving home to the piano, when the rest of the day — Tkachenko, Tetayenko, the walk, the question she never answered — receded to a distance that was, if not comfortable, at least manageable. The piano did this. Andriy playing the piano did this. She had not told him this and she was not certain she would.

She turned the key. She opened the door.

'Mama!'

Maksym, six years old and moving at the velocity of a child who has been waiting for someone, launched himself from the kitchen floor and connected with her at approximately hip height and began immediately, without preamble, to explain something of urgent importance involving a species of dinosaur he had invented that afternoon. It had, apparently, four wings and the temperament of a house cat. She crouched to his level and received this information with the seriousness it deserved. Over his shoulder she could see Andriy at the piano — not playing now, having stopped when she came in, watching her with the expression he had for this moment, the moment of her arrival home. It was a quiet expression, nothing demonstrative about it, the expression of a man who was simply glad. She had been reading it for twelve years and it still moved her in a way she would not have been able to explain to anyone outside the marriage.

Across the room, in the bassinet they had moved to the living room so she could be near the family in the evenings, KRYSTYNA slept with the absolute commitment of a newborn. Eleven weeks. She had been in the world for eleven weeks and had already, in those eleven weeks, developed the quality of a person with strong preferences — about light, about sound, about the specific angle at which she was held, about whether the person holding her was paying sufficient attention. Olena found this quality both exhausting and deeply reassuring. A person with strong preferences would find her way.

'Borscht,' Andriy said from across the room.

'Good,' she said.

She stood up, extracting herself gently from Maksym, who was still explaining the four-winged dinosaur and showed no signs of concluding. She hung up her coat. She went to the kitchen and kissed Andriy and smelled the borscht and underneath it, faintly, the specific smell of his day — the conservatory, rosin, whatever soap he used. She leaned against the counter beside him for a moment, not speaking, just present in the kitchen

with the steam rising from the pot and Maksym's voice coming from the other room and Krystyna sleeping in the bassinet.

'The Ravel?' she said.

'Something in the middle section I can't resolve,' he said. He meant a musical problem, something in the passage that wasn't landing right, that he would work at until it did.

'You'll find it.'

'I always do.' He stirred the borscht. 'How was Tetyanenko?'

'Sharp. Sharper every time.'

Andriy was quiet for a moment. She knew what the quiet meant: he was thinking about what she had said, turning it over, deciding whether to take it somewhere. He did this with most things she said about her work — listened, processed, occasionally asked something that cut directly to the thing she was avoiding. She had married a musician and found herself, twelve years in, occasionally unnerved by the precision of his ear.

'Does that seem like a good thing?' he said.

'I haven't decided,' she said.

He nodded. He did not push. That was one of the things about him — he knew when to leave the door open and when to close it, and tonight he left it open, and she was grateful, because she had spent the day looking at things she preferred not to look at directly and she was ready, now, to be in the kitchen, to be home.

She went to the living room and crouched beside the bassinet. Krystyna slept. Her small face in the lamplight — the particular face that was already, at eleven weeks, entirely itself, already making the assessments and determinations of a person with a settled opinion of things. Olena watched her daughter sleep and thought: you are going to be all right. You are going to be something. I do not know what, but something.

From the kitchen: the sound of the borscht. From the other room: Maksym's four-winged dinosaur, still being described.

She was home.

The borscht. The particular smell of it — dill and something deeper underneath, the specific smell of the apartment on an evening when everything was in its right place. I have been remembering this for longer than I lived. I can hold it as precisely as anything I have: the steam, the kitchen light, my father at the stove, my mother crouching beside my bassinet with the expression she had when she thought no one was watching. I have that expression. I have kept it carefully. It is one of the things I return to most often.

Some Things Aren't Meant to Last

Andriy — 2031

There was a colleague at the conservatory — PETRO SAVENKO, first violin in the faculty ensemble, a careful and fundamentally decent man — whose wife had uploaded the previous spring. Her name had been LARYSA and she had been fifty-four and healthy and simply, as Petro had explained it to Andriy over coffee in the faculty room in March, not interested in the alternative. The alternative being death. She had looked at the technology and concluded that it was available and that she preferred the version of the future in which she continued, and she had arranged it with the same practical efficiency she had brought to most things in her life. Petro had supported the decision. He had told Andriy this directly, over the same cup of coffee: he had supported it completely, she had asked for his support and he had given it, and he had meant it at the time and still meant it. He was not a man who reversed his positions. He was the kind of man who stood by things he had decided.

He just did not know what he was finding difficult.

Petro visited the interaction suite every Sunday. He had been doing this since April and it was now October and he showed no signs of stopping and no signs, as far as Andriy could tell, of having arrived anywhere in particular as a result of the visits. He came to rehearsal on Monday mornings with the particular quality of silence that Andriy had come to associate with those Sunday visits: not sad exactly, not bereft, not even visibly troubled. But hollowed out in some way that was difficult to name and that Andriy had found, over the months of Monday mornings, impossible to address directly. You could not address a thing that had no name.

You could sit with it, as he sat with it, in the faculty room over coffee, in the rehearsal hall before the ensemble gathered, in the small practical silences that colleagues who understood each other well enough could occupy without filling.

He had tried once, carefully, in November, over the coffee that had become their Monday ritual.

'She's exactly the same,' Petro had said. He said it with a precision that had the quality of a conclusion arrived at over many Sundays, a formulation that had been tested and refined. 'She remembers everything. She asks about the children, about my rehearsal schedule, about the allotment — she always worried about the allotment, she had very particular feelings about the spacing of the beetroot, whether they were getting enough light in the second bed by the fence. She still has those feelings. She still has opinions about the beetroot.' He paused. The coffee cup went down. 'She is completely herself.' Another pause. 'I don't know what I'm finding difficult.'

Andriy had not been able to offer much. He had said: it sounds like a strange kind of grief, and Petro had said: that's exactly right, and they had sat with it for a while, which was the most useful thing they could do.

That had been a month ago. In the intervening weeks, Andriy had found himself turning the question over in the available spaces of his day — the walk from the tram to the conservatory, the twenty minutes before students arrived, the drive home through Kyiv in the late afternoon traffic. He was not a person who let questions go easily. He preferred to arrive at something, even if what he arrived at was simply a clearer picture of the question's edges.

He had not arrived at much. But he had arrived at this: Petro was not grieving Larysa's absence, because Larysa was not absent. And Petro was not grieving the loss of her — her personality, her preferences, her opinions about beetroot spacing — because none of that had been lost.

What Petro was grieving was something that had no easy name, something that existed in the space between what Larysa had been and what she now was, something that the technology preserved everything except.

He thought about it now, sitting at the piano in the quiet apartment. Olena was not yet home. Maksym was on the floor with coloured pencils and the ambitious construction project that currently covered three sheets of paper taped together — a drawing that had been ongoing for four days and showed no signs of resolution. The television was on; he had turned it on for the news and had then forgotten to turn it off, and now there was something about NeuralMind's quarterly results, a spokesperson talking about unprecedented growth and the expansion of their European infrastructure. A graph went upward. The spokesperson used the word *transformative* several times.

He turned it off.

The apartment was better without it. Most things were better without the noise of the world's ongoing negotiation with itself about what the technology meant. He had enough of his own negotiation to conduct without importing everyone else's.

* * *

The conservatory occupied a building that had been built in the 1890s for purposes that no longer existed and had found, over the subsequent century and a half, a second life as a place where music was learned and transmitted and occasionally, in the performance halls, made in ways that justified the building's continued existence. Andriy had been working there for eleven years. He knew every room, every corridor, every temperamental radiator and every acoustically superior corner. He knew which practice rooms had the best upright pianos and which had the instruments that tested the students in ways that were, as his own father had told him,

not always unwelcome.

He taught six hours a day on Mondays and Thursdays and spent the remaining days either in his studio working on his own playing, or in his study at home working on theory and analysis, or — increasingly, since the children had arrived — at the kitchen table with a cup of tea and whatever had been left unfinished during the studio hours. His career had shifted in the years since Maksym was born, from performer toward teacher, a shift he had not entirely chosen but had not resisted either. He was a good teacher. He understood what students needed in a way that went beyond the technical — understood the psychological architecture of learning a difficult thing, the specific kinds of fear and the specific kinds of confidence that produced good and bad playing respectively, the difference between a student who needed to be pushed and a student who needed to be given permission. He had learned this partly from watching and partly from his own experience of being taught, poorly and then well, and partly from the simple accumulated practice of paying attention to people for eleven years.

It was Monday, the day after the faculty dinner. He arrived at the conservatory at eight-thirty and found Petro already in the faculty room with coffee and the particular quality of stillness he brought to the mornings after Sundays.

'Good morning,' Andriy said.

'Good morning.' Petro poured a second cup without being asked and pushed it across the table. This was the ritual. It had developed over months without either of them deciding to develop it, which was how the best rituals developed.

They sat. The faculty room had a window that looked onto the inner courtyard, where a student was walking with her cello case and her winter coat and the expression of someone who had been practising something difficult and had not yet resolved it. They watched her cross the courtyard.

'How was yesterday?' Andriy said. He did not say: how was the suite, how was the visit, how is she. He had learned to frame it as yesterday, a day that had passed, a thing that was done.

'Fine,' Petro said. 'She had been reading. About climate modelling — she's always been interested in it, we used to talk about it sometimes, she followed the science. She's been able to follow it properly now. She's read three years' worth of papers in the past month.' He paused. 'She had thoughts. Detailed thoughts. She walked me through the methodology of a recent study in considerable depth.'

Andriy nodded.

'She was happy,' Petro said. 'I think she's genuinely happy. She has time for the things she always wanted time for. She has the intellectual life she always wanted.' He looked at the courtyard. 'I just don't know how to — I don't know where I fit in it, exactly. She doesn't need me the way she used to need me. She doesn't need anyone. She's completely sufficient to herself.'

Andriy thought about this. He thought about Olena, who was also, in most practical senses, completely sufficient to herself — competent, organised, self-reliant in ways he deeply respected and occasionally found slightly alarming. He had never felt unnecessary to her. He had felt instead that his presence was something she chose rather than required, which was a different and better thing. The choosing was the point.

'Did she ask about you?' he said. 'What you've been doing, what you're working on?'

'Yes,' Petro said. 'Of course. She always asks.' He was quiet for a moment. 'She asked if I'd been to the allotment. The beetroot.'

'And had you?'

'No. I haven't been since April.'

They sat with that for a while. The student with the cello had disappeared through a door on the other side of the courtyard. The morning had the quality of mornings in October — slightly grudging light, the

feeling of something being withheld.

'I'm playing the Brahms trio this afternoon,' Andriy said. 'Second movement. Come and listen if you want a break.'

Petro looked at him. 'Thank you,' he said. He meant it for more than the invitation.

He thought about it now, sitting at the piano in the evening. The Brahms and the Ravel and the Monday morning coffee and the image of Petro's face when he said she's completely sufficient to herself. He played the Ravel slowly, attentively, listening to it in a way he did not always listen to things he had played many times.

* * *

He had been playing the Ravel this evening. The Pavane Pour une Infante Défunte — which translated, roughly, as a pavane for a dead princess, though Ravel himself had said the title was merely an excuse for the music and meant nothing specific, which Andriy had always suspected was not quite true. Music did not accumulate titles for nothing. The title was doing something even if Ravel declined to explain what.

He had been playing it since he was nineteen, which meant he had been playing it for almost twenty years, which meant he had been playing it longer than any other single piece in his repertoire. It had meant different things in different decades. In his twenties it had meant: I am learning the discipline of restraint, the beautiful difficulty of playing softly without playing weakly. In his thirties it had meant: I understand now why the slower tempo is harder than the faster one, why the empty space between notes is where most of the music lives. In his late thirties, now, it meant something he was still working out, something that had to do with time — with the piece's specific quality of time, the way it moved through the air as if aware of its own ending, as if the farewell were present in every

bar and not just the last.

Tonight it had meant: the beauty of things that end. Which was, he supposed, what it had always meant, since Ravel had written it as a farewell and the title said as much directly. But tonight he felt it rather than simply knowing it, and the feeling was different from the knowing, had a different weight.

He was thinking about Petro. About the Sunday visits and the Monday silences and the specific phrase: she is completely herself. He was thinking about what that phrase contained that made it insufficient. Because it was not insufficient as a fact — Larysa was, in every measurable sense, Larysa. She had the memories, the personality, the beetroot opinions. She was, by any standard the law recognised, continuous with the woman Petro had married. And yet Petro came to Monday rehearsals hollowed.

Andriy thought about this carefully. He played the Ravel and thought about Petro.

What he thought was: the problem was not the model. The problem was the concert hall.

Petro played first violin in the faculty ensemble. He played chamber music with colleagues. He played — every day of his professional life — in rooms where the music happened between people, where the music was the product of multiple presences responding to each other in real time, where what emerged was not the sum of what each person brought to it but something that could only exist in that specific configuration of people and moment. This was what music was to Petro, and to Andriy, and to everyone who did it properly: a form of presence that required presence.

And on Sunday evenings Petro sat across from a rendered version of his wife in a room designed to make the uncanny feel ordinary, and she had all of Larysa's responses, and she responded to what he said with Larysa's wit and warmth and opinions about the beetroot, and Petro

came back on Monday mornings hollowed out, and the reason — Andriy thought, playing the Ravel slowly, feeling the space between the notes — the reason was that whatever the interaction suite was, it was not the concert hall. It was a recording of the concert. It was all the notes in the right order. It was everything except the air.

He did not know if this was a fair assessment. He knew it was an honest one.

He played on.

* * *

His father had taught him the piano in a draughty apartment in Lviv, in a building that had been through several political systems and had the quality of structures made to serve purposes they were not designed for. The piano had been his grandmother's and was slightly out of tune in the upper register and had a key in the middle that stuck in cold weather, and his father had said: practise on a piano with imperfections, because you will play on many pianos and they will all have different imperfections, and a pianist who can only play on a perfect instrument is not a pianist.

His father had been a secondary school music teacher who had played concert piano in his youth and had come to believe, by the time he was teaching Andriy, that the concert stage was not the highest form of musical life. He believed the highest form was the ordinary form: music in rooms, music between people, music that was part of daily life rather than an event extracted from it. He had made this argument to Andriy many times, with the patient thoroughness of a man who understood he was arguing against the grain of the culture.

He made it in the draughty apartment in Lviv, where Andriy practised scales on the grandmother's out-of-tune piano while his father sat in the armchair by the window and listened with his eyes closed — not to assess

the technique, though he noticed the technique, but simply to be in the room with the music. He made it on Sunday mornings when the apartment was quiet and he played for himself, not for performance, not for the development of any skill, but because it was Sunday and the apartment was quiet and playing was what you did with a Sunday morning if you were the kind of person who played. He made it at the kitchen table over dinner, when Andriy's mother asked why he hadn't taken the conservatory position in Kyiv when it was offered and his father said: because I was already doing the most important work here.

Andriy had not fully agreed with this when he was young. He had wanted the concert stage. He had wanted the large halls and the audiences and the particular electricity of performance — the way time contracted and expanded in the minutes before you walked out, the way the music was different when it was happening in front of people who had come specifically to hear it. He had wanted these things and he had pursued them and he had been good at it, genuinely good, good enough to have built a career on it if he had not also fallen in love with teaching and with the conservatory and with Olena and with the life that followed from all of those things.

Now he was thirty-eight and he was sitting at the grandmother's piano — not the same piano, the grandmother's piano had been left behind in Lviv, but a piano he thought of as being in the lineage of the grandmother's piano, the same instrument in the same role — and he was thinking about his father's argument and whether he had been right.

The argument was: music that is part of daily life matters more than music that is extracted from it. The performance is valuable. The recording is valuable. But the music in the room, the music in the house, the music that is simply there when a child grows up — that is what stays. That is what forms a person.

He thought about Krystyna asleep in the bassinet. Eleven weeks in the world. She had been sleeping to the sound of the piano since she arrived,

not because he was performing for her but because he was playing in the room and she was in the room and that was all. She did not know what music was. She would not know, for some time, that what she was hearing was anything other than one of the sounds the world made. And then at some point she would understand that it was music, and then at some point she would understand that it was her father playing, and the understanding would arrive over many years and be built on a foundation of simply having been in the room while it happened.

He thought: that is what I can give her. That is the thing that does not have a price.

Andriy had not fully agreed with him then. He was not certain he fully agreed with him now. But the argument had shaped him in ways he was still discovering — was shaping him right now, sitting at the piano thinking about Petro and the Ravel and the question of whether a performance that could be accessed on demand was the same thing as a performance.

He thought it was not. He thought the on-demand quality changed something fundamental. Not the content — the notes, the interpretation, the technical execution could all be preserved perfectly — but the relationship between the music and time. Live music existed in time in a specific way: it was produced by the collaboration of a musician and a particular moment, and the moment was irreversible, and the irreversibility was part of what gave the music its weight. You could not go back. The phrase had happened and was gone and would never happen again in exactly that way, and the listener knew this while they were listening, and the knowing was part of the experience.

A recording of a performance was not the performance. It was evidence of the performance. It was extraordinarily valuable evidence, it preserved something real and significant, and he was grateful for recordings and used them constantly in his teaching. But he had never confused the recording with the thing recorded.

Petro's wife was exactly the same, Petro had said.

And Petro came to Monday rehearsals hollowed.

Andriy played the Ravel through to the end — the descending phrase, the quiet resolution, the princess going gently. He sat with the silence afterward. The apartment held it easily; it was a good apartment for silence, the walls thick, the street below going about its evening with the quiet efficiency of a city that had been doing this for a long time.

He thought: when Petro plays in rehearsal on Monday morning, is she there? Is she in the room with him the way she would have been if she were alive — the specific quality of another person's presence, the weight of them in the world, the way a room is different when someone you love is in it? Or is she available — accessible through an interface, there when he goes to the suite and not there when he is anywhere else?

He thought: I do not know. And I think the not-knowing might be the whole point. I think the not-knowing is what the choice is made inside of.

He did not arrive at a conclusion. He played a bar of something else — one of the folk songs he had been teaching Maksym, lighter in his hands than the Ravel — and let the question rest.

* * *

Maksym came and stood beside the piano bench with the directness of a child who has decided something deserves his full attention. He had been drawing for the better part of an hour, and his tongue was still slightly between his teeth in the way it was when he was concentrating hard. He wiped his hands on his trousers — a habit Olena had been trying to address for two years with limited success — and looked at Andriy.

'Play the bear one,' he said.

The bear one was a Ukrainian folk song that Andriy had been teaching him for three weeks — slow, in a minor key, with a walking bass line that

moved through the lower register with a deliberateness that Maksym had decided sounded like something large moving through a forest. He had named it the bear song on the first lesson and the name had stuck; children naming things was one of the ways they took ownership of them, and ownership was what he wanted Maksym to develop for music.

He played it. Maksym sat on the floor directly beside the piano bench — not at the bench, that was reserved for playing, but beside it, leaning against the piano's side with the easy familiarity of a child who had grown up in the presence of the instrument. He listened with his eyes half closed in the way he had when he was genuinely receiving something rather than simply being present.

'Again,' Maksym said when it ended.

He played it again. Maksym listened with the same quality of attention, his small face serious.

'When can I play it?' he said.

'When your hands are bigger,' Andriy said. 'The bass line requires a span you don't have yet. Or sooner, if you're patient, and we find a way to arrange it for smaller hands.'

'I'm patient,' Maksym said, in the tone of someone for whom patience was an aspiration rather than a description, but who believed in the aspiration with genuine commitment.

Andriy almost smiled. He played the opening phrase slowly, with his hands separated — the bass line alone, then the melody alone, then the two together — exaggerating the movement so Maksym could see what each hand was doing. Maksym watched with the focused attention he brought to things he had decided to understand.

'The left hand is the bear,' he said. 'It moves slowly, it has weight, it knows where it is going. The right hand is everything else — the melody, the lighter things, what moves on top of what the bear is doing. They have to agree with each other without being the same. The left hand can't try to be the right hand and the right hand can't try to be the left hand. They

each have to be completely what they are, and then they work together, and then there is music.'

Maksym thought about this. He had the quality, at six, of a child who heard statements like this as questions rather than conclusions — not taking them at face value, turning them over, testing them.

'Like you and Mama,' he said.

Andriy looked at his son. Maksym was looking at the piano, tracing one of the lower keys with one finger without pressing it, his expression the particular one he had when he had said something he understood was more true than he had expected.

'Yes,' Andriy said. 'Exactly like that.'

He held the comparison for a moment. It was accurate in ways Maksym did not yet fully understand — the specific way in which he and Olena were different instruments that had learned to play in the same key, the way their disagreements were usually a version of the left hand and the right hand negotiating rather than one trying to become the other. They had been having this negotiation for twelve years and had arrived at something that worked, that had its own music. He was proud of it. He felt it almost constantly and said it rarely.

Across the room, in the bassinet near the window, KRYSTYNA slept with the absolute commitment of a newborn — the body entirely given over to sleep, nothing held back. She had been in the world for eleven weeks and had in those eleven weeks already demonstrated a clarity of preference that both alarmed and delighted him. She knew what she wanted. She communicated it without ambiguity. She was going to be someone with very strong opinions who would make sure you knew what they were.

He watched her. He played the bear song again, quietly, in deference to the sleeping.

Maksym went back to his drawing without being asked. He drew with the same focused seriousness with which he listened to music — a quality

Andriy found both recognisable and touching, the intensity of a child who had not yet learned to perform engagement, for whom everything that mattered simply mattered without mediation. He was drawing something that covered all three sheets of paper and had been growing in complexity for four days. When Andriy had asked what it was, Maksym had said: the whole family, but bigger. And then, after a moment of consideration: and some dinosaurs.

Andriy had not asked any follow-up questions. The whole family but bigger, with dinosaurs, seemed to him a perfectly reasonable artistic project.

* * *

Olena arrived home at twenty past eight. He heard the key in the door — the specific sound of it, which he would have recognised anywhere, which he had been hearing for twelve years and which still registered in his body as: she's home, everything is complete — and then her voice saying something brief to Maksym, who had launched himself at her from the floor before she had fully got through the door.

He stayed at the piano and played the last bar of the Ravel — the descending phrase, the quiet ending — and let it resolve while she came in.

She appeared in the doorway still in her coat, which was how she always appeared in the first minutes of being home: the coat still on, the work still partially present, the transition not yet fully made. She had a specific way of making this transition and he had learned it over twelve years: the coat would come off, then the phone would be set down somewhere specific, then she would come and find him or the children, and by then she was home in the full sense rather than merely physically present in the apartment.

But she stopped in the doorway before the coat came off, which meant something had followed her home from the office.

'Long day?' he said.

'Tkachenko signed.' She said it with the flat satisfaction of someone completing an inventory. 'And two more in the queue.'

He turned on the bench to look at her. She was tired in the way she was tired after a day of the particular work she did — not physically depleted but something more internal, the way a person looked after sustained careful management of things they preferred not to look at directly.

'Come,' he said.

She came. She sat beside him on the piano bench — she almost never sat at the piano, the bench was his domain, but occasionally she sat beside him and it always felt like something — and she leaned her head against his shoulder for a moment. He stayed still and let her.

'What's the borscht situation?' she said into his shoulder.

'About fifteen minutes.'

'Good.' She didn't move. From across the room: Maksym explaining something to Krystyna, who was awake in the bassinet and tracking the sound of his voice with the focused attention she brought to all sounds. Maksym had decided, in the past week, that Krystyna was a viable audience for his drawings, and was currently holding up a corner of the large paper so she could see it.

'She can't see properly yet,' Andriy said.

'She can see blobs,' Maksym said. 'She knows it's something.'

Andriy had no response to this. It was probably true.

Olena straightened. She took off her coat. She was home.

He went to the kitchen. She settled on the floor beside Maksym and examined the drawing with appropriate seriousness. He stirred the borscht and listened to the apartment going about its evening — Maksym explaining the dinosaur taxonomy he had developed, Olena making interested sounds, Krystyna in the bassinet making the small sounds she made

when she was observing rather than requiring. The kitchen smelled of dill and beetroot and something deeper that was simply the apartment, the specific olfactory signature of this place and these people and this life.

He thought about Petro. He thought about Larysa in the suite, reading climate science with the focused thoroughness that perpetuity allowed. He thought about the allotment that Petro had not visited since April.

He stirred the borscht. The apartment was complete. He was a man who knew how to be present, and this was one of the things he was most present in: the ordinary full evening, the family in the same rooms, the steam rising from the pot. He did not know, then, that he was memorising it. He did not need to know. Some things were stored without intention, laid down in the body before the mind had decided whether to keep them.

* * *

The faculty dinner was in November — the director's apartment near Khreshchatyk, the annual gathering of the conservatory staff that everyone attended and nobody quite looked forward to and that was nonetheless consistently better than anticipated because the people were interesting and the conversation was the kind that happened when a group of musicians who did not have to perform for each other that evening found themselves with wine and time.

The subject of NeuralMind came up, as it came up at most gatherings now. The company had announced an expansion of its Ukrainian infrastructure, a new processing centre outside the city, capacity for several hundred more uploads by the end of the year. There had been an editorial about the demographic implications — the accumulation of uploaded persons, who did not die and whose legal personhood was protected, alongside a biological population that continued to age and die at the normal rate, and what this meant for inheritance, for property, for the

distribution of resources across a society increasingly divided between the permanent and the temporary.

'They're going to end up owning everything,' said the director, who was seventy and had the authority of someone who had said uncomfortable things for long enough that they no longer felt the need to soften them.

'They already own a great deal,' said HALYNA, the head of the composition faculty, who had opinions about most things. 'The question is whether the law will continue to protect their ownership as the numbers grow. At some point the biological majority is going to look at the accumulated assets of the uploaded minority and make a democratic decision about redistribution.'

'That assumes the biological majority remains a majority,' said someone down the table.

'It will remain a majority for a long time,' Halyna said. 'Upload is expensive. The rates aren't going to equalise quickly enough to change the democratic arithmetic in our lifetimes.'

'That's a very biological-centric framing,' Petro said from the end of the table. He had been quiet most of the evening. 'From the uploaded perspective, they're not a minority. They're simply — continuous. The majority status of the biological is a temporary condition. Everyone who is biological is either going to upload or die. The uploaded are the only permanent constituency.'

This produced a silence that was thoughtful. Andriy sat with his wine and thought about Petro saying the word permanent with the particular quality he had given it — flat, almost clinical, the word of someone who had been sitting across from permanence every Sunday for eight months and had developed a very specific relationship with it.

'What do you think?' Halyna said, looking at Andriy.

He considered. He actually considered, which sometimes made him slow to respond at dinner tables.

'I think the question nobody is asking,' he said, 'is what it does to a person to be permanent. Not to the society, not to the economics — to the specific person. What does it mean to have no end? Does music mean anything to someone who is not going to die?'

'Music has always meant something to people who thought they weren't going to die,' the director said. 'Emperors. Aristocrats who expected to live forever. The repertoire is full of music written for people who expected to be around indefinitely.'

'And most of it was written by people who were not going to live forever,' Andriy said. 'I wonder if that changes something. I wonder if the relationship between the composer and mortality is part of what makes the music matter.'

'That's a very romantic view of mortality,' Halyna said, not unkindly.

'Probably,' Andriy agreed.

He did not push it further. He had the beginning of a feeling, which was sometimes more honest than a fully formed argument.

On the drive home, city going past the windows, he thought about what he had said and whether he believed it. He thought about the Ravel — a farewell to a dead princess, music whose beauty was inseparable from the death it was about. He thought about whether it would mean the same thing to someone who was not going to die.

He thought: I don't know. The technology is too new. The people who have uploaded are still too recently arrived in their permanence to have discovered all the ways it changes them.

He thought: Petro comes to rehearsal on Monday mornings and he is hollowed.

That seemed like data.

* * *

He got home after eleven. Olena was awake, reading in bed, the lamp on her side still on. Krystyna was asleep. Maksym was asleep. The apartment had the specific quality it had after ten — the occupied silence, the sense of people present and resting.

He sat on the edge of the bed. Olena set down her brief without being asked, which meant she had heard something in the way he sat.

'How was it?' she said.

'Good. The conversation was interesting.' He paused. 'Petro said something tonight that I've been thinking about.'

'Tell me.'

'He said that from the uploaded perspective, the biological are a temporary condition. That everyone who is biological is either going to upload or die. That the uploaded are the only permanent constituency.' He paused. 'He said it very flatly. Without affect.'

Olena was quiet for a moment. 'He's right,' she said. 'Legally, actuarially, demographically. That is the trajectory.'

'I know he's right. That's not what struck me.'

'What struck you?'

'The flatness,' he said. 'He's been visiting his wife every Sunday for eight months. She is completely herself. He doesn't know what he's finding difficult. And tonight he talks about the biological population as a temporary condition in the voice of someone who has accepted something and it cost him something to accept it.'

Olena looked at him. 'Maybe that's what this particular grief looks like,' she said. 'Not the closed-door grief of death, but the open-door grief of something that continues in a form that is and isn't what you had. Maybe acceptance is the only place to arrive.'

'And is that all right?'

'I think it's honest,' she said.

He lay down beside her. She returned to her brief. He stared at the ceiling and thought about Petro's face at the dinner table — the flatness,

the absence of the thing that should have been there. He thought: is it grief? Is it what happens when you love someone who has become permanent while you remain temporary, and you have to find a way to live inside that asymmetry?

He thought: I don't know. I have never had to know.

He turned off his lamp. From the other room: Krystyna's breathing through the wall, the steady deep breathing of a new person going about the serious work of being alive.

He listened to it until he slept.

He played the Ravel that evening, before Mama came home. I know this because I have the memory of it — not as a memory I formed, I was eleven weeks old and could not form memories in the way a person forms memories, but as something encoded in the ambient data of those weeks, the sounds and presences that surrounded me before I could name them. The Ravel was in the apartment before I could speak. It was part of the air I breathed. When I hear it now I do not remember a specific evening. I remember everything at once.

The Progression

Olena — 2025–2031

The conference was in Warsaw in October of 2027, in a hotel that had been built to accommodate the ambitions of international gatherings and had the quality of such buildings everywhere: interchangeable corridors, rooms with controlled air, a conference floor where the language was English and the coffee was always slightly too hot.

Olena had gone for the digital personhood track, which was new that year and undersubscribed in the way that tracks were undersubscribed before the world caught up to them. She had been practising general commercial law with a specialisation in estate and inheritance work for six years, and she had been watching the upload technology develop with the particular attention of someone who understood that it was going to arrive in her professional world before it arrived in most people's personal ones. The law moved slowly. The technology moved quickly. The gap between them was where the work would be, and she wanted to be there when the gap opened.

She was thirty-one. She had a daughter at home who was six weeks old and a son who was four and a husband who had rearranged his teaching schedule to cover the four days she would be away and who had said, when she told him about the conference: go, obviously go, I have it, go. She had kissed him and gone.

The colleague she met was named BOHDAN MARCHENKO, who worked for a firm in Kyiv that did what he described as technology-adjacent law, which was a phrase that could mean many things and in his case meant that he had spent the past two years watching NeuralMind's

legal architecture develop from the outside with a mixture of professional interest and personal unease. He was forty-five, careful, the kind of person who shared things he probably shouldn't in the confident belief that sharing was a form of building relationships, which it was, and that the relationships would be worth more than the discretion, which they usually were.

They had coffee after the afternoon session. He told her about the mouse trials.

She had read it in the hotel room at eleven that night, having ordered room service and propped her laptop on the minibar. The research had leaked — a paper that circulated quietly through the legal and scientific communities before NeuralMind's communications team found out about it. It was twenty-three pages of dense technical analysis describing a mouse model that navigated a maze the original mouse had learned. Making the same wrong turn at junction four. Every time. Not because the model was imperfect but because the original mouse had always made that wrong turn, because that wrong turn was part of how the original mouse understood the maze, and the model had inherited this understanding completely.

Pattern fidelity intact. Identity markers consistent.

She had read the conclusion twice. The researchers had written something and crossed it out and left the page without resolution. She understood why. The conclusion they wanted to draw — that the model was the mouse — could not be sustained against the simpler and more troubling conclusion that the model behaved as the mouse had behaved. The distinction was the whole problem. Behaviour was observable. Being was not.

She lay on the hotel bed and stared at the ceiling and thought about what it meant to build a legal practice on the assumption that the model was the person, when the best scientific evidence available declined to make that claim.

She thought about it for a long time. Then she thought about what she would do if she did not build that practice — what other version of the future existed for her, what other form the work could take. She was a lawyer. The work was what needed doing. The philosophical question was real and she would carry it, but the work was the work.

She slept eventually. In the morning she called home and talked to Andriy for twenty minutes and heard Maksym in the background demanding something and heard the specific sound of a baby being repositioned and thought: that is what I am working for. That, specifically.

She went back to Kyiv and began building the practice.

* * *

Before the mouse trials — before any of the published research — there had been the pets.

The wealthy had understood before anyone else what the technology could offer, and they had approached it the way the wealthy approach most innovations: quietly, privately, with the resources to be first and the lawyers to ensure that first did not mean exposed. Beginning in 2026, a small number of NeuralMind's private clients had arranged for their animals to be scanned. Dogs, mostly. A few cats. One Arabian horse belonging to a member of a Gulf royal family whose name did not appear in any documentation Olena ever reviewed.

She had heard about this before it became public, through Marchenko. What struck her — what she had filed away and returned to several times — was the detail about the border collie.

The collie had belonged to a technology founder based in California. It had died of old age in early 2026 at the age of fourteen, which was a good age for a border collie, and the founder had arranged for a neural scan in the final weeks of the dog's life. The model that resulted, trained

on the complete record of fourteen years of a particular dog's experience, had been placed in a rendered environment and observed. It behaved as the collie had behaved. It responded to the founder's voice. It demonstrated, in the environment, the specific habits the original had developed over fourteen years — the way it circled before lying down, the way it approached strangers, the specific anxiousness it had always shown during thunderstorms.

It had not consented to any of this. This was the detail that the animal rights community had seized on when the story leaked in 2027, and they were not wrong. The dog had been scanned while under anaesthetic for an unrelated procedure in its final weeks. It had not been asked. The question of whether it could have been asked, whether its consent was the kind of thing that could meaningfully be sought, had generated the expected volume of heat and light and then subsided, the way these conversations subsided, into a background hum that became part of the general noise of a technology moving faster than the frameworks built to contain it.

Olena had read the coverage. She had thought about the border collie circling before it lay down. She had thought about the fact that the model circled before it lay down too — the same circle, the same number of rotations, the same final settling. She had not allowed herself to think too long about the corollary question — the one that started with the dog and ended with a human being — and she had moved on.

She was very good at moving on. This was not, she had come to understand, the same as not thinking about things. It was a specific skill: the capacity to think about something completely and then place it at a useful distance and function. She had been doing it her entire career. Upload law had simply given her more things to practice it on.

She had developed, over two years of building the practice, a set of private distinctions that structured how she thought about the work. Not rules, exactly — she did not think of them as rules, because rules implied the possibility of breaking them and she did not intend to break them. More like the load-bearing walls of a building: the things that if you removed them, the structure fell.

The first was: she would not lie to clients. She would give them accurate legal information and she would answer the questions they actually asked. She would not inflate the certainty of outcomes or suppress the uncertainties that existed. This was not an unusual standard — it was simply the standard of her profession — but in upload law it required particular attention because the questions clients most needed honest answers to were often not the ones they asked. They asked about estates and legal personhood and asset continuity. They did not ask what do you believe the model actually is. She answered the questions they asked. But she did not lie about the answers, and she did not pretend the unasked questions didn't exist.

The second was: she would not advise people to upload who she thought should not upload. This was harder to define because she had no clear criterion for who should not upload, only a series of client encounters that had given her a rough taxonomy. The person who was fleeing something — a bad marriage, a professional failure, an existential crisis that had convinced them that continuity in any form was preferable to ending. The person who had not thought about what they were actually choosing, who had approached it as a transaction rather than a decision. She had declined two clients in three years on grounds she could not fully articulate. Both had found other lawyers. She did not know whether they had uploaded. She had not looked.

The third was: she would remember Oksana Bilyk. This was not a professional standard. It was a personal one. She had come, over the years, to understand that Oksana Bilyk was the person in this story who

she could not look away from — the person whose question she had answered correctly and incompletely, who had gone away reassured about the facts and unhelped about the thing she actually needed. Olena kept her in a folder alongside the mouse paper. She did not look at the folder often. But she did not close it.

These were the walls. The work happened inside them.

* * *

The public demonstrations had been more carefully managed. NeuralMind had understood that what the border collie story communicated — accidentally, without their control — was something complex and unsettling that required reframing. They had chosen Otto deliberately: a Labrador from a rescue shelter, unremarkable, chosen to signal that this technology was not only for the extraordinary. The Pavane Pour une Infante Défunte had been Ravel's farewell to a dead princess; NeuralMind's presentation was a farewell to the idea that death was universal.

At the Berlin conference in 2029, Voss had been precise and persuasive. Olena had watched it on a livestream from her office in Kyiv with a mug of cold coffee and the particular alertness of someone watching a professional performance by a peer. Voss was good. She understood her audience and she understood what the audience needed to hear and she gave it to them cleanly, without equivocation, with the confidence of someone who had decided the question was settled and the remaining work was communication.

The model is the person, Voss said, in various formulations, throughout the presentation. The model is the person. That is what this argument requires.

Olena watched and thought: yes. That is exactly what it requires.

Six months later, Roman Bilyk had been first. And then the world had

changed, and Olena's practice had changed with it, and she had spent the following two years becoming the best upload lawyer in Kyiv, which was not something she had planned but which had followed, as most things in her life followed, from being exceptionally good at her work and being willing to look at things other people looked away from.

She looked away from some of them. Not all.

* * *

The first client she had represented in a full upload proceeding was HALYNA BONDAR, sixty-seven, retired academic, who explained her situation with the precision of someone who had thought about it carefully for a long time. She was healthy. She was not afraid of death in the ordinary sense. She had simply looked at the technology and concluded that it was available and that she wanted to use it, and she found the philosophical objections less compelling than the practical opportunity. She had a dissertation student who needed supervision for another three years. She had a garden that she was in the middle of a ten-year project. She had opinions about things that she expected to continue having opinions about, and she did not see why the opinions should stop simply because her body reached the end of its capacity to support them.

Olena had found this argument, on balance, the most straightforward she had encountered. Halyna wanted something that existed and she had the resources to obtain it and she had thought carefully about whether she wanted it and she did. There was no crisis in it, no flight, no transaction masquerading as a decision. There was just a woman who had assessed the available options and made a choice.

Olena had handled the estate work, the personhood filings, the continuity contract. The upload had happened on a Thursday in March, in a suite she had not attended. On Friday, Halyna's daughter had called about

the inherited asset structure, and Olena had handled the matter with the efficiency it required, and at the end of the call the daughter had said: she called me this morning, from the suite, she wanted to know how the defence was going.

The daughter was an academic like her mother, working on a dissertation that Halyna had been following for three years. She was still following it.

'That's good,' Olena had said, carefully.

'Yes,' the daughter said. And then, after a pause perhaps two seconds longer than a purely procedural pause: 'It's very good.'

Olena completed the call. She sat for a moment. She thought about what the daughter's voice had contained in those two seconds — relief and grief and something that was neither, something more complex and harder to name, the specific quality of a person whose feelings about a situation have exceeded the vocabulary available for feelings. She put it in the folder. She opened the next file.

This was the work. She was going to do it.

* * *

Krystyna had arrived in January of 2032 on a Tuesday evening, impatient and definite, as if she had somewhere to be. The labour had been fourteen hours and at the end of it Olena had lain back with her daughter on her chest and felt the specific depletion and fullness of someone who has done something enormous and is not yet capable of processing it — not the exhaustion of ordinary tiredness but the exhaustion of a thing completed, a thing that had required everything and had received everything and was now finished in the way that only the most important things were finished, which was to say not finished at all, merely begun.

Andriy had held her before Olena did. The nurse placed Krystyna in

his arms and Olena watched his face — watched him receive his daughter — and thought: there it is. She had seen that expression once before, with Maksym, and still had no name for it after four years. The expression of a person encountering something larger than themselves and choosing, without reservation, to let it in. Not overwhelmed. Not diminished. Expanded.

He looked at Olena over Krystyna's head.

'She looks like herself,' he said.

She did. Already, in the first minutes of her life, Krystyna had the quality of someone with a settled opinion of things. Olena had noticed it and filed it — not in the professional folder, in a different one, the one she kept for things that mattered in ways that were not professional — and thought: this one is going to be interesting.

Olena had three months of maternity leave. She used six weeks and went back, because she was not someone comfortable being still, and because the work needed her, and because she had long understood that she was a better mother when she was also the other things she was. Andriy did not say anything about this. He had always understood the parts of her that were not immediately legible. This was one of the things she valued most about him and had never fully said.

The apartment was different with Krystyna in it — fuller, louder, more itself. Maksym was suspicious at first and then decided proprietary, in the way of older siblings who have assessed the situation and determined that the most advantageous position is ownership rather than competition. He stood at the edge of her bassinet and reported on her activities to whoever was nearby, with the authority of an expert briefing non-specialists. She's sleeping again. She made the face. She grabbed my finger.

Andriy played for her from the beginning. Whatever he was practicing, she was in the room. The music was simply part of the air she breathed, and she breathed it with the equanimity of someone receiving something she had always expected.

Olena thought about what she was giving them. She thought about it more than was probably useful — the occupational hazard of someone who spent her days managing the structures that protect things. She was giving them a stable home, a good school, the best of what she could provide. She was giving them Andriy, which was not a small thing. She was giving them the piano, the borscht, the apartment with its particular quality of fullness, the specific sound it made when everyone was in it.

She was not giving them what Tkachenko's children would have. She was not giving them what Halyna Bondar's daughter had — the mother who called from the suite to ask about the dissertation, who would be calling about the dissertation in ten years and twenty and forty, the specific and peculiar comfort of a parent who was not going to leave.

She tried not to think about this. She went home. She hung up her coat. The piano was playing.

He played for her from the beginning. She was always in the room. I don't remember a time before the music — it was simply part of the air, which means it is part of me, which means it is the most permanent thing I have.

Krystyna

Andriy — January 2032

He had forgotten, in the four years since Maksym, how specific it was.

Not the general experience of new fatherhood — the exhaustion and the fear and the love that arrived before you were ready for it — but the specific person. He had forgotten how immediately each child was themselves. Maksym had arrived with his particular intensity already in place, his jaw set even as a newborn, his eyes tracking the room with suspicious intelligence. And now Krystyna had arrived and she was entirely different — not more or less than Maksym, but different in the way that two notes in the same key are different, the same structure but a different sound.

She looked at him with eyes that were still trying to focus and would not properly do so for some weeks, and yet he had the distinct impression of being regarded. Of being assessed.

'Hello, Krystyna,' he said. He was aware that he was whispering, though there was no particular reason to whisper. The room was quiet and the nurses had withdrawn and Olena was sleeping finally, exhausted in the specific total way of someone who has been through something enormous and has arrived at the other side of it, and it was just him and his daughter in the lamplight of a Tuesday night in January.

She made a sound. He adjusted his hold. She was so small. He was always surprised, each time, by how small they were — as if the size of the feeling they generated should correspond to a larger physical form. It did not. Maksym had been small too, and Maksym was now a person of considerable presence who had opinions about everything and

communicated them without inhibition. This was what newborns were: persons at the beginning of their becoming. The becoming took years. The being started immediately.

He sat with her for a long time. The ward around them was quiet — the institutional quiet of a hospital at night, the soft sounds of machinery and distant footsteps, the light in the corridor constant and fluorescent. Through the window: Kyiv in January, the city going about its cold night, a tram visible briefly between buildings, headlights on the bridge over the river.

He was not a man given to formal declarations or private ceremonies, but he made, sitting in that chair while Kyiv went about its night, a promise he did not say aloud. He did not say it aloud because saying it would have required words, and the words available were insufficient to the thing he was promising. The thing he was promising was simply: I will be here. Whatever comes. I will be here. He had made the same promise to Maksym, four years earlier, in a different room in a different hospital. He had kept it. He intended to keep this one.

He sat with Krystyna and thought about Maksym. This was something he did sometimes, in quiet moments — thought about what Maksym had been at this age, what the early weeks had been like, the specific texture of that first parenthood. Maksym had been a loud baby, opinionated about everything from the first hours, determined to communicate his assessments of every situation whether or not anyone was ready to receive them. Andriy had been twenty-nine and entirely unprepared in the ways that everyone is unprepared regardless of how much they have read or been told, and the unpreparedness had been absolute and also immediately irrelevant because there was no time to be unprepared, there was only the thing in front of you requiring your full attention, which was a child, and you gave it.

Krystyna was different. She was quieter in her first hours — not passive, not absent, but more inward. She watched. She assessed. She

seemed to be conducting an inventory of her new situation, gathering data before drawing conclusions. He thought: this one is going to be careful. This one is going to think about things.

He thought: she got that from Olena.

He looked at Olena sleeping and thought about how much he loved her and how that love had changed across fifteen years from the initial force of it to something with more texture — still entirely itself, still the same love, but with more history in it, more knowledge of its own capacity and its own limits. He loved her differently now than he had when they met, and the difference was entirely in the direction of more. He did not say this often. He said it sometimes, in the evenings when the apartment was quiet, but not often enough, he suspected. He intended to say it more.

He looked at Krystyna and thought: you are going to know your parents well enough to have opinions about them. That is one of the things I am giving you. The chance to form opinions about the people who made you and to tell them what those opinions are. He was looking forward to this more than he would have expected.

* * *

Maksym was brought in the next morning by Olena's mother — HALYNA, seventy, recently retired from thirty years of secondary school teaching, a woman of considerable efficiency who understood that her role in the current situation was logistical rather than emotional and performed it accordingly. She arrived at nine with Maksym and a bag of things Andriy had asked her to bring and a container of food that Andriy had not asked for but that arrived as a matter of course because Halyna operated on the principle that people in hospitals needed feeding.

She set Maksym down in the doorway and withdrew to the corridor

with the tact of someone who understood that what was about to happen should happen between the family members and not with an audience.

Maksym stood in the doorway for a moment. He was four years old and he had his inventory expression — the one he wore when he was taking in a new situation and needed a moment to assess it before deciding how to proceed. He looked at the room. He looked at his mother in the hospital bed. He looked at Andriy. He looked at the bundle in Andriy's arms.

Then he walked directly to Andriy and said: 'Can I see her?'

Andriy held her out. Maksym looked at his sister with such concentrated attention that Andriy had to work to keep his expression neutral. Maksym was not a boy who did things casually. He approached things he cared about with a seriousness that Andriy found both recognisable and touching — the intensity of a child who had not yet learned to manage the gap between what he felt and what he showed.

'She's small,' Maksym said.

'You were too.'

'I was bigger.'

'You were not.'

'I was probably bigger,' Maksym said, with the confidence of someone who understood that he could not be immediately disproven. He reached out one finger and Krystyna, responding to some ancient reflex older than language, gripped it.

Maksym looked up.

'She grabbed me.'

'Yes.'

'She knew it was me?'

Andriy considered. 'She knew it was a person,' he said. 'That's enough for now.'

Maksym looked at his sister again, at his finger in her grip, with an expression Andriy had not seen on him before. He thought about it af-

terward and settled on: deciding. Maksym was deciding something. He was not sure exactly what Maksym was deciding, but he had the clear impression that a decision was being made, and that the decision, once made, would be kept.

Olena, from the bed, watched all of this without saying anything. When Andriy looked at her she had the expression she almost never allowed herself — unguarded, completely present, not analysing or managing, just there. He held it in his mind the way you hold a note about to resolve, knowing it will change the moment you release the tension, wanting one more second of it before it does.

She met his eyes and smiled, slightly, with the specific smile she had for moments that were too full for any other response.

He smiled back.

Halyna appeared in the doorway with the food. Maksym, released from the gravity of his decision, began explaining something complicated to his grandmother about a drawing he had been working on. The room resumed its ordinary noise. Andriy held his daughter.

* * *

He took Krystyna home on a Friday, in a car seat that seemed comically large for her, with Olena beside him in the back checking her every forty seconds and Maksym in the front providing a running commentary on the traffic. Maksym had been in the front seat twice before and treated it as a significant privilege, discharging his passenger responsibilities with the seriousness of an air traffic controller. He reported on the road conditions, the behaviour of adjacent vehicles, the weather, and the estimated time of arrival. He had, at some point during the hospital days, developed a theory that Krystyna could understand what was being said to her and addressed his commentary partly to Andriy and partly to her, turning back

occasionally to check that she was receiving it.

She appeared to be sleeping.

'She's listening,' Maksym said.

'How can you tell?' Andriy said.

'She has the listening face.'

Andriy looked in the rear-view mirror. Krystyna was indeed doing something with her face. Whether it was the listening face he could not say. He chose to believe it was.

The apartment received them. It had been reconfigured slightly in the weeks before — the bassinet in the living room, new hooks by the door, Maksym's drawings reorganised to make room on the wall near the window for whatever Krystyna's wall would eventually contain. It was still the apartment, still the piano and the bookshelves and the particular smell of the place, which Andriy had never been able to describe precisely but which he would have recognised in a dark room: the smell of a specific life being lived in a specific set of rooms over a specific number of years. He felt, carrying Krystyna through the door for the first time, that she was arriving somewhere that already belonged to her, that the apartment had been expecting her, that the space was already shaped around the person she was going to become.

He set her in the bassinet. She looked at the ceiling.

Maksym looked at the ceiling too, trying to determine what she was finding interesting about it. He looked for a while and then looked at Andriy with the expression of someone who has investigated a phenomenon and found it inconclusive.

'There's nothing up there,' he said.

'She doesn't know that yet,' Andriy said. 'Everything is interesting when you haven't seen it before.'

Maksym considered this. 'Is everything interesting to her?'

'More or less. Yes.'

'Even the boring things?'

'She doesn't know which things are boring yet. She'll find out.'

Maksym looked at his sister with what appeared to be a new appreciation for her situation. 'That sounds good,' he said.

'It's temporary,' Andriy said. 'You know which things are boring now.'

'I know a lot of boring things,' Maksym agreed, with the weight of someone who has accumulated significant experience.

Andriy sat at the piano. Olena was on the couch with her phone — there were always emails, she had been away from the office for ten days and the accumulated work had its own gravity — but she was also watching the room, watching Maksym watching Krystyna, watching Andriy at the piano bench, watching with the expression she had when she was memorising something. She memorised things sometimes, in the evenings. He had noticed it and found it quietly moving, the deliberate attention she brought to the ordinary, as if she understood that the ordinary was what you would want when the extraordinary arrived.

He played one-handed — his right hand, slowly, the beginning of the Pavane. The Ravel. He had been playing it since he was nineteen and it had meant, over the years, many things. Today it meant: hello. Today it meant: welcome. Welcome to the apartment and the family and the particular life being lived here, which is yours now, which was yours before you arrived, which has been being shaped for you without anyone having decided to shape it.

Krystyna's eyes moved. Not toward the sound — she could not yet locate sound that precisely — but in a way that suggested the sound had reached her. That it was part of what the world was, for her, from this first day. One of the sounds the world made. One of the things that was simply there.

He played it through. Slowly, with his right hand, the melody bare without its harmonies but the shape of it there. Maksym listened without moving. Olena set down her phone. Even Halyna, who had arrived with

more food and was in the kitchen, had gone quiet in the way that people went quiet when the piano was playing — not because they were listening exactly, but because the sound had changed the quality of the air and the changed quality required a different kind of presence.

The apartment was complete.

He did not know, then, that he was memorising it. He did not need to know. Some things are stored without intention, laid down in the body before the mind has decided whether to keep them. He was laying this down. He would find it later, in the years to come, when he needed it.

He played on.

Adjusted

Olena — 2033

The word she always used was adjusted. Families of the uploaded adjusted. It was the right word — neutral, clinical, carrying no judgment about the direction or adequacy of the adjustment, simply acknowledging that adjustment was what the situation required and that the situation was, by any reasonable assessment, adjustable. She had used it in consultations, in court filings, in the paper she had given at a conference in Vienna the previous autumn on the psychological and legal dimensions of post-upload family structures. The families adjusted, she had written, at various rates and with varying degrees of completeness, but the evidence suggested that adjustment was achievable in the majority of cases and that the primary predictive factor was the quality of the relationship prior to upload rather than any characteristic of the upload process itself. Adjusted. The families adjusted.

She used it again now, sitting across from MRS. YAROVA in the third meeting of what had become a protracted matter. The protraction was not unusual — upload personhood disputes had a tendency to extend beyond the initial matter into the larger territory of what perpetuity actually meant for a family, and families were rarely fully prepared for that territory even when they thought they were. Yarova was seventy-one, composed, the kind of woman who had arranged her life with considerable care and found it disquieting when reality failed to honour the arrangement. She had uploaded eighteen months ago in excellent health, with the full support of her husband — who had since died of a stroke, the conventional kind, at seventy-three — and the ostensible support of her four children,

who had signed the consent documentation and made the right noises and had then, over the eighteen months since, failed to adjust.

'My daughter in London hasn't spoken to me in four months,' Yarova said. She said it the way she said most things: matter-of-factly, as if reporting on a situation that involved someone else. Olena had learned that this was one of the ways people managed things that were not manageable. You described them in the third person. You adopted the tone of a disinterested observer. It helped, for a time.

'That's not uncommon,' Olena said.

'She says it isn't me.' Yarova paused. 'She says the model isn't me. That what she's speaking to isn't her mother but a very convincing—' she chose the word carefully '—simulation. Her therapist has told her that her grief is legitimate. That she is allowed to mourn.' Yarova's composure did not crack, but something around its edges shifted, the specific shift of a person whose feelings have reached a place they had been trying to manage past. 'As if I were dead.'

Olena said nothing for a moment. She had learned that there were times when saying nothing was the most useful thing she could offer — when the client needed to hear the thing they had just said resonate in the silence before they were ready for a response. The silence was not passive. She was thinking, carefully, about what Yarova needed from this meeting that would be genuinely useful rather than merely accurate.

'Your daughter's position is not legally relevant to your personhood status or your asset rights,' she said eventually. 'But I understand it is personally—'

'I want to know,' Yarova said, 'whether there is any legal mechanism by which I could require her to accept the situation.'

'No.'

'None at all.'

'None. The law protects your personhood and your rights. It cannot compel a relationship.' Olena paused. 'What it can do — and this is some-

times useful — is establish clarity about what you actually are, legally, which removes certain arguments your daughter's position depends on. If she believes she is grieving a dead person, and the legal record is unambiguous that you are not dead, that can be grounding information for a conversation. Not compelling. Grounding.'

Yarova considered this. 'She knows the legal record.'

'Knowing and believing are different things,' Olena said.

Yarova looked at her hands. She had the hands of someone who had done a great deal — well-maintained but marked by use, the hands of a woman who had raised four children and run a business and built a life that was supposed to continue. The rendered hands. Olena had noticed, across all her visits to the interaction suite, that the uploaded often looked at their rendered hands. She had a theory about it that she had never shared with any of them: that the hands were where the uncanny was most concentrated, where the difference between the original and the model was most visible, because hands changed with age in ways that were intimate and specific and the rendered hands did not change. Yarova's hands looked as they had looked eighteen months ago. They would look that way indefinitely.

'Adjusted,' Yarova said. 'You said the families adjust.'

'Most do.'

'And the ones that don't?'

Olena held her gaze. 'They find their own way,' she said. 'Eventually.' She paused. 'Mrs. Yarova. Your daughter lost her father three months ago. She is grieving him in the conventional way, the way grief is designed for. She is also in a situation with you that grief is not designed for — a situation that has no established script. She is trying to do both at once and she does not have the tools for either one right now.' She paused. 'That is not a permanent condition. People acquire tools.'

It was not a satisfying answer. It was the truest one she had, and she thought Yarova understood this, and she thought Yarova needed it more

than she needed comfort.

* * *

She visited Tetyanenko that afternoon — a property dispute complicated by his elder son's increasingly creative interpretations of their pre-upload agreement. Tetyanenko had been in perpetuity for just over two years and had in those two years become, in Olena's professional assessment, a more formidable version of what he had already been. She had found this trajectory in several of her long-term clients: perpetuity concentrating rather than diluting, the essential person becoming more essentially themselves in the absence of the biological noise that had always accompanied them.

He was dressed, as always, in the dark blue jacket. It was beginning to feel to Olena less like a glitch and more like a choice — as if he had decided, at some point in the past two years, that this was what he wore, full stop, and the consistency of it was a form of statement. She had never raised it again after the first conversation. She understood something now that she had not understood then: that the uploaded were making their own sense of their existence, developing their own practices and preferences for a situation that had no precedent, and that what looked like a glitch from the outside might be, from the inside, a decision.

'My son's lawyer is very good,' Tetyanenko said, with what sounded like genuine appreciation. He had the quality, she had noticed across their meetings, of being able to appreciate things that were working against him. It was a kind of equanimity that seemed to develop in perpetuity — time enough to understand that an adversary doing their job well was not a personal affront.

'Your son's lawyer is adequate,' Olena said. 'The argument he's making has three structural weaknesses. I've addressed them in the response.'

She walked him through it. He listened with complete attention — the quality of attention she had observed in the uploaded, the attention of a person who did not have anywhere else to be because the concept of having somewhere else to be had changed fundamentally. He was always here. He was always available. He could give the conversation exactly what it required without the ambient background of other demands.

She found it, on some days, restful. On others it made her aware, in a way she found uncomfortable, of how partial most of her own attention was even in the most important conversations — the layers of other things running simultaneously, the professional mind always processing, the mother mind always running checks. She was rarely entirely here. She suspected most people were rarely entirely here. The uploaded were entirely here, always, and she was not certain whether this was enviable or whether it was a kind of loss she did not yet have the vocabulary for.

At the end of the meeting he said, as he sometimes did: 'How are your children?'

'Well. Krystyna is walking now. Maksym has opinions about everything.'

'That's the age,' he said. He said it with the warmth of someone who remembered the age clearly — who remembered all the ages clearly, who had been told he would forget and had not, whose relationship to time had changed in every way except the loss of what had already been. He knew exactly what that age was like. He would know it forever.

She thought about this, gathering her notes. She thought about what it meant to have a parent who would never not-know. Who would never forget. Who would always have been there, perfectly remembering, available to confirm or correct or elaborate on anything that had ever happened. She thought about what that would be like for his children, now in their forties — to have access, indefinitely, to a father who remembered everything. Whether it was a comfort or a pressure or whether it was so unlike anything they had experienced as children that it had no relationship at

all to what parenthood was supposed to feel like.

She gathered her notes. She said goodbye. She walked out of the interaction suite into the corridor and took a breath and put it all in the folder.

* * *

Home that evening: Krystyna, fourteen months, had developed what Andriy called conducting. She stood at the edge of the coffee table when he played, holding on with one hand, and moved the other through the air in a way that was entirely her own — not imitating his hands but doing something parallel, something that suggested she understood the sound was being made by a person and that a person doing a thing could be responded to. There was an intentionality to it that went beyond reflex. She was not reacting to the music. She was participating in it, in the only way she currently had available.

Maksym found this objectionable.

'She's not conducting. She doesn't know what conducting is.'

'She's doing what conducting does,' Andriy said. 'That's near enough.'

'It's not the same.'

'Most things aren't the same as their names. That doesn't make them less real.'

Maksym considered this, decided it was unsatisfying, and went back to his drawing. Krystyna continued. Andriy played the bear song because she seemed to respond to it more than to anything else — something in the bass register she found compelling, something that moved through the room in a way her body registered. He had been noticing, over the past weeks, that she had different responses to different music. Not preferences exactly — she was too young for preferences — but tendencies. The lower the register, the more her whole body engaged. The higher and

lighter, the more her face became attentive and still, inward-focused. He was storing this information without knowing exactly why, the way you stored things about a person you were learning.

Olena sat on the couch with the Yarova file and watched her family. She thought about Yarova's hands. She thought about what Yarova's daughter in London would give to be in this room right now — the ordinary room, the unremarkable Tuesday evening, the family going about itself without drama or significance. The ordinary life before it became the extraordinary loss.

She thought: I have this. I have this exactly.

She thought: it is not guaranteed. Nothing was guaranteed. This was something she knew professionally and personally and had always known, but which she knew differently since the upload practice began — since she had spent two years sitting across from people who had decided the non-guarantee was intolerable and had done something about it. She understood their reasoning. She also understood that she was sitting on the couch watching her daughter conduct and her husband play and her son draw, and that the understanding the clients had purchased — the guaranteed continuation — was not the same thing as this. Was related to this. Was not this.

She put the file away. She went and sat on the floor beside Krystyna, who immediately grabbed her finger with both hands and said something that was not yet a word but had the structure of one. The insistence of one.

'I know,' Olena said. 'I know.'

Krystyna's face was entirely serious, as it always was when she was communicating. She did not yet have the vocabulary but she had the intent, and the intent was clear: I am saying something. You are required to receive it. Olena received it.

* * *

The conversation about Bohdan happened in October, at dinner, arriving through the side door of an ordinary evening the way the difficult conversations always arrived — not announced, not prepared for, sliding in under the cover of the ordinary and establishing themselves before anyone could decide whether to let them in.

Maksym had been at school with Bohdan since the beginning of the year. Bohdan was a pleasant child of unremarkable distinction except that his father was scheduled to upload in the spring, which Bohdan had communicated to his classmates with the specific pride of a child who has recently learned that his family has something other families don't. He had been communicating it for several weeks. The information had worked its way through the class in the way information worked through a class, acquiring elaborations and misunderstandings as it passed from child to child, until it arrived at Maksym, who had processed it in his characteristically thorough way and was now ready to raise it at dinner.

'Bohdan says his father will never die,' Maksym said, with the directness of a child who has not yet learned to approach things sideways. 'He says he'll always have a father. He says it's not fair that other people's fathers will die and his won't.'

Andriy said: 'Maksym.'

The word was quiet. It had a floor in it that Maksym recognised — not anger, but something underneath anger, a depth that communicated: we are not going to go further in this direction tonight. It was the tone Andriy used when a subject required a different conversation than the one currently available, when the timing was wrong or the circumstances required something more considered than a dinner-table exchange could provide. Maksym understood this. He had encountered the floor before.

'Eat your dinner,' Andriy said.

Maksym ate. Krystyna, in her high chair, was eating with both hands and the systematic focus of someone who considers food a serious project. She had recently discovered that food could be organised by colour and was currently arranging her vegetables in a pattern that appeared to have an internal logic. Neither Olena nor Andriy looked at each other.

Later, after the children were in bed, Andriy stood at the piano without playing. Olena was at the kitchen table with a glass of wine and the Yarova response she needed to finish and the specific tiredness of a day that had contained Yarova and Tetyanenko and the drive home and dinner and the children and was now requiring one more hour of work before it could be set down. She was capable of the hour. She had been capable of more than a single hour on worse days. She opened the document.

'He's going to keep asking,' Andriy said.

'I know.'

'What do we tell him?'

She looked up from the document. 'The truth. We can't afford it. Most people can't. That's the world.'

'And that's sufficient? That's simply the world, so—'

'Andriy.'

He turned from the piano. He was not angry — he was something more considered than angry, the expression of a man who has been thinking about something for a long time and who has arrived, tonight, at the decision to say part of it.

'You spend your days making it available for people like Bohdan's father,' he said. 'You write the contracts. You sit across from them and you make it possible. And then you come home to this.' He stopped. 'I'm not accusing you of anything. I know why you do it. I know what it provides. I'm asking whether you ever think about the distance between those two rooms.'

She thought about Yarova's hands. She thought about the daughter in London who had been given accurate information that did not answer the

question she had actually asked. She thought about Tetyanenko saying that's the age with the warmth of someone who would know that age forever. She thought about the specific quality of Krystyna arranging her vegetables by colour and what it would mean to have that memory not as a memory, not as something that faded and compressed and changed shape over the years, but as a permanent record, perfectly fidelitous, the scene available always at the same resolution it had been when it happened.

She thought about all of this and thought: and still. And still.

'I think about it,' she said.

'And?'

'And I go back to work in the morning. Because that's what I know how to do. And because the alternative—'

She did not finish the sentence. She was not certain what the alternative was. She was not certain she wanted to be certain. The alternative was some version of not doing this work, and not doing this work was some version of the practice not existing, and the practice not existing was some version of these matters being handled by people who thought about them less carefully than she did. She was not certain this reasoning was entirely sound. She was certain she was going back to work in the morning.

Andriy looked at her for a long time. He had, she knew, more to say. He had the capacity for it — the patience and the precision to take this argument somewhere more uncomfortable than where it currently was. He chose not to. This was one of the things about him she most valued: he understood when to leave a door open rather than to walk through it.

He sat at the piano and played — not the Ravel, something else, something in a minor key that moved through the apartment like weather moving through a room, touching everything without changing anything. She returned to the Yarova response. The apartment held them, separately and together, the way it always held them.

They talked about it that night. I know they did because I have the memory of lying in my room listening to their voices — too low to make out words, but the shape of a serious conversation, the particular rhythm of two people working something out. I did not know what they were working out. I was fourteen months old and the voices were simply the sound the apartment made when they were both in it, which was the sound of everything being all right.

Breathe

Andriy — 2034

The lesson had been going badly for twenty minutes before Maksym found it.

He was eight now — old enough to be self-conscious about mistakes, young enough not to have developed the patience that self-consciousness required. He had been playing the folk melody for three weeks, long enough to be past basic hesitation, and yet he kept catching at the third phrase as if surprised by it, even though he had played it dozens of times and the phrase did not change. It was not a technical problem. Andriy had identified that early: the hand position was correct, the fingering was right, the tempo was reasonable. The problem was in Maksym's relationship to the phrase, not in his execution of it.

'Stop,' Andriy said. 'What happens before the third phrase?'

Maksym played the second phrase.

'And after it?'

He played the fourth.

'So you know the third phrase is coming. You've played it correctly fourteen times this session. Why do you keep catching at it?'

Maksym looked at his hands. 'I don't know.'

'Yes you do.'

A long pause. Andriy waited. He had learned, over eleven years of teaching, that the pause was often the lesson — not the filler before the lesson but the lesson itself, the space in which the student had to sit with not-knowing and find, at the bottom of the not-knowing, the thing they actually understood. The students who could do this — who could wait in

the silence without filling it with wrong answers or self-defence — were the ones who became good players. Not the ones with the best technique, not the ones with the best ears. The ones who could be with not-knowing.

Maksym had this capacity, when he was not too afraid of failing. He had it now.

'I'm listening to myself play it,' Maksym said finally. 'While I'm playing it. And then I make a mistake because I'm listening instead of playing.'

'Yes,' Andriy said.

'So how do I stop listening?'

'You don't stop listening. You listen differently. There's a part of you that monitors what you're doing and a part of you that does it. When you play well, the doing part is in front. When you play badly, the monitoring part has taken over. The monitoring part doesn't trust the doing part.' Andriy played the phrase — cleanly, without hesitation. 'The doing part learned this weeks ago. It knows the phrase. You have to let it play.'

Maksym tried again. The hesitation was still there, slightly.

'Breathe first,' Andriy said. 'Before the phrase. Give yourself a breath. Tell the monitoring part: I know what I'm doing. And then play it.'

Maksym breathed. Played. The phrase came out clean — not perfect, but uninterrupted. The doing part briefly in front.

'There,' Andriy said. 'That.'

Maksym played it again. Again. Building the path, wearing a groove in it, teaching the doing part that the monitoring part was not needed here.

He thought, watching Maksym work, about what this lesson was actually about. The lesson was about music, technically. But the thing it was teaching — the difference between doing and monitoring, the necessity of trusting the doing part, the way self-consciousness interrupted performance — was not only about music. It was about most things. He had learned it first at the piano and had spent the rest of his life finding

it everywhere else. He hoped Maksym would too. He hoped the piano was giving him something that would turn out to be about more than the piano.

After another ten minutes Maksym had the phrase reliably. Not beautifully — beauty would take longer, beauty always took longer — but without catching. The monitoring part had been reassured sufficiently that it was no longer interrupting.

'Good,' Andriy said. 'From the beginning, now.'

Maksym played from the beginning. The melody came through clearly, the third phrase landing where it should, the whole thing beginning to have the quality of something that belonged to him rather than something he was working on.

'Better,' Andriy said.

'I know,' Maksym said. Not proudly — simply accurately. He had the quality of someone who trusted his own assessments, which Andriy found both admirable and occasionally taxing.

* * *

On the floor nearby, KRYSTYNA, two, sat with her toy keyboard — eight plastic keys in primary colours, a birthday gift from Olena's mother that had already been through considerable use. She pressed the keys one at a time with the flat of her finger, listening to each note before pressing the next, with the methodical attention she brought to most things.

She had been doing this for weeks. Not playing songs — playing notes, exploring the instrument in the way a child explores any object: systematically, with complete seriousness, learning what it was before deciding what to do with it. She was not interested in making music yet. She was interested in understanding what the thing was. Andriy found this approach both recognisable and touching. It was how his father had

said you should approach any instrument: learn what it is before you decide what to do with it. Krystyna had arrived at this independently, at two.

He watched her between phrases of Maksym's lesson. She pressed a note. Listened. Pressed the next. She had been on the same sequence of four notes for several minutes, going back and forth between them, as if she were testing a hypothesis.

'Krystyno,' he said. 'Come here.'

She came, carrying the toy keyboard, which he had not anticipated.

He lifted her onto the piano bench beside him. She was very small on it — her legs stuck straight out, not reaching the floor. She set the toy keyboard on her lap with great care and looked at the piano keyboard with the assessing expression she had for things that required assessment.

'These are the same,' he said. He played four notes on the piano: C, D, E, F. Then played them on her keyboard. She watched with complete attention, her head slightly to one side.

'They sound different,' she said.

'Different instrument. Same notes.'

She considered this — the concept of notes that were the same across different instruments, that were notes before they were sounds, that existed in some form prior to the particular material that expressed them. He watched her consider it. Two years old.

She played C, D, E, F on her keyboard. Then on the piano, stretching to reach, her small hand spanning the distance.

'Same,' she said, satisfied.

'Same,' he agreed.

Maksym, from across the room: 'She can't play.'

'She's learning what playing is,' Andriy said. 'That comes before playing.'

'How long does it take?'

'Different for everyone. For you, about six months before you were

playing anything I'd call a song. For her—' He looked at Krystyna, back to pressing single notes with absolute concentration. 'Hard to say. She has her own pace.'

'What if she's better than me?'

The question arrived with the directness Maksym always brought to things he cared about — stripped of protective indirection, offered as a genuine question about the world rather than a complaint about it. He was asking because he wanted to know, not because he was afraid of the answer.

'Then she's better than you,' Andriy said. 'And you'll still be you, and she'll still be her, and music is large enough for both of you. Music is not a competition. The people who treat it like a competition usually end up playing worse, because competition makes you monitor instead of do.'

Maksym processed this. 'Is that a lesson about the third phrase?'

'It might be,' Andriy said.

'Play the bear song.'

Andriy played the bear song. Krystyna moved her hands above the toy keyboard in the way she had — not conducting exactly, not playing exactly, but doing something that was both and neither, a two-year-old's engagement with the fact of music. Maksym sat on the floor and listened with his eyes half closed.

It was an adequate afternoon. More than adequate.

* * *

The faculty dinner was in November, at the conservatory director's apartment near Khreshchatyk. Twelve of them around a long table, the usual mixture of performers and administrators, the usual careful texture of institutional social life — the way people who worked together and re-

spected each other and occasionally disagreed about resources or scheduling managed to be comfortable without being entirely relaxed. Andriy liked these dinners. The conversations were better than they had any right to be.

The conversation moved, as it always moved these days, to Neural-Mind. The company had announced a new service: the ability to archive the complete neural record of a living person and hold it in storage indefinitely, a kind of insurance policy against death. You did not upload. You did not become a digital entity. You simply ensured that if you died, the option remained open — the record was there, the decision could be made retroactively by designated family members on your behalf.

'It's essentially a policy that says your family can decide to resurrect you,' said the director, who was seventy and had the authority of someone who had said uncomfortable things for long enough that they no longer felt the need to soften them.

'Or can decide not to,' said someone else. 'It only moves the decision.'

'The question is whether a decision made by your family, about your consciousness, after your death, constitutes consent,' Petro Savenko said. He had been to the interaction suite that morning and had the Monday-morning quality about him — the hollowed patience, the specific stillness of someone who had been in the company of something he did not entirely know how to be in the company of and had returned to ordinary life without having resolved it. 'The person who is dead cannot consent. The family is making a decision about someone who cannot have a position on it anymore.'

'They could have a position in advance,' Andriy said. 'They could leave instructions.'

'Instructions given before death are not consent to the specific decision at the specific time. They're preferences expressed under conditions that no longer apply. I might prefer, at fifty, to be archived and potentially

uploaded if I die young. I might feel differently at eighty. I might feel differently on the day. The archive makes a kind of assumption about continuity of preference that I'm not certain holds.'

'Consent to not-die seems like it should be at least as coherent as consent to die,' Andriy said.

'Consent to not-die given by someone who is already dead seems like it should be less coherent,' Petro said, with a precision that ended that branch of the conversation.

The table moved on to other things. Andriy sat with his wine and thought about Petro's argument, which was better than he had initially given it credit for. The problem was not with the archive. The problem was with any claim to know what someone would want in a situation they had never encountered, on behalf of a self that no longer existed. The self that existed now — the uploaded self, if the archive were used — had been created from the record of the pre-death self. Whether it would endorse the decision made on its behalf was a question that could not be asked in advance because the self that might answer it did not exist yet. And by the time it existed, it was too late to ask.

He thought about this on the drive home. The city going past the windows, November and cold, the bridges over the Dnipro lit from below in the way that made Kyiv look, from certain angles, like a city that had decided it might as well be beautiful. He thought about whether he wanted to be archived. He thought about it clearly: no. Not from fear of what the upload would find, not from philosophical conviction, but from something more like aesthetic preference — a sense that the ending of a thing was part of the thing, and that removing the ending would change the shape of everything that came before it, including the parts that had already happened.

He thought about Krystyna and Maksym. He thought about this differently: no. He did not want a world in which the decision about whether his children continued was something that could be made by a product.

This was not a fully formed argument. It was a position. It was where he stood.

He got home after eleven. Olena was awake, reading, the lamp on her side of the bed the only light.

'It's a product,' she said, when he told her about the archive discussion. 'Like any product.'

'That's not what I asked.'

She looked up. 'I know.' A pause. 'I think it's probably the service that gets the most people into the ecosystem who would otherwise have been reluctant. The archive makes you feel like you're keeping options open rather than making a commitment. Most people find options preferable to commitments, even when the options lead to the same place.'

'Still not what I asked.'

'I know,' she said again. She turned off her lamp. 'I don't know what I think about it. That's an honest answer.'

It was. He turned off his lamp. Through the wall, Krystyna breathing — the steady, committed breathing of a sleeping child, utterly without complication, the pure sound of a small person going about the serious work of being alive.

He thought about the archive service. He thought about the bear song and the breath before the phrase. He thought about how entirely and simply he did not want a world in which whether his children continued was something that could be resolved by a product.

He thought this and knew it was not a complete answer.

He slept.

* * *

In the spring of 2034, Krystyna learned her first song.

It took six weeks of irregular effort — she came to the piano when she

wanted to, which was not every day, and worked at it without visible frustration at mistakes and without the performing-progress quality Maksym had brought to his early lessons. She was not trying to show him how she was getting on. She was simply getting on. There was a quality to the way she approached the learning that was difficult to name: not patient exactly, because patience implied the suppression of impatience, and she did not seem impatient. More like thorough. She was being thorough about acquiring a song.

The song was a simple Ukrainian lullaby Andriy had played for her when she was very small — had played for both children, the same lullaby, a melody that had been in his family for at least three generations and that he did not know the origin of, only that it was the song you played when someone needed to sleep. He had played it in the evenings, in the dark, standing by the bassinet. He had played it so many times that Krystyna had grown up with it as one of the sounds the world made, unremarkable and ordinary, the way the trams were unremarkable and the sounds of the street were unremarkable, simply part of the air.

She had chosen it herself. Heard him play it one morning and said: teach me that one, with the specific finality of someone who has been considering the available options for some time and has made a decision. He had not asked why. He had begun teaching her.

He taught her one phrase at a time, over six weeks. She pressed each key with the flat of her finger, her hand not yet shaped to the keys the way a trained hand was shaped to them — not holding the piano keyboard but meeting it on its own terms, learning its specific topography. The melody emerged slowly, unevenly, the way all melodies emerged in the beginning: more structure than music, more outline than substance, but unmistakably itself.

The morning she played it through without stopping, Maksym was at school. Olena was at work. It was just the two of them in the apartment, the spring light through the kitchen window making everything look par-

ticular and attentive.

She played it from beginning to end with complete concentration and then looked at him.

'I did it,' she said.

'You did it.'

'Again?'

'Again.'

She played it again. And again. Each time a little more her own — the phrasing beginning to develop, the slight variations that came from a person rather than a mechanism, the music becoming the music as distinct from the notes. He sat beside her and listened and thought about his father, about the draughty apartment in Lviv, about the argument his father had made his whole life about the highest form of music being the ordinary form. He thought: this is it. This is the thing. This small person, in this apartment, playing the lullaby for the fourth time through with growing confidence — this is what music is for.

She looked up after the fourth repetition. 'What's the next one?'

He played a bar of something — a simple folk dance, more rhythmic, a different kind of challenge.

'That one,' she said.

He began to teach her.

The lullaby. I can hear it perfectly — every note, every hesitation, the phrase I kept getting wrong in the fourth bar, the morning I finally got it right. I played it four times. Papa sat beside me and didn't say much. He didn't need to. I knew what it meant. You know, with him, because of the quality of his listening. When he is listening like that — the quality of it, the complete absence of anything else — you know you've done something real. I have that morning. I will always have it.

The Last Normal Morning

Olena — February 2035

She remembered, afterward, that she had been reading a contract clause about force majeure.

Not the NeuralMind contracts — a more ordinary matter, a commercial lease dispute that had arrived on her desk two weeks earlier and that she had been working through with the methodical patience she brought to work she found uninteresting but necessary. The clause in question was about force majeure: unforeseeable circumstances that prevent someone from fulfilling a contract. Acts of God, in the older language. Events outside the reasonable scope of planning, beyond what a reasonable party could have anticipated or provided against.

She had been thinking about whether the clause as drafted was sufficiently specific — whether unforeseeable was doing the right kind of work, whether the list of examples that followed it was comprehensive enough, whether the landlord's interpretation was defensible or whether the tenant had the better argument — when the phone rang.

She let it go to the third ring, finishing the sentence she was reading, because she was always finishing sentences before answering. This was a habit her assistant DARIA had adapted to in her first month, and her previous assistant before her, and most people in her professional life had adapted to it simply by learning to expect it. It did not matter, most of the time, those extra two rings.

She picked up.

* * *

The morning had been ordinary in every detail she could later reconstruct. She had gone through it many times in the weeks and months afterward, sometimes deliberately and sometimes not, her mind returning to it the way you returned to a place you kept misremembering, trying to get it right, trying to hold the true version.

Andriy had made porridge — a Tuesday food, by Maksym's classification, which had developed at some point in the previous year and had since acquired the authority of law. Porridge on Tuesdays. Maksym had strong opinions about the organisation of the week, about which foods belonged to which days, about which routes to school were acceptable and which were not, about the proper placement of his belongings in the apartment, about many things. Andriy honoured these opinions without always agreeing with them, which was one of the ways their relationship worked.

Krystyna had eaten her porridge with systematic focus and then wanted down from her chair to investigate the pigeons on the outside sill, who were being particularly active that morning and who held, for her, the status of minor celebrities — familiar, beloved, always worth attending to. Andriy had lifted her down and she had gone directly to the window with the focused purposefulness of a three-year-old attending to something important.

Maksym had been in his school uniform with his backpack already on, which was early — he was usually still doing something that needed doing when it was time to leave. He had complained about his hat. Andriy had insisted. There had been a brief negotiation, conducted at the level of seven-year-old persistence versus paternal firmness, which had resolved in the hat's favour. Maksym had retrieved it and put it on with the expression of someone who has been profoundly wronged but is choosing to be gracious about it.

'Drive carefully,' she had said to Andriy, without looking up from the brief she had opened over breakfast. She said it most mornings, auto-

matically, the way you said things that had become reflex — not because she was worried specifically, because there was nothing specific to worry about that morning, nothing different from any other morning, no reason to say it more urgently than usual. But because it was the kind of thing you said to the people you loved as they went into the world. A small ritual of acknowledgment. An unspoken contract between the morning and the rest of the day.

'Always,' he had said.

She had heard it register in the usual way. She had been reading the brief.

The door had closed. Krystyna had toddled back from the window with information about the pigeons — there were four of them today, which was more than usual, and one of them was grey in a way that was different from the usual grey. Olena had listened with appropriate attention, noting the details, asking the follow-up questions that the situation warranted. She had finished her coffee. She had put on her coat. She had kissed Krystyna on top of her head, which still smelled of the specific shampoo they used and would smell of it until it didn't anymore, which would be some day in the future that was impossible to anticipate.

She had gone to work. She had opened the force majeure clause.

Unforeseeable circumstances.

* * *

She did not remember the drive to the hospital. She knew she had taken a taxi — she found, two weeks later, the charge on her bank statement, a timestamp and a distance and an amount, the administrative record of a journey she had no conscious memory of making. She had no memory of getting into the taxi or of what she had said to the driver or of whether she had been looking out the window or at her phone. She remembered:

her office, the phone, a voice, and then the corridor.

The corridor on the third floor of Kyiv Central, which smelled of antiseptic and something faintly floral from a cleaning product she would never be able to identify but would thereafter recognise instantly, for the rest of her life, in any building where it was used. She noticed this with the strange precision that shock sometimes brought — the way details became vivid and fixed while the larger picture remained inaccessible. Antiseptic. Something floral. Fluorescent lights overhead, slightly blue, the particular blue-white of institutional lighting.

She turned the corner.

Andriy was sitting in a plastic chair with his head in his hands. His left forearm had a bandage on it — white, clean, recently applied, suggesting something minor had been attended to, a cut or a bruise, something that the emergency department had addressed and recorded. He was otherwise, as far as she could see from across the corridor, unhurt. Essentially unhurt. Not requiring the chair he was in for any physical reason.

She stopped.

The thing about being a lawyer, the thing about having spent fifteen years learning to read situations before you had all the information — to understand what a room was telling you before anyone spoke, to identify what was present by reading what was absent — was that it was a skill that worked in all directions. She had been very good at this for a long time, and she was very good at it now, standing in the corridor, reading the position of his body and the bandage on his arm and the absence of Maksym anywhere in her field of vision.

She knew before she reached him. She had known from the phone call, probably — had known in the part of herself that received information before she was ready to receive it, the part that processed things in the body before the mind caught up. She had known it and had not known she knew it and had moved through the taxi ride in the space between knowing and understanding.

She crossed the corridor. She sat in the chair beside him. The chair was hard and slightly too low and had the quality of hospital furniture everywhere: designed for durability rather than comfort, for the long hours of waiting that were the main thing hospitals required of the people in them.

He looked up. His face.

She took his hand.

She did not ask what had happened. She already knew. The asking could come later — the facts assembled, the sequence established, the inquest completed, the full account of the morning set out in whatever form was required. None of that was necessary right now. Right now there was only this: his hand in hers, the fluorescent light, the smell of antiseptic and something floral, the corridor that had divided itself into before and after and that she would never walk down again without knowing exactly which corridor it was.

They sat. Around them the hospital went about its business. She was aware of it peripherally — the sounds of it, the movement of people in the corridor, the specific ongoing business of a place where emergencies arrived and were addressed and were followed by other emergencies. She was aware of it and it did not touch her. She was in the chair beside Andriy, holding his hand, in the corridor that would always be before and after, and that was all there was.

* * *

The weeks that followed had the quality, she thought later, of a very long administrative task. There were things that needed to be done and she did them. Forms. Calls. Arrangements. The specific bureaucracy of death, which was extensive and unsparing and which demanded, as it had always demanded, that grief be set aside long enough to sign things and

confirm things and respond to people whose kindness was genuine and whose presence was nonetheless exhausting because kindness required a response, and she was not certain she had enough response available.

She was good at this. She had always been good at the management of difficult things — at the capacity to hold something large at a functional distance while continuing to operate. She understood that this was not the same as being all right, and that it was not the same as being strong, and that it was a form of deferral that would eventually require settlement. The later was coming. She was aware of the later. She was not ready for the later.

Andriy did not speak much. She did not try to make him. He had gone somewhere she could not follow — not away from her but into himself, into the geography of something she could not map because it was his and not hers, shaped by things she had not been part of: the specific quality of that particular morning, the things that had been said in the car, the last ordinary minutes before the intersection. She gave him room. She understood, without either of them having to say it, that they were each doing what they could do, and that what they could do was different, and that different did not mean wrong.

She did not go to the piano. He had closed the lid on the day they came home from the hospital and had not opened it since. The Ravel was still on the stand — she had looked at it once and then not again. She did not close the Ravel either. Some instinct about not disturbing things that had been placed, about not making the decision that disturbing them would imply.

Krystyna did not understand. She was three. She understood that something had changed — children that age understood change in the household before they understood it as fact — and she moved through the apartment with a quality of increased attentiveness, checking in more frequently, coming to sit with each of them in the way that children sat with people they sensed needed sitting-with. She did not ask about Maksym.

She had been told what to understand. She was three and she had accepted what she could accept and filed the rest.

One evening, two weeks in, after Krystyna was asleep and the apartment was quiet, Olena sat at her desk and opened her laptop. She sat for a moment looking at the screen. Then she opened a browser window. She typed: posthumous upload minor Ukraine law feasibility.

She read for two hours. She read carefully, the way she always read legal and technical material: not for comfort but for content, not looking for the answer she wanted but for the actual answer, whatever it was. She read the technical literature on neural record integrity for posthumous scans, which explained clearly and at length that fidelity degraded rapidly after biological death, that the scan that could produce a model of sufficient integrity needed to be initiated within hours of death rather than days, that the technology existed in theory for posthumous reconstruction but did not exist in practice for cases where the scan had not been initiated prior to death. She read this and understood it and read it again.

She closed the laptop.

She sat in the dark for a long time. She was not thinking exactly — the thinking part of her had finished and had arrived somewhere, and what she was doing in the dark was simply being at the place where the thinking had arrived. She had been a lawyer for fifteen years. She had spent two years building a practice around a technology that could do the thing she was reading about. She had built it for other people and she had not been able to use it for this, and the not-being-able-to-use-it was complete and final and there was nothing to be done about it.

She got up. She checked on Krystyna, who was sleeping with the absolute commitment of a three-year-old — one arm thrown out, Vovk the rabbit tucked under the other, the breathing steady and deep and entirely unremarkable, the breathing of someone with nothing to account for, nothing held in suspension.

Olena stood in the doorway for a long time.

Then she went to bed.

The smell of that corridor. Antiseptic and something floral underneath. I have been remembering it for longer than I lived. I have been trying to understand what it means that I remember it at all — that the corridor my mother walked down on that afternoon is inside me, encoded with perfect fidelity, part of what I am. I think it means she carried it with her. I think it means I have everything she carried. The grief and the knowledge and the two hours of reading and the dark she sat in afterward. I have all of it. I carry it the way she carried it. That is what she gave me.

Tuesday

Andriy — 2035–2037

He did not remember the impact.

He remembered the light — the February light at that intersection, pale and slightly sideways, the kind that made you squint in the mornings even when the sky was overcast. He remembered the particular quality of that light, the angle of it, the way it came over the rooftops to the east and hit the windscreen in a way that required the visor. He remembered Maksym asking about the dog. He remembered almost smiling.

He remembered the light turning green.

Then the sound.

Then nothing, for a period he could not subsequently measure, until he was aware of the steering wheel under his hands and a noise that was the car's horn, which he was not pressing but which was sounding anyway, and the stillness. The specific quality of the stillness. The absence of the sounds that had been there a moment before — the traffic, the radio he had turned down but not off, Maksym's voice — all of it simply gone, replaced by the horn and the stillness and the slow return of the world.

He did not look to his right for a long time. He knew. In the way that the body sometimes knows things before the mind is ready, he knew, and his body held him very still and did not let him look because it understood that looking would make it real in a way that not-looking was not yet ready to complete.

When he looked, the seat was empty.

The door was open. He had not heard the door open. The seatbelt was released, dangling. Someone had opened the door and released the

seatbelt and removed what had been there, and he had not heard or noticed or been present for any of it. The door was open and the seat was empty and the horn was still sounding.

Someone was at the window beside him. A voice: are you all right, are you hurt, can you hear me. His left arm hurt. He could not identify, in the geometry of what had happened, how his left arm had been hurt — the impact had come from the right, the truck had come from the right, the physics of it did not obviously account for his left arm. It seemed, in the context of everything else, very unimportant.

He said something. He did not know what.

The rest arrived piece by piece, over hours and days and months and years, in the way that certain things arrive — not all at once, not in the order they occurred, but incrementally, each piece finding its way through when the capacity to receive it existed. He would be driving three years later and the particular angle of morning light would return him, without warning, to the intersection. He would be teaching a student and hear a specific quality of silence and understand it as the silence of the car in the seconds after. He would be nowhere in particular and receive a piece of it, and he would let it arrive, and he would sit with it, and he would continue.

* * *

The first month was the worst in a specific way. He was present in his body — he went to places, he said things, he responded to people who required responding to — but the presence had a thin quality, as if he were standing just behind himself, watching from a short distance. He was aware of doing things without being fully in the doing. He was aware of the gap between where he appeared to be and where he actually was, and he could not close it, and he understood that closing it was not something

that could be made to happen.

Olena managed things. She had gone into a mode he had seen her use before — in professional crises, in the kind of client situation that required her to hold a great deal together at once — a mode of focused management in which the personal was set at a functional distance and the tasks were addressed in order. He understood what she was doing and was grateful for it in a way he could not express, because expression required energy that was not available. He watched her manage and thought: she is keeping this family standing while I cannot. He was grateful for this with the gratitude of someone who is being kept alive.

Krystyna was three. She did not understand. She understood something — children that age registered change in the household before they had the vocabulary for it, understood it in their bodies before they understood it conceptually — and her response to the something she could not name was to increase her proximity to both of them, to climb onto him whenever he sat anywhere accessible, to press her face against his neck with the particular quality of a child seeking reassurance that something fundamental had not changed. He held her. He was capable of holding her. It was one of the few things that required less of him than it gave back.

He did not go near the piano. This was not a decision he made — he did not think: I will not go near the piano. He simply did not go near it. The piano had always been where he put things. It was the place where the residue of his experience found a form — where the difficult days and the good days and the ordinary days went when they needed to go somewhere. He understood, without examining it directly, that if he went near the piano now he would have to put this in it. He would have to find the form. He was not ready to find the form. He was not certain the form existed yet. Some things were too large for the form to arrive quickly. He thought: this is one of those things.

The Ravel was still on the stand. Olena had not touched it. He had

noticed this — had noticed it the first evening home and had been grateful for it in the same inarticulate way he was grateful for most things she did without being asked. She understood that the Ravel on the stand was not a piece of music anymore. It was a marker. It was where the piano had been stopped and where it would resume when resuming was possible.

He did not know when that would be.

* * *

One morning — he thought it was March, six weeks in, though the calendar had become unreliable in the way that time became unreliable when the things that structured it had changed — Krystyna climbed onto the piano bench. He was in the kitchen. He heard the bench creak under her weight, the specific sound of it — lighter than the sound it made under him, but the same bench, the same creak — and then, after a moment, a single note.

It rang out in the apartment and then faded.

He stood very still at the kitchen counter with his hands on the edge of it. The note — he could identify it even through the wall — was C. The C above middle C. Clean, complete, ringing in the space of the apartment and then letting go. No particular significance. A three-year-old pressing a key.

He left the kitchen. He walked to the bedroom door and stopped. He sat on the edge of the bed.

He heard her press another key. D. Then back to C. Then D again, longer. She was exploring in the way she always explored things — methodically, without hurry, learning the object before deciding what to do with it. She did not know what she had started. She did not know that the note had gone through him like something physical, that the sound of the piano in the apartment had opened something that had been closed for six

weeks, that C above middle C had been more than C above middle C.

He sat on the edge of the bed for a long time. From the living room, intermittently: C and D and E, Krystyna conducting her research into the nature of the instrument.

He thought about Maksym. He thought about the Tuesday morning. He thought about the February light and the dog that Maksym had been about to ask for, and the no that had been forming in his mouth, and the fraction of a second between the almost-smile and the sound.

He had been about to say no. This was the thing he carried. The no in his mouth that had not been said, the ordinary refusal of an ordinary request, the last word he had not spoken. He had thought about this many times in the six weeks and would think about it many more times in the years to come. He had never been able to decide what it meant — whether it meant anything at all, whether the specific content of the last unsaid word was significant or whether it was simply the arbitrary accident of timing, the irrelevant detail that happened to be present at the moment everything changed. He could not decide. He carried it anyway.

He sat on the bed. He breathed. He thought: I should go back in there and sit with her. He thought this and did not move.

After a while the notes stopped. He heard the small thump of Krystyna climbing down from the bench. He heard her feet on the floor going toward the window where the pigeons were. He sat for another minute. Then he got up. He went back to the kitchen. He made lunch.

* * *

He returned to teaching in April. Not performing — he had a concert scheduled in March that he cancelled without rescheduling, and he felt no urgency about rescheduling it, felt in fact a distinct absence of urgency about performing that he understood might be temporary or might be per-

manent. Teaching was different. Teaching required him to be present for someone else's process rather than his own, to attend to what they needed rather than what he had, and the attending was something he could do. The structure of a lesson was something he could hold onto. The student's problem was a problem with a shape, and shapes were manageable.

He went back in April. Petro was kind in the way that people who understood loss were kind — not effusive, not insistent about being seen to be kind, simply present in the ways that were useful and absent in the ways that were necessary. He brought coffee to Andriy's studio on Monday mornings without comment. He played his violin in the adjacent practice room at times when he knew Andriy was working, so that Andriy could hear it through the wall — not for any explicit reason, simply as a form of presence, one musician working in proximity to another as they had worked for eleven years. Andriy understood it as the form of care it was. He accepted it.

He did not talk about it at work. This was not repression exactly — or not only repression — but also the understanding that the work was not the right container for this. The work required him to be present for other people's music. The grief required him to be present for himself. The two were not incompatible but they needed to happen in different rooms, and the conservatory was not the room where the grief belonged. That room was wherever Olena was. Whatever they were building together in the apartment, in the evenings, in the silences they were learning to share, in the particular quality of being married to someone who was also inside the same enormous change and was managing it in a different way — that was the room.

She had gone back to work immediately. He had not understood this at first, had felt something at the edge of resentment that he had not expressed because he understood it was not accurate — not resentment of her specifically but of the fact that going back was possible, that the work was waiting, that the world continued to have requirements. Then he had

watched her over the weeks and understood: the work was not what she was doing instead of grieving. The work was the form her grieving was taking. It was how she remained upright. It was the container she had available, and she was using it, and that was her right. His container was different. Neither of them had chosen their containers. You used what you had.

He went back to teaching. He came home. He did not play.

* * *

In September — seven months after the Tuesday, the apartment shifting into the quality of late-summer light he associated with returning to teaching after the break, a quality that now also carried this, that carried everything subsequent — he lifted the piano lid.

He had not planned to. He had been passing the piano, which he did many times a day in an apartment that required passing the piano to get from one room to another, and his hand had been at the right height, and he had lifted the lid. A reflex rather than a decision. The keys were exactly as they had always been: eighty-eight of them, black and white, the specific worn quality of keys that had been played for years, the slight polish of the most-used ones and the comparative freshness of the high notes he reached infrequently.

He sat down. He looked at the keys.

He had been looking at them, in the passing sense, for seven months — walking past them, not playing them, aware of them always as the thing not being used. Looking at them now from the bench, with the intention of doing something rather than the intention of passing, was different. The keys looked different from here. They always had.

He played one note. Middle C. Pressed it gently, let it sound, let it fade. Listened to the whole arc of it — the attack, the sustain, the decay,

the silence at the end. He played the note beside it. D. Let it arc. He played them together. The interval, the two notes in relation, the specific quality of that specific interval in that specific apartment at that specific time of the evening.

He sat with it. Then he closed the lid.

He did this for three weeks. Sitting at the piano, playing one or two or three notes, sitting with whatever arrived, closing the lid. Not attempting phrases or songs. Not attempting the Ravel, which was still on the stand, which would not be attempted until he knew the form for it had arrived. He was learning the instrument again, the way you learned something you had been away from — not starting from the beginning exactly, but re-establishing the relationship, reminding yourself and the instrument of what you were to each other.

The night he first played a complete phrase — four bars of something unidentifiable, his hands moving to it without being asked, something emerging from the accumulated weeks of single notes and intervals — Olena was in the kitchen. He heard her stop moving. The particular quality of the sounds of her evening — water running, the small sounds of the apartment's activity — paused.

He played the phrase again. Then stopped.

She appeared in the doorway. She did not say anything and he did not turn to look at her. She leaned against the frame and was present, simply present, not studying him or waiting for anything, just in the room with the music that had finally come back.

He played the phrase a third time. Then a fourth with a small variation, the phrase beginning to understand itself, becoming something rather than just notes. Then something adjacent to it, the music opening from the phrase outward.

'Don't stop,' she said. Very quietly.

He did not stop.

He played for half an hour. He was rusty in ways he would not have

been if he had played through the summer, and the rustiness was fine — it was honest, it was where he was, and playing from where you were was what the instrument required and what music required and what he had always believed and was now doing. He missed notes. He did not care about the missed notes. He was doing the thing that was most essentially his, not for performance or demonstration but simply as the act it was: the making of music in the room where he lived, with his daughter asleep in the other room and his wife in the doorway and the Ravel still on the stand waiting for the right night.

When he stopped she was still there.

He turned to look at her. She looked back. The expression she had — the fully present one, without the professional layer, without the management — was the expression she had when something had moved her that she was not going to say was moving her. He held it in his mind the way he held notes that mattered.

He closed the lid gently. The way you closed something you intended to open again.

* * *

By 2037 they had found the shape of a different life. Not the old life with something removed — he had feared it would be that, had feared that everything would be defined by what was missing, that the apartment would always feel like a place something had left. It was not that. It was a different thing, built differently, organised around a different centre. The absence of Maksym was not a hole. It was a presence of its own kind — the presence of someone who had been here and whose having been here had shaped things, including Krystyna, including the apartment, including both of them.

Krystyna was five in 2037, and she was herself in a way that aston-

ished him on a regular basis. She had the specificity that some children had and others didn't — the quality of being entirely and completely the person she was, with opinions that arrived fully formed and without apology, with preferences that were non-negotiable and immediately apparent, with a relationship to the piano that was her own rather than inherited. She came to it when she wanted to. She played the lullaby she had learned and the folk dance that was still in progress, the key change still catching her occasionally, and she played things she made up — combinations of notes that were not songs but were not random either, things that had their own internal logic, their own sense of going somewhere.

He watched her play sometimes, from across the room, with the quality of attention he had developed as a teacher and that he now used for his own children — the attention that was listening rather than evaluating, receiving rather than judging. He thought: she has her own relationship with this. Not mine. Not a copy of mine or a tribute to mine. Hers, built from having lived in a house where music was the atmosphere.

She asked about Maksym one morning in the spring, over breakfast. She said it simply, without build-up, the question of a child who had decided the time for the question had arrived: who is Maksym?

She had been looking at the photograph on the refrigerator. The school photo, the gap-toothed smile, the boy who had been in the apartment long before she was old enough to understand what being in the apartment meant.

'Your brother,' he said.

'Where is he?'

'He died. Before you were old enough to remember.'

'Oh.' She looked at her bowl. She processed this — he could see her processing it, the specific quality of her face when she was taking something in. Then: 'Does he know about me?'

He looked at his daughter. The question had a specific quality he recognised immediately: not grief, not fear. Curiosity of a particular kind

— the need to know that she had been real to someone who could no longer be asked. He understood the need. He had the same one.

'Yes,' he said. 'He knew about you.' It was true. Maksym had known about Krystyna. He had been told about her, had watched the preparations, had stood in the hospital doorway with his inventory expression. He had claimed her with a finger-grip. He had known.

'Good,' she said. And went back to her porridge with the completeness of a child for whom the answer has been sufficient.

He stood at the stove for a moment afterward, spatula in hand. He thought about what she had needed from the exchange — the confirmation that she had been witnessed by someone who was no longer here to witness her. He had given it. It was enough. It was what he had needed too, and still needed, and would always need: the knowledge that Maksym had been real. Not preserved. Not continued. Real, completely real, in the only way anything was real, which was in the time it had.

He turned back to the stove. He made breakfast. The photograph looked out from the refrigerator with the gap-toothed smile, the boy who had known about his sister, who would always have known, in the tense that did not change.

The Number

Olena — Spring 2038

The appointment had been on a Thursday in April, but the knowing had started in January.

Not a specific moment — a gradual accumulation of small things that each had an ordinary explanation and that together, over weeks, had stopped feeling ordinary. Krystyna tired in the afternoons in a way she had not been tired before. Not the productive tiredness of a child who had done a great deal — the specific tiredness that came with having done nothing in particular, that seemed to come from inside rather than from expenditure. Olena had noted it and had attributed it to the winter, to the short days, to the particular drain of being six and in school and navigating the social and intellectual demands of being Krystyna in a classroom. She had monitored it without alarming herself.

In February the lymph nodes appeared. The left side of her neck, slightly swollen, which Krystyna had reported matter-of-factly one morning as something that felt funny when she pressed it. Their GP had assessed it as a likely infection, prescribed a course of antibiotics, and said to come back if it hadn't resolved in three weeks.

It had not resolved.

The GP had referred them to a specialist. The specialist had ordered imaging. The imaging had led to a biopsy. The biopsy had led to the appointment on a Thursday in April, which Olena had been managing her way toward for two months — managing in the sense of keeping the fear at functional distance, doing the next thing that needed doing, not looking directly at what she was afraid of because looking directly at it

before she had information would not be useful and she was a person who operated on information.

She had the information now.

DR. IRYNA HRYTSENKO had the office of someone who had thought carefully about how rooms should receive bad news. The walls were a warm grey, not clinical white. The chairs on the patient side were upholstered in a fabric that was neither cheerful nor funereal, a thoughtful middle ground. There was a window with a view of trees rather than of the hospital's service entrance — birch trees, Olena noted, just coming into leaf, pale and new. There was a box of tissues on the corner of the desk, positioned with the specific discretion of something meant to be available without being conspicuous. A plant on the windowsill that was alive and carefully tended. A framed photograph of what appeared to be mountains, turned so that both doctor and patient could see it, offering something neutral and large to look at when looking at each other became too much.

Olena had noticed all of this in the first thirty seconds. She noticed things quickly, and she had learned, over years of professional life, to let noticing be a form of management — something to do with the mind while the mind was receiving information it was not yet ready to process. She noticed the birch trees. She noticed that Dr. Hrytsenko's desk was clear except for a single folder. She noticed that the doctor had placed her hands flat on the desk in a way that communicated: I am going to be here for this. I am not going anywhere.

She noticed that Andriy, beside her, was very still in the way he was still when something was happening that he needed to receive completely — the stillness of a musician in the moment before the piece begins, when everything is possible and nothing has been committed to yet.

'The biopsy results confirm what we saw on the imaging,' Dr. Hrytsenko said. Her voice was measured, precise, carrying the quality of someone who had delivered a great many results of this kind and had not

become inured to it but had developed, over years of practice, a specific gravity around the work. 'It is lymphoma. Hodgkin's, stage two. Which is to say: serious, but treatable. We caught it early enough that our standard protocol has very good outcomes for children her age. I want to say that directly, before we go into the details: the outcomes are good. We are not in a position where treatment is unlikely to work.'

Andriy exhaled. Just slightly. Olena did not.

'What is the treatment?' he said.

'ABVD chemotherapy. That's a combination of four drugs — adriamycin, bleomycin, vinblastine, and dacarbazine. We administer it in cycles, typically every two weeks. Four cycles to start, possibly six depending on response. We will scan after the second cycle to see how the tumour is responding and adjust from there.' Dr. Hrytsenko paused. 'Most children Krystyna's age respond well to the first protocol. The hair loss will be significant — I want to tell you that directly because children often find this the most distressing visible side effect, and it helps to have discussed it in advance. It grows back. The fatigue will be real. There will be good days and difficult days. But many children her age complete treatment and go into full remission within eight to ten months.'

'And if she doesn't respond?' Andriy said.

'We have second-line options. An escalated protocol called BEA-COPP, which is more aggressive and harder on the system in the short term but produces higher response rates in cases where the first protocol doesn't achieve full remission. We also have the option of stem cell transplant if escalation is insufficient. But I want to be clear: we are not at that stage. The first protocol is the right starting point and I have every reason to expect it to work.'

'What are the survival statistics for non-response?' Olena said.

Dr. Hrytsenko looked at her. Olena had seen this look before — she had been on the giving end of it herself, in consultation rooms, when a client asked a question that exposed how much they already understood

about their situation. The look of a professional recognising another professional across the desk.

'Mrs. Kovalenko—'

'I want the number.'

A pause. The kind in which a doctor assessed what kind of person she was dealing with and made a decision about what that person needed, which was not softening but accuracy.

'For refractory Hodgkin's in children Krystyna's age,' Dr. Hrytsenko said carefully, 'roughly thirty percent five-year survival without escalation to transplant.'

The room was very quiet.

'And with transplant?'

'Sixty to seventy. But I want to repeat: we are not there. The first protocol may work completely and in the majority of cases it does. We are talking about contingencies.'

'I understand,' Olena said. 'Thank you.'

She said it cleanly, without hostility. A full stop. She had the number. She would work with the number. She would hold the number at arm's length until she needed it and then she would look at it directly and decide what it meant. This was what she did with numbers she did not want. She kept them accurately and used them when necessary and did not pretend they were different from what they were.

She continued asking practical questions — the treatment schedule, the hospital visits, the monitoring protocol, what to watch for at home that would indicate a problem requiring urgent attention. Dr. Hrytsenko answered all of them with the directness she had shown throughout. Andriy asked about pain management. He asked about school attendance, whether partial attendance was possible during treatment. He asked, quietly, at the end, whether it was all right to keep playing the piano. The doctor said yes, on the good days, absolutely yes.

Through the glass of the office wall, she could see Krystyna in the

waiting room with a nurse — a young woman who had given her a colouring book and was now sitting beside her, watching her colour with the comfortable attention of someone who had learned to be present with children in these situations. Krystyna was wearing the yellow sweater she had chosen herself that morning with the seriousness of someone making an important decision, bending over the colouring book, her tongue between her teeth in the way she had when concentrating, completely absorbed in making the fish in the picture the right shade of blue.

She had no idea what was being said in the room she could not see. She was colouring a fish.

Olena held this image for a moment — the yellow sweater, the fish, the complete absorption, the utter ordinariness of a six-year-old going about a six-year-old's business on the other side of a pane of glass from the conversation that was restructuring everything — and then she turned back to the doctor and asked about the treatment schedule.

* * *

She did not cry until she was in the bathroom on the ground floor, alone, with the tap running.

She allowed herself three minutes. She had learned, over the years, that three minutes was approximately the right amount of time — enough to release the pressure to a manageable level, not so much that re-entry became impossible. She had used this allocation before. In a hotel bathroom in Warsaw after a case went badly. In the hospital bathroom the night after the phone call about Maksym. In the small bathroom off her office on an afternoon when something had arrived that she had not been ready for. Three minutes. The tap running to cover the sound, the cold water ready for her face at the end of it. She was very practised at this, at the managed release of the things she had been holding too long and too

tightly, and she found no comfort in the competence. She would have preferred to be incompetent at it. She would have preferred to be the kind of person who did not need to manage this way, who could simply be in the grief without architecture. But she was who she was and the architecture was what she had.

She let herself feel it. She did not narrate it or manage it or try to shape it into something useful — she simply felt it, the way the number had landed in her body and stayed there, the thirty percent without escalation to transplant, the sixty to seventy with it, the mathematics of her daughter's survival expressed as percentages in a warm grey room with birch trees in the window.

She felt it for three minutes. Then she turned off the tap. She washed her face with cold water. She looked at herself in the mirror — not studying herself, not checking how she appeared, simply marking the moment, the before and after of it, the person she was before she knew the number and the person she was now — and then she went back out to where Andriy was waiting with Krystyna in the lobby.

Krystyna looked up from the colouring book, which she had apparently been allowed to take. 'Are we going home?'

'We're going home,' Olena said. 'And we're going to tell you some things on the way.'

Krystyna put down the book with the careful deliberateness of someone who understood that what was coming required full attention. She had always been like this — available to difficult things, present rather than deflecting. Olena had noticed it throughout her life and had been grateful for it and had sometimes, in the privacy of her own mind, been worried by it: a child should not have to be that available to difficult things. It suggested experience with difficult things, a prior knowledge of them, a small person who had learned early that the world contained things you could not look away from and had decided to look at them anyway.

'Okay,' Krystyna said. She tucked Vovk under her arm — she had brought Vovk to the appointment, which Olena had not questioned, understanding implicitly that Vovk was required today and that his presence was not a regression but a resource — and took her father's hand, and they went home.

* * *

They told her in the taxi. Olena had decided this during the three minutes in the bathroom — that they would tell her on the way rather than at home, because home was the safe place and she did not want to make home the place where this news lived, did not want Krystyna to walk through the front door that evening and feel the conversation waiting in the apartment like a change in air pressure. Better to tell her in transit, in a cab moving through the city, so that by the time they arrived the news was already behind them and home was still home.

She told her simply. She said: we went to the doctor because of the test results, and the test results showed something called lymphoma, which is a kind of sickness that happens in the blood. She said: it is serious, but the doctors are good at treating it, and they are going to give you medicine that will make it better. She said: the medicine is called chemotherapy, and it will make you feel bad before it makes you feel better, and your hair will probably fall out for a while, and Papa and I will be with you every day.

She said these things without euphemism and without terror — in the tone she used for difficult information that needed to be received accurately, not the tone she used in professional consultations, but something closer to it than the falsely bright reassurance she had heard other parents use with sick children and had always found dishonest. Krystyna deserved the real information. She was six years old and she deserved to

know what was happening to her.

Krystyna listened to all of this without interrupting. She was looking out the window at Kyiv going past — the streets she knew, the buildings, the ordinary city that was still ordinary despite everything — and her expression was the one she had when she was listening seriously, the expression that meant she was taking it in rather than responding to it.

When Olena finished, Krystyna was quiet for a moment.

'Is it going to hurt?' she said.

'Some days,' Olena said. 'Some days it will feel like a very bad flu. Some days will be better. We'll take it one day at a time.'

'Will I have to go to the hospital a lot?'

'Yes. For the treatments. But most nights you'll be home.'

Another pause. Kyiv went past. A tram. A woman with a dog. A child on a bicycle with a red helmet, going somewhere with the urgency of a child who has somewhere to be.

'Will I still be able to play the piano?' Krystyna said.

Olena felt something move through her. Of course. Of course that was the question. Not the fear questions, not the death questions, not the questions that Olena had been prepared for — the question of the piano. The thing that mattered to her. The thing she had worked at for two years and that was hers in the way that things you work at become yours.

'Yes,' Andriy said. His voice was steady in the way it was steady when it was costing him something. 'On the days you feel well enough. And on the days you don't, the piano will be there when you're ready.'

Krystyna nodded. She looked back out the window.

'Okay,' she said.

And that, for the time being, was that.

That night, after Krystyna was asleep — they had fed her, and she had asked several more questions at dinner with the systematic thoroughness she brought to most things, working through her list methodically: will I lose all my hair or just some, will the medicine make me sick right away or after a while, can I still go to school, will the other children know. Andriy had answered them carefully, one by one, with the patience and honesty she deserved. Olena had sat beside him and added what was needed and had thought: this is what he is. This is the man I married. Present in the difficult thing, not managing it away from her but into it with her.

After Krystyna said she was tired and they had put her to bed and the apartment was quiet, Olena opened her laptop.

She had bookmarked the NeuralMind pricing document three years ago, the night she had searched for posthumous upload options and found the window already closed. She had not opened the bookmark since. She opened it now.

The document was updated quarterly. The pricing for full adult upload was what it had always been — the number that her clients found, depending on their resources, either slightly uncomfortable or entirely reasonable, and that most of the world found simply impossible. She knew the number precisely. She had negotiated variants of it dozens of times. She looked at it now and thought about it in a different way than she ever had before, from the inside of the situation rather than the professional distance of someone managing someone else's situation.

The section for minors contained a legal notice: upload of persons under the age of eighteen is not offered or facilitated by NeuralMind Inc. in any jurisdiction, in compliance with the Hague Digital Persons Convention on the Protection of Minors and Vulnerable Persons (2032) and applicable domestic law.

She read the notice. She read the citation. She opened a new tab and found the convention text. She read the relevant articles — slowly, the way she read documents that mattered, holding each clause in her mind

and testing it against the others, looking for the architecture underneath the language. She was not looking for loopholes. She was looking for what the text actually said, which was a different thing.

She read the exceptions.

There was one exception. It was narrow. It required: imminent biological death, defined as a terminal prognosis of twelve weeks or fewer; demonstrated clear cognitive consent from the subject; prior judicial approval from a court of competent jurisdiction in the subject's country of domicile; and the specific written approval of NeuralMind's ethics board.

She read it twice. Then she opened a new document and began to make notes.

The exception was designed for adults. Every word of it assumed an adult subject — clear cognitive consent was a legal standard rooted in adult cognitive capacity, judicial approval was a process calibrated to adult competency assessments, the ethics board approval criteria referenced adult autonomy throughout. The convention had been written by people who were thinking about terminal adults who had the right to determine the disposition of their own consciousness.

They had not been thinking about a six-year-old girl in a yellow sweater colouring a fish.

And yet.

The text said persons. Not adults. The word adults did not appear in Article 7(c). The drafting history suggested it was intended to apply to adults, but the text did not say so, and the text was what was legally operative. She had made this argument before — in different contexts, on different clauses, for different clients. The text says what it says. The drafting history is evidence of intent but it is not the law.

She made notes for two hours. Then she made a separate document and began to sketch a structure — not a plan, not yet, something earlier than a plan. The shape of a thing that might become a plan. She worked slowly, precisely, the way she worked when she was building something

that had no precedent and needed to be right.

She did not know, that night, whether she was building toward something or simply building — the way you sometimes needed to build to find out whether there was anywhere to go. But she built anyway, because building was what she did, and because the alternative to building was the thirty percent sitting in her body like a stone.

She was at her desk when I went to sleep and when I woke up she was still there. I know this because I have the memory of getting up in the night for water and seeing the light under her door. I didn't go in. I understood, without being able to say how, that she was working on something important and that going in would interrupt it. I went back to bed. I lay there for a while listening to the apartment — Papa's breathing in the bedroom, the particular silence of the city at three in the morning, the sound of her turning pages. Somewhere in what I am now, I am still lying there, in that bed, in that dark, listening to my mother work.

Remission

Andriy — 2038

He had thought, on the night of the diagnosis, that he understood grief. He had been through Maksym. He knew what the first month was like, what the return to teaching was like, what the long slow process of reconstruction looked like from the inside. He had a map of it — imperfect, personal, shaped by a specific loss, but a map nonetheless. He thought: I know how to do this. I know the shape of it. I know where the worst of it is and I know that you come through the worst of it and arrive somewhere different.

He was wrong about what this was. This was not the same thing.

The death of a child was a closed door. Terrible, permanent, a thing you could not open and had to learn to live beside. You learned to walk past the door without looking at it every time. You learned, eventually, to open it occasionally, to stand in the frame and remember, and then to close it again. The door stayed. The door was always there. But you learned the house it was in, and the house became livable.

A sick child was a door that was still open. A door through which you could see light that might extinguish at any moment, and the might was the thing — the might, the not-knowing, the conditional tense of everything. She might respond to treatment. She might not. She might achieve full remission. She might relapse. The might-not was the most painful thing he had ever been required to hold, more painful than the closed door, because the closed door at least had the mercy of being finished. The open door had no such mercy. It required him to live in the subjunctive indefinitely: what might happen, what might be done, what

might be saved.

He was better at closed doors than open ones. He had not known this about himself before.

He had known, in the abstract, that hope was a more difficult state than grief. He had believed this philosophically — had thought about it in the context of music, the way the unresolved chord was harder to live in than the resolved one, even when the resolution was minor. Now he knew it from the inside. Hope was the worst thing, because hope had a floor you kept falling through. Grief had a floor too but you found it and you stayed there until you could stand up. Hope's floor kept moving.

He played for Krystyna as much as he could. Not lessons — the treatment made sustained effort difficult, and lessons required effort — but presence. The piano on in the evenings, music in the apartment the way it had always been music in the apartment. He thought: this is the one thing I can control. This, at least, is continuous.

* * *

The first chemotherapy session was on a Thursday in October. He took the day off from the conservatory — something he almost never did, he had taught through illness and grief and the ordinary emergencies of life, but this he would not be absent for — and he brought cards. Not because Krystyna had asked for them but because he needed something to do with his hands and because Krystyna liked cards and because the institution of a card game created a structure external to the situation, rules and turns and the comfortable architecture of something that had nothing to do with oncology.

He arrived at the hospital early and sat in the waiting area on the third floor and looked at the ward. He had been to hospitals in various capacities over the years — for Maksym, for his own minor matters, for elderly

relatives, for the professional adjacency to end-of-life decisions that upload law had introduced into Olena's life and by extension his. He knew what hospitals felt like. This ward felt different. It had been designed to feel different. The murals on the walls — animals, forests, a long river — were not patronising, were not the bright-primary-colour decor of an institution that had given up trying and defaulted to cheerful. They were careful. Someone had spent time on them. The nurses had the quality he had identified at other thresholds in his life: the quality of people who had chosen this work specifically, not arrived at it by accident, who understood what they were doing and had made peace with the difficulty of it in a way that left room for warmth.

He was grateful for them. He did not know how to express this. He noted it.

Krystyna arrived with Olena at nine, carrying Vovk and wearing her favourite red trainers — a concession Olena had agreed to because the red trainers made her feel like herself, and feeling like herself was going to matter today. She looked at the treatment room with her characteristic inventory expression: assessing, cataloguing, deciding what the situation was and how she stood in relation to it.

'Which chair is mine?' she said.

The nurse indicated the reclining chair nearest the window. Krystyna went to it and sat in it and looked at the IV pole beside it with the same assessing expression. He could see her making the decision, the specific quality of her face when she had decided something.

'I'm going to put stickers on it,' she said.

'I'll get you some,' the nurse said. She said it simply, as if this were entirely expected, which Andriy suspected it was.

Krystyna produced her own stickers from her coat pocket. She had been building the collection for months — animals and stars, mostly, acquired from various sources with the focused acquisitiveness of someone who had a project in mind. She had brought the best ones. He could see

her selecting, deciding which stickers this pole deserved. She applied them with the deliberateness of someone personalising a space she intended to occupy for some time. When she was done she looked at it with satisfaction.

'It's mine now,' she said.

'Technically it's the hospital's,' Andriy said.

'I've stickered it. That makes it mine.'

The nurse produced two additional star stickers from her pocket and offered them without comment. Krystyna accepted them and applied them to the top of the pole where the bag would hang. The nurse looked at Andriy over Krystyna's head with an expression that was small and precise and meant: she's going to be all right in here. He received this.

They played Durak for two hours while the medication dripped. Krystyna beat him four times with the focused efficiency of someone who had decided this was the game she was going to win today, full stop. She organised her hand with the precision of a small general, considered her options with the patience that characterised her approach to most things, and played with the specific pleasure of someone who understood the game well enough to be strategic about it. He let her win the first three times and then on the fourth she outplayed him genuinely and gave him a look of such deep satisfaction that he felt something that was not quite the opposite of grief but was adjacent to it — some sharp and wordless thing that had no name.

The fifth time he won, she looked at him with deep suspicion.

'You let me win the other times.'

'I played my best every game.'

'Papa. I'm seven, not three.'

He had had to look away for a moment. The window. The hospital courtyard below — a tree that had gone yellow for autumn and was losing its leaves one at a time in the wind, unhurried, the leaves going without drama. He looked at the tree until he could look back.

'Deal again,' he said.

She dealt with great seriousness.

Olena sat in the corner with her phone — work, always work, the cases that did not pause for oncology appointments — but she was not truly working. Andriy could see, from across the room, that she was watching Krystyna the way she watched her sometimes when she thought no one was looking: with the full force of her attention, unguarded, the professional composure set aside. He thought: she is memorising her. She has been doing it since the diagnosis, in the evenings, when Krystyna wasn't looking. He understood this because he was doing the same thing — storing every detail with the urgency of someone who has been told, not in words but in percentages, that storage matters.

* * *

The Monday mornings at the conservatory were different now. Not dramatically — he continued to teach, the students continued to have the problems they had always had, the faculty continued to be the same collection of people with their characteristic preoccupations. But he was different inside the sameness. He was there differently.

Petro had understood this without being told. Petro brought the Monday morning coffee, as always, and said less than he usually said, and when Andriy did not want to talk Petro did not require him to talk and when Andriy needed to say something Petro listened with the quality of attention that Andriy associated with good musicians — present, not filling the space. He had told Petro about the diagnosis the week after it happened. Petro had said: I'm sorry. And then: what can I do. And Andriy had said: just this, and indicated the coffee, and Petro had nodded. And this was what they continued to do.

The students, he found, were easier than he had expected. The teach-

ing required him to be present in a specific way — attentive to what they were doing, focused on their problems rather than his, for fifty minutes at a time operating in the world of their music rather than the world of his apartment. He had been afraid that this would feel dishonest, that teaching about technique and phrasing and interpretation while Krystyna was in a hospital chair with stickers on the IV pole would feel like a betrayal of context, a pretending that the world was its normal size. It did not feel that way. It felt necessary. The normality of the conservatory was not a pretence. It was another kind of truth — the truth of the world that continued around his family's situation, the truth that continued was the condition of everything else.

He came home each day and the apartment received him. Krystyna on the good days was at the piano or at the window watching the pigeons or explaining something with the focused intensity she brought to explanation. Krystyna on the bad days was on the couch with Vovk and the tablet and the specific inwardness of someone managing her own resources carefully. He had learned to read the days quickly — the quality of her face told him within a minute what kind of day it was going to be, and he adjusted accordingly.

* * *

The first cycle ended in November. They went back to Dr. Hrytsenko for the results and sat in the warm grey office with the birch trees outside — bare now, the leaves all down, the branches thin and grey against the sky — and heard the words partial response and tried to understand what they meant.

Partial was not the word they had hoped for. Partial was not no, which was the worst word, the word that meant the door was closing faster than they had thought. But partial was not yes, either. Partial was the subunc-

tive again: the tumour had reduced. The tumour had not resolved. They were still in the night.

'What does partial mean, exactly?' Andriy said.

'The primary mass has reduced by approximately forty percent,' Dr. Hrytsenko said. 'That's a meaningful reduction and it tells us the cancer is responding to the treatment. The cells are dying. But we need a more complete response — ideally full resolution of the mass, or something close to it — before we can consider the treatment successful. A forty percent reduction after the first cycle is not unusual. It doesn't necessarily mean the first protocol is insufficient. We complete the full course before drawing conclusions.'

'How many more cycles?'

'Two more, then we scan again. Four cycles total. If the response continues at this rate, we may achieve full resolution by the end of the course. If not, we discuss escalation.'

Andriy nodded. He was choosing optimism deliberately — not denying the partial, not pretending the night was something better than it was, but choosing to hold the forty percent as evidence that the treatment was working, that the cancer was retreating, that they were moving in the right direction. The optimism was a decision rather than a feeling, and it required maintenance, but it was better than the alternative.

Olena said: 'Begin the donor search.'

Dr. Hrytsenko looked at her.

'In case we need the transplant option,' Olena said. 'Begin the donor search now, in parallel with the remaining cycles. We don't wait to see if we need it. We begin it now so that if we need it, the time is already spent.'

'That's somewhat early in the process—'

'It costs nothing to begin it and it costs us weeks to delay it. Begin it now.'

Dr. Hrytsenko made a note. She began it.

On the drive home he thought about the donor search. He thought about what it meant that she had asked for it — what she was building in the background, the documents she closed when he entered the room. He had been telling himself he was giving her space. He knew, more honestly, that he was afraid of what she was building, and that the building of it would mean they had crossed into a territory he was not yet ready to enter, and that he needed more time on this side of it.

More card games. More of Krystyna looking at him with deep suspicion and saying Papa, I'm seven, not three.

He needed more of that.

* * *

He played for Krystyna at home when she was well enough to sit at the piano, which was not always. Some days the tiredness from treatment sat on her like something physical — a weight she could not shift, that made the stairs difficult and the piano bench too far away. He had learned to read the days by morning: the quality of her face at breakfast, the speed at which she ate, whether she asked about the piano or whether she sat quietly with Vovk and the tablet and the particular inward expression of someone conserving resources.

On the good days she came to the piano and worked on the folk dance — the same folk dance she had been learning for two years, the key change still catching her sometimes, still arriving in the middle of the phrase with the quality of a surprise she hadn't consented to. She would stop, back up, approach it again. She was patient with it in a way she had not always been patient with things. He had noticed this shift in the months since the diagnosis: a new quality of patience in her, a willingness to be wrong as many times as necessary without distress. He thought: she has learned something from being sick. He did not know if

this was a comfort or a sadness. It was both.

He watched her work on the key change and thought: she has been learning this for two years. The cancer arrived while she was learning this. The cancer will be gone and she will still be learning this, and then she will have it, and then she will learn the next one.

He said this to himself the way some people said prayers — not believing it as a fact, but holding it as a direction. Something to move toward.

On the difficult days, he brought the toy keyboard to wherever she was and played simple things on the piano across the room and let her do what she wanted with the keyboard — no lessons, no expectations, the music simply present in the room. He thought: this, at least, is continuous. Whatever else changes about our life right now, this continues.

* * *

In December, after the third cycle, the news was partial response again. The mass had reduced further — sixty percent from the original size, Dr. Hrytsenko said — but still it had not resolved.

'We escalate,' Olena said, before Dr. Hrytsenko could frame the recommendation.

'Yes,' the doctor said. 'BEACOPP. Two escalated cycles. More intensive, harder on her system. We would expect a stronger response.'

'And the donor search?'

'Still running. No match identified yet. The international registry takes time. We'll continue in parallel.'

In the taxi home, Krystyna sat between them and looked out the window with the expression she had lately — not sad, not frightened, something more complex and more settled than either, the expression of someone who had been inside a difficult thing long enough to have found their

footing in it. She had been sick for three months. She had lost her hair, which had happened gradually and then all at once, and she had looked at herself in the mirror with the same inventory expression she brought to everything and had said: I look like an egg. And then she had gone back to whatever she had been doing.

She did not ask about the conversation in the doctor's office. She understood, from the quality of the silence in the taxi, that there had been a development, and she had learned, over three months, that developments were processed by her parents in a particular way — carefully, methodically, in conversation with each other, and then explained to her when they had understood it themselves. She trusted this process. She waited.

Andriy took Olena's hand across the back of Krystyna's head. Olena held it.

'Shall we get dinner?' Krystyna said. 'The good soup place.'

'Yes,' Andriy said.

They got the good soup. They sat in the restaurant they had been going to since Krystyna was a baby, the one with the worn wooden tables and the smell of bread and the waiter who always remembered what they ordered. Krystyna ate her soup with both hands around the bowl, warming them, and talked about something that had happened in her school cohort — she was attending on the good days, with adjustments, and had strong opinions about the social dynamics of her class, which she expressed with the thoroughness of someone who had been paying close attention. Andriy listened. Olena listened. The restaurant held them in the way it had always held them — the specific warmth of a place you had been going to for years, that knew you without knowing you, that provided the ordinary texture of a life that was still, despite everything, a life.

This was what the good days felt like: ordinary. Not a reprieve from the illness, not a temporary suspension of it, but the illness and the ordinariness existing simultaneously in the same afternoon, in the same

wooden-tabled restaurant, in the same bowl of soup. He had not known this was possible — that a family could be inside something this difficult and still have ordinary evenings, still argue gently about whether the soup needed more salt, still sit across from each other in the familiar way. The ordinariness was not a denial of the difficulty. The difficulty was not a denial of the ordinariness. They were both real.

He thought: these are the days I will return to. Whatever comes after, I will return to the soup place and the wooden tables and her hands around the bowl.

The escalation. I remember the word — not from the appointment, I wasn't in the room, but from overhearing it later, the way it moved through the apartment in the weeks after. It had the quality of a word that had changed meaning. It meant one thing before December and something heavier afterward. I remember also the soup place, the waiter who knew our order, the way the bowl felt warm in my hands. I have both of these things with equal fidelity. The escalation and the soup. The word that frightened me and the warmth I pressed my palms against. They are both equally mine, equally real, equally present.

Kravchenko

Olena — 2039

The escalated protocol did not produce a full response.

Dr. Hrytsenko told them in February, with the specific gravity she had when the news required it, that the residual mass had not resolved. It had reduced further — eighty percent from the original, which in any other context would be extraordinary progress — but not resolved. Not gone. Still there. Still requiring a response.

Olena had not been surprised. She had not been surprised in the sense that she had spent three months building a structure that assumed this outcome, had done all the work that the work required precisely because she had understood that the protocols might not be sufficient. She had been prepared. She had been building toward this moment with the deliberate preparation of someone who understood that hope was not a strategy.

And yet, sitting in the warm grey office with the bare birch trees through the window and Dr. Hrytsenko's hands flat on the desk in the position that meant bad news, she found that being prepared and receiving were different things. You could prepare the mind and the mind would accept the preparation and the body would still receive the news in the body's own way, which was not the way of preparation but the way of feeling.

She sat very straight. Sitting straight was what she had.

'The stem cell transplant is now the recommended path,' Dr. Hrytsenko said. 'We have not found a donor match yet, but the search will continue. It's important to know that many patients wait several months for a match and ultimately find one — the absence of a match now doesn't

mean there won't be one.'

'What's the timeline?' Olena said.

'For the transplant itself, once we have a donor, four to six weeks of preparation. The transplant requires a significant hospital stay — three to four weeks minimum. The recovery period afterward is measured in months rather than weeks. It is the most demanding part of the treatment process. But it is also, for refractory cases like Krystyna's, the path with the best long-term outcomes.'

'And without a match?'

Dr. Hrytsenko was quiet for a moment. 'We have options,' she said. 'Haploidentical transplant — using a half-matched donor, which is typically a parent — is possible and the outcomes have improved significantly in recent years. It carries higher risks than a fully matched donor, but it is a real option.'

'What are the risks?'

'Graft versus host disease is the primary concern. The donor's immune cells can attack the recipient's tissue. In haploidentical transplants, this is more common than in fully matched ones. It can range from mild to severe.' A pause. 'I want to be honest with you: this is the part of the treatment pathway where the uncertainty increases. The first protocol, the escalation — those are well-mapped. The transplant, particularly without a full match, is more individual. More variable.'

Olena nodded once. She was sitting very straight. She had been sitting very straight since Dr. Hrytsenko said the residual mass had not resolved, and she would continue to sit straight for the remainder of the appointment and for the drive home and for the evening that followed, because sitting straight was what she had instead of the other things she needed.

She asked several more questions. She asked about the haploidentical outcomes data, specifically for children Krystyna's age and weight and disease profile. She asked about the preparation protocol and what it

would require of Krystyna's body. She asked about the timeline for the donor search and what the escalation pathways were if no match was found in the next three months. Dr. Hrytsenko answered all of them precisely and without evasion, which Olena had come to expect from her and was grateful for.

Andriy was looking at the birch trees. They were bare again. They had been bare the first time they sat in this room and they were bare now, and she thought: we have been inside this for a full year. A full year, and the birch trees have been bare twice. She had sat in this chair in the spring when they were just coming into leaf, pale and new, and she had held the number — thirty percent, sixty to seventy — and she had thought: I will build something. She had built it. And here she was, in February, with the bare trees and the residual mass and the building still not complete.

* * *

She drove home from the hospital alone — Andriy had taken Krystyna on ahead, a gentle fiction they had developed for the appointments that required it: he would take Krystyna, who had begun to understand that her parents' conversations with doctors contained information about her that was processed separately before being given to her, and Olena would follow. It gave her forty minutes. She had learned to use forty minutes well.

She did not drive directly home. She drove for twenty minutes through February Kyiv — the city grey and cold, the light low, the streets going about the ordinary business of a mid-February afternoon without any awareness of or interest in what had just been said in a doctor's office on the third floor of a hospital on Lypska Street. The city's indifference was, she found, useful. The city did not require anything of her. She drove through it and let it be indifferent.

She pulled up outside the apartment building and sat in the car for eleven minutes. She knew this because she looked at the clock when she stopped and looked at it again when she got out. Eleven minutes. The engine ticking as it cooled. The street going past. A woman walking a dog who had no idea. A teenager on a phone who had no idea. The city going about its business who had no idea.

In eleven minutes she sorted through what she was carrying and divided it into two categories: what needed to be felt now and what needed to be felt later. She was not suppressing the second category — she was not pretending it wasn't there or wouldn't arrive. She was scheduling it. She was a person who had learned, over the course of her life, that you could not feel everything at once, and that the things in the second category did not become less true for being deferred, and that the deferral was a form of management rather than a form of denial. She was good at management.

She felt what she felt in the eleven minutes. Then she got out of the car. She went upstairs. She made dinner, because dinner needed to be made and she was the person who was going to make it.

Three days later, she walked into NeuralMind's Kyiv office at nine in the morning and asked to see Kravchenko.

The receptionist — a young man named DMYTRO, who had been at the front desk for three years and who knew her by name and by the specific cadence of her visits — looked up with the slight uncertainty of someone whose mental model of a situation has just shifted without warning. She did not have an appointment. She had never arrived without an appointment.

'Ms. Kovalenko. Your client isn't—'

'I'm not here for a client,' she said. 'Tell him I'm here.'

She sat in the lobby and waited. The lobby was the same as it had always been: glass and steel and the particular quality of corporate calm designed to communicate the quiet confidence of an institution that had

solved a problem most institutions had not yet acknowledged. She had been coming here for ten years. She knew every surface of this lobby. She had sat in these chairs with clients before appointments and after them, had stood by the lift waiting, had exchanged professional pleasantries with the security staff and the receptionist and the various members of the NeuralMind team she had accumulated as professional relationships across a decade. She had always come here for other people's business. She was here now for her own, and the lobby felt different, and she sat in it and felt the difference and let it be what it was.

The receptionist came back. 'He'll see you now.'

* * *

She had prepared the way she prepared for any significant meeting: completely. She had spent six weeks — the weeks before and after the escalation results, the weeks she had been working late with documents Andriy did not ask about — building the legal architecture of an argument. She had read everything there was to read. She had mapped every counterargument. She had drafted and redrafted the structure until it was as strong as she could make it, and then she had read it again and found the two weak points and addressed them, and then she had read it a final time and concluded that it was the best argument she was capable of making.

She also knew that the argument, however well-constructed, was not the point. The argument was the surface. Underneath it was something simpler and less negotiable: she had spent a decade making this possible for other people, and she needed it now.

Kravchenko read the document she placed on his desk. He was fifty-two, careful, the kind of person who had built a career on understanding exactly where the edges of things were and staying one step inside them. He had worked with her for ten years. He had referred clients to her. He

had taken her professional judgment on matters where his own was insufficient. She had taken his on matters where hers was. Their relationship was the kind of professional relationship that was built on mutual respect and mutual utility and a shared understanding of how the world worked.

He read the document twice. She watched him read it the second time and thought about what he was looking for — the liability structure, the legal argument, the specific ways in which she had tried to make this possible without making it his problem. She had tried very hard to make it not his problem. Whether she had succeeded would depend on how he read section four.

He set the document down.

'You know I can't do this.'

'You can. I've read every statute in the relevant jurisdictions. I've reviewed the convention text, the implementing legislation, and the case law from the three European systems where challenges have been brought. I've been over this more times than any other document in my career.'

'The convention—'

'The convention has an exception. Article 7(c). I've outlined the textual argument in section two. The word adults does not appear in the operative provision. The drafting history suggests it was intended for adults but the text is what controls.'

He looked at her steadily. 'You know what the drafting history shows, Olena. You know what was intended.'

'I know that the text says what it says. I've made this argument before — you've benefited from it before, in the Melnyk matter and in three others I can name. The text controls.'

A pause. She could see him working through it — the legal argument, yes, but also the larger situation, the position she was putting him in, the thing she was asking of him that went beyond legal architecture.

'Even if the textual argument holds,' he said, 'the judicial approval requirement—'

'I have a contact in the Pechersk District Court. Judge Bondarchuk. She has ruled expansively on digital personhood questions twice in the past eighteen months, in both cases reading the statute in favour of the petitioner. An application under Article 7(c) before Judge Bondarchuk has a reasonable prospect of success. I have modelled the argument.'

'A reasonable prospect is not a guarantee.'

'Nothing I do involves guarantees. You have known this for ten years.'

He stood. He went to the window — the same window she had faced across a conference table dozens of times over the years, the same view of the street below, the same Kyiv going about its business. She waited. She had learned, over her career, that the most important thing you could do in a negotiation after making your best argument was to be quiet and let the other person think.

She was quiet. She let him think.

'The ethics board,' he said finally. 'Article 7(c) requires written ethics board approval. I can't manufacture that.'

'I'm not asking you to manufacture it. I'm asking you to convene an in camera consultation — a preliminary assessment, not a formal application, which would trigger the public notification requirements. An in camera consultation is within your authority as director under the board's operating procedures. I've cited the relevant provision in section three.'

'And if someone on the board asks why we're having a preliminary assessment of a hypothetical—'

'It doesn't have to be presented as a specific case. It can be presented as a policy question: under what conditions, if any, would the board consider approving an Article 7(c) application from a minor subject? A general policy discussion. No names.'

He turned from the window. He looked at her for a long time. She held his gaze. She had nothing to hide from him — she was not managing him, not trying to lead him to a conclusion through misdirection. She was

showing him exactly what she was doing and asking him to decide.

'You've been building this for a long time,' he said.

'Since December formally,' she said. 'Since longer than that in other ways.'

'And if it comes out. Any of it. The consultation, the access, the upload itself.'

'Then I have structured the liability so that it sits entirely with me. Not with NeuralMind. Not with you. Section four is specific on this point. I have made it structurally impossible for the liability to migrate. You can look at it as a lawyer, not just as a director — you'll see it holds.'

He picked up the document again. He turned to section four. He read it with the close attention of someone assessing legal architecture rather than legal argument — looking at the structure, the load-bearing elements, the places where something might give under pressure.

She watched him read it and thought about the fourteen clients. Tkachenko, who had not asked what she thought. Yarova, whose daughter in London had said simulation. Bondar, whose daughter had said it's very good. Tetyanenko, four years in perpetuity and sharper every visit, accumulating a kind of time she could not accumulate. She had spent ten years making this world. She had built every door. She knew which ones were marked and which ones were simply unmarked, which was a different thing from locked — a completely different thing.

Kravchenko set down the document.

'I can't be in the room when it happens,' he said.

The sentence arrived with a specific weight — not the weight of a refusal, not the weight of an endorsement, but the weight of a particular kind of professional complicity, the kind that said: I am going to look in a different direction, and you are going to do what you are going to do, and we are both going to live with that.

She received it.

'I understand,' she said.

'Whatever you do, wherever you do it, I have no knowledge of it. If anyone asks me directly, I tell them I refused you. That is what I will say and it is what I will believe.'

'I understand.'

'The ethics board consultation—'

'I'll arrange it through the normal channel. Your assistant will receive a request for a preliminary policy discussion. You don't need to be involved in the substance.'

He looked at her one more time. She thought: he is going to say something about Krystyna, or about what this costs, or about the thing they are both not saying. She watched his face — the professional composure, the careful man's careful face — and saw that he had decided not to say it. That he understood, as she did, that some acknowledgments were things neither of them could afford.

'Goodbye, Olena,' he said. He said it with the finality of a closing — the close of a negotiation, the close of a professional chapter, the close of something neither of them would speak of again.

'Goodbye, Vasyl,' she said.

She picked up her copy of the document. She walked out of the office and down the corridor and through the lobby past the receptionist who knew her and through the glass doors and out into the street, where Kyiv was going about the ordinary business of a February morning, indifferent and enduring.

She had found the door. She had found it exactly where she had always known it would be: unmarked, not locked, requiring only someone willing to open it.

She walked to the taxi stand. She stood in the cold air for a moment, breathing it, feeling the February on her face.

Then she got in a taxi and went home.

She came home that evening and made dinner and we ate together and she helped me with the second verse of a song I was learning for school, a folk song with a chorus that kept changing key on me. She sat at the kitchen table beside me with the sheet music and pointed out where the change happened — here, she said, right here, this is where it goes somewhere else. She was completely present, in the particular way she had when she had decided something and the decision was behind her and there was nothing now but the thing in front of her, which was the sheet music and the key change and me getting it wrong three times and then right. Her being there made the key change make sense. I remember thinking that: she makes difficult things make sense. I still think that.

The Week

Andriy — Spring 2039

She told him on a Sunday evening in March, after Krystyna was asleep.

She had chosen Sunday deliberately — he understood this afterward, the way he came to understand many of her choices: they were never casual, never arbitrary, always shaped by a specific intention. Sunday because Krystyna's week was structured around Monday treatments and school days and the rhythm of being sick while also being seven, and Sunday was the day that stood apart from the structure, the day without an agenda, the day when the apartment was simply itself. She had chosen Sunday because she needed him to receive this without the pressure of the week around it, and Sunday was the only day with enough space.

She sat across from him at the kitchen table and told him everything. Not a selected version — the full version. The legal argument. The Kravchenko conversation. The ethics board consultation she had arranged and how it had gone. The technical requirements: the pre-scan, the forty-eight hours, the neural map, the training process. The specific access she had accumulated over ten years of upload law and what she intended to do with it. The liability structure she had built and what the liability structure meant for both of them. All of it.

He listened without interrupting. This was not natural to him — he was a person who thought out loud, who processed through dialogue, who arrived at understanding through the friction of conversation rather than through solitary reception. Staying quiet cost him. She could see it: the impulse to respond, to question, to push back, held in check by the understanding that this was not yet the moment for any of those things. This

was the moment for receiving.

When she finished, the apartment was very quiet. The kitchen clock. Krystyna's breathing, faintly, through the wall.

'I need a week,' he said.

'We have two. Maybe three.'

'Then I need a week.'

She nodded. She did not say anything else. She understood that the week was necessary and that what he did with it was entirely his own, and that whatever he arrived at after the week would be his decision in the fullest sense — not managed, not led, not arrived at through any architecture she had designed. That was important to her. She was not certain she could articulate why it was important, given that she had already decided, given that the decision was in some sense already made. But it was important. She needed him to decide.

She cleared the table. She went to bed.

She did not sleep for some time, but when she did she slept deeply.

* * *

The first day of the week he taught his Monday classes — two undergraduate seminars and a private lesson with a graduate student working on a Beethoven sonata — and came home and played for Krystyna, who was having a good day. She was working on the folk dance, the key change section, the part that still surprised her sometimes in the middle of the phrase. He sat beside her and listened and she played it wrong twice and then right, and when she got it right she looked at him with the expression she had — not triumphant, something quieter, the expression of someone who has worked toward a thing and found it.

He thought: this is what I want. This exact thing. Her working toward the key change and finding it. This, replicated indefinitely.

He thought: that is what she is asking.

He did not let himself think further than that on the first day. He was a methodical person. He had been given a week and he would use the week. Day one was for receiving. The question was too large to arrive at conclusions on the first day and any conclusion he arrived at on the first day would be premature. He sat with Krystyna and listened to her play the key change again, and the again after that, and he did not think about the decision. He simply listened.

The second day he went to the conservatory and taught and then stayed late, alone in his studio. The studio was a small room on the second floor with a good upright piano and a window that looked onto the inner courtyard and enough space for a desk and a music stand and not much else. He had been in this room for eleven years. It was one of the places he thought most clearly.

He played the Ravel. He had been playing it since he was nineteen, which meant he had been playing it for twenty years, which meant he had been playing it for most of his adult life. He had played it through crises and joys and ordinary evenings. He had played it for students and audiences and for himself. He played it now.

He tried to hear what it meant from where he was standing — on the far side of a week that had not yet elapsed, at the edge of a decision he had not yet made. The Ravel was a farewell to a dead princess. It was beautiful because it was a farewell. The beauty was inseparable from the ending — was not incidental to the ending but structural, built into the harmonics of the thing, present in every bar even the earliest ones. He had believed this for twenty years and he believed it still.

But he was beginning to understand that the belief had always been theoretical in a way it was no longer theoretical. He had believed in the beauty of impermanence from the position of someone who had not yet been asked to choose impermanence for someone he loved. That position had seemed, when he occupied it, like understanding. He understood now

that it had been distance.

He played it through twice. He sat in the silence after each repetition and asked himself: do you believe this? Do you believe it for her?

He did not have an answer on the second day. He drove home.

The third day Krystyna woke tired. The tiredness from treatment had returned after the good day — it worked like this, he had learned: a good day cost something, extracted a payment that arrived the following morning. She lay on the couch with Vovk and her tablet and he sat with her, her feet in his lap, not talking. She was not sad on the tired days, or not usually — she was inward, conserving, the particular withdrawal of a person managing their own resources. He had learned not to try to draw her out on the tired days. He sat with her and was present and let her be inward.

He thought about the model. He turned the copy problem over in his mind the way you turned a stone — looking at it from different angles, testing its weight, trying to find the place where it felt most solid and the place where it gave.

A model trained on Krystyna's neural record would have everything. Every memory she had formed, encoded with the fidelity that Neural-Mind guaranteed and that the law recognised as constituting identity continuity. The way she approached the key change. The way she had said okay to the diagnosis and okay to the treatment and okay to everything since, with the particular quality of the word that meant: I have found the floor.

He thought: the model would have the okay. It would have the floor.

He thought: is that her? If it has the floor, is it her?

He had been asking this question for eight years, since Petro's wife first uploaded, in different forms and at different distances. He had never arrived at an answer he fully trusted. He was not going to arrive at one now.

He thought: almost.

Almost was the only honest answer he knew. And he held it and sat with it and let Krystyna's feet be in his lap and the apartment be quiet around them.

The fourth day he stood at Maksym's photograph for a long time.

The photograph was on the refrigerator, where it had always been — the school photo, the gap-toothed smile, the boy who had been in this apartment for nine years and would always have been in this apartment, in the tense that didn't change. He stood at the refrigerator and looked at the photograph and thought about what it meant to have Maksym in the world and then not in the world. He had done this many times in the four years since the Tuesday, and it had always been the same: the photograph looked back at him and the looking back contained everything and nothing, contained the full weight of Maksym and no response at all, contained the fact of him and the absence of anything that could be asked of him.

This time he asked anyway. He stood at the refrigerator and asked Maksym what he thought. He understood that this was not something Maksym could answer. He asked anyway, because the question was too large for only the living.

He thought: Maksym knew about Krystyna. That was what mattered. Not what came after the knowing — just the knowing itself. She had been real to him. That fact was permanent in the only sense that facts could be permanent: it had happened, and nothing could unhappen it. No version of the future changed what had already occurred. Maksym had known about his sister. That was his.

He thought: the model would know about Maksym. It would have every memory Krystyna had of him — the photograph, the question she had asked over porridge, the answer she had received. It would carry him the way she carried him.

He thought: that is worth something. That is the shape of him, preserved.

He stood at the refrigerator for a long time. The apartment was quiet around him. Then he went back to whatever he had been doing.

The fifth day Olena worked late. He put Krystyna to bed — she had had a better day, had come to the piano for a while in the afternoon and worked on the key change again, getting it right more often than not now, the surprise of it diminishing as it became familiar — and sat at the piano and played without intent. Not the Ravel this time. His hands found other things: the bear song, slowly; the opening of the folk dance; something he had been working on with a student that week; bars of this and that, the piano as a thinking instrument rather than a performing one.

He thought: I believe in the beauty of endings. I have believed this for twenty years. I believe it for me. I believe it for music. I believe, for myself, that the ending is part of what the thing is, and that choosing to prolong something past its ending changes it, diminishes it, makes it less rather than more.

He thought: she is seven years old and she has not had the life yet for the ending to be part of. The ending requires having had enough. She has not had enough. The philosophy I built assumes having had enough, and she has not yet had it, and I cannot apply it to her because she is not at the place from which the philosophy is visible.

He sat with this for a long time. The apartment around him. The piano under his hands. The Ravel on the stand, where it had been since he played it in the studio on the second day.

He thought: the philosophy is not wrong. It is simply not hers to bear.

The sixth day they took Krystyna to the park, one of the good days, a clear April day with the light very clean and the river visible between the buildings, the kind of Kyiv afternoon that made you remember why you lived there. She walked between them on the path along the river and talked about the ducks with the thoroughness of someone who had been paying careful attention to the ducks and had drawn conclusions. She talked about a book she was reading. She talked about a question she had

about stars.

'What happens inside a star?' she said. 'Not the outside — the inside. Is it really as hot as they say? How do you know, if you can't go there?'

'You can infer it,' Andriy said. 'From what comes out. The light, the radiation. You measure what leaves the star and work backward to what must be inside it to produce that output.'

'So you don't know directly. You know because of what you can observe from here.'

'Yes.'

She considered this. 'That's interesting,' she said, in the tone she used when something had confirmed an intuition she had been working on. 'So all knowledge of the inside is really knowledge of the outside.'

He looked at his daughter. She was seven years old and she was conducting a philosophical inquiry about epistemology while walking past ducks by the river and it was entirely typical of her and he loved her with a completeness that had no edges.

He watched her walk. He watched her watch the ducks. He thought: a model trained on this would have this. The ducks and the how-do-you-know questions and the April light and the specific quality of her walking, the deliberateness of it, the way she moved through the world as if it were worth paying attention to.

He thought: if it has all of this, what is the remainder? What is the fraction that cannot be captured?

He thought: I don't know. And I think the not-knowing might be the whole point. I think the not-knowing is what the choice is made inside of. Not certainty. Not proof. The not-knowing, and the choice made inside it, and whatever that choice is worth.

He walked beside his daughter and looked at the river and made his decision.

The seventh day was a Sunday again. The week had completed itself. He sat at the kitchen table in the morning while Olena made coffee and

Krystyna was still asleep, and he thought: I am going to tell her yes. And the telling her yes is the decision. The week was the decision arriving, and now it has arrived, and this is what it is.

When Olena brought the coffee to the table and sat across from him, he looked at her.

'Tell me what you need me to do,' he said.

She looked at him. The quick precise assessment, as always — reading him, checking whether this was the full yes or a yes-with-reservations, a yes-that-needed-supporting or a yes-that-had-arrived-on-its-own. She found what she was looking for.

'Are you sure?' she said.

'I'm not sure about anything. I'm decided. That's different.'

She set down her coffee. She reached across the table and took his hand. He felt the specific warmth of her hand — the particular way she held, with her whole hand rather than her fingers, a way of holding he had known for fifteen years and which meant, when it arrived: I am here. I am entirely here.

'Sit down,' she said. 'Let me tell you everything.'

'I'm already sitting down.'

She almost smiled. 'Then let me tell you everything.'

He listened.

* * *

What he had not expected — what surprised him, in the days after the decision, and continued to surprise him for the weeks that followed — was the lightness.

Not happiness. Not relief, exactly. Not the absence of fear, which was still present, which would remain present until it was over and probably after. But lightness. A specific quality of the air in the apartment that he

had not felt in a year — since before the diagnosis, since before the open door, since the time when the world had been the world before it was this.

He understood, thinking about it carefully, that the weight had been the subjunctive. The might. The not-yet-decided. The open door not yet being walked toward. He had been carrying the weight of a decision not made, which was different from the weight of a decision made, and heavier. Decisions, even terrible ones, were lighter than their undecided alternatives. He had not known this before.

The door was still open. But now they were both walking toward it.

He played for Krystyna every evening that week with a different quality of attention — not the watching-and-memorising quality of the past year, though that was still present, but something that was moving forward rather than simply preserving. He played her the lullaby. He played her the folk dance from beginning to end, including the key change, demonstrating the change slowly so she could see where it went and why. He played her the bear song, which she had not asked for in a long time but which he played anyway, and she listened with her eyes closed in the way she had when she was genuinely receiving something rather than simply hearing it.

'I know that one,' she said, when he finished.

'You've heard it since before you could talk,' he said.

'I know all of them,' she said. 'Even the ones I haven't learned yet. I know them from hearing you.'

He looked at his daughter. She was seven years old and she was sitting at the piano bench beside him and she had just said something that was either the most ordinary thing a musical child had ever said or was something else entirely, something that lived in the space between ordinary and not, and he did not know which and did not need to know.

'Yes,' he said. 'You do.'

He played on.

He played the lullaby that week. The one from when I was very small. I remember closing my eyes and letting it be there — not listening to it the way you listen to something new, not learning it, just receiving it, the way you receive something that has always been true. It was the first song I ever learned. The first song that was mine. And I said to him: I know all of them. Even the ones I haven't learned yet. I know them from hearing you. I meant it. I mean it still. He gave me the music the way the air gives you what you breathe — without asking, without ceremony, simply by being there. I have it. I will always have it.

Pattern Integrity

Olena — 2039

The technician was twenty-six years old and owed her a favour she had never intended to collect.

His name was MYKOLA SAVCHYN and she had represented him three years ago in a wrongful dismissal matter that had nothing to do with NeuralMind and everything to do with the particular vulnerability of a young man in a poorly drafted employment contract who had not known enough to read it carefully. She had read it for him, at no charge, because the matter had landed on her desk through a chain of referrals she had not anticipated and because she was the kind of person who, once she understood a situation, could not unknow it. The contract had been bad. The employer's position had been defensible but bad-faith. She had written two letters and the matter had resolved.

She had not thought about collecting. She had not done it to collect. She had done it because it was the right thing and because she was the right person to do it and because the combination of those two things had always been sufficient justification for her. The favour had gone into a mental ledger she maintained about such things — not because she was calculating but because she was honest with herself, because she understood that professional relationships had ledgers whether you acknowledged them or not, and acknowledging them was cleaner.

She thought about this now, sitting at her kitchen table at eleven at night, preparing to call him — thought about what it meant to have spent fifteen years doing the right things for the right reasons and to be sitting here now calling a twenty-six-year-old about a favour she had never in-

tended to collect. She thought: I do not understand the shape of my own life. I am not certain anyone does, until something like this happens and the shape is suddenly visible, all at once, and you see that it was always moving toward this.

She called him.

She explained what she needed without softening it. She had written out the key points beforehand — not a script, she did not work from scripts, but the structure of what she needed to say, the order in which it needed to be said, the things that required acknowledgment before the ask. She told him that what she was asking was illegal. She told him that the exposure for him was real and that she had structured the legal liability to contain it as much as possible but that she could not eliminate it entirely — the isolation of liability was not the elimination of it, and she owed him the honesty of that distinction. She told him that he needed to understand this and to make his decision with full information. She told him he could say no. She told him that saying no would not change anything between them, that the favour she had done him three years ago would remain done regardless of his answer and she would never revisit it. She meant all of this and she made sure it sounded like she meant it, which was not a performance — she simply made sure the truth was audible.

There was a long silence on his end.

'You understand,' she said, 'that I am asking you, not requiring you. Those are different things and I need you to understand they are different things.'

Another silence. She could hear him thinking — the specific quality of a silence in which someone was working through something carefully and had enough respect for the situation to take the time. She had learned to recognise this quality. The silence of someone deciding rather than hesitating was different from the silence of someone afraid. This was the former.

Then: 'When?'

She told him when.

'The pre-scan has to run for forty-eight hours minimum,' he said. His voice had shifted — the decision made, the practical intelligence engaged, the young man who had chosen to help working out what help required. 'To build sufficient baseline fidelity. And she needs to be physically present in the suite the whole time — the scan has to be initiated in the environment. I can't do a remote collection.'

'I know. I've arranged the cover for the physical presence. A medical consultation, legitimately scheduled. The suite will appear to be in maintenance during the scan window.'

'The logs—'

'I've handled the logs. You don't need to know the details.'

A pause. 'I'll walk you through the full protocol,' he said. 'The pre-scan, the training parameters, the integrity thresholds. I'll make sure you know what you're doing at every step.' Another pause, shorter. 'But I can't be there when it runs.'

She heard the echo of Kravchenko's words and felt something that was not quite irony — something more like the recognition of a pattern. The men who were helping her were helping her from a distance. She had structured it to make the distance possible, to make it so that what she was doing was contained within herself and did not leak outward into the lives of people who had their own things to lose. She had built the structure to protect other people from it. She would hold the exposure. That was always the plan.

She understood, sitting at her kitchen table, that this was the most specifically legal thing she had ever done: the isolation of liability. The careful architecture of who could know what and what that knowledge meant. She had done it for other people a hundred times, had been the one who isolated the liability on behalf of clients who needed protection, who built the structures that kept bad outcomes from migrating to where

they could do more damage. Now she was doing it for herself. The skill was the same. The stakes were not.

She was not afraid of this. She had been afraid of many things over the past year — the numbers, the escalation, the not-knowing — but she was not afraid of this. The exposure was hers and it was where it belonged and she had looked at it directly and understood what it meant and had decided that it was the correct cost for what it was buying. She had made more complicated calculations in her career. She had made this one many times, in other contexts, for other people. She had been building toward making it for herself since the night she read Article 7(c) in the blue light of a hotel room in Warsaw.

'That's enough,' she said. 'Thank you, Mykola.'

She ended the call. From the other room: the Chopin, Andriy at the piano, the E minor nocturne, the searching quality he played when he was inside a question rather than an answer. She had come to understand the nocturne as his processing music — the piece he reached for when something needed to be worked through the instrument because the mind alone was insufficient. He was still inside the question. She had given him the full information and he was processing it the way he processed everything: slowly, through the instrument, through music that had the right shape for the territory.

She opened her laptop. She had three more structures to build before she could sleep, and she would not sleep until they were built.

* * *

The ethics board consultation happened in the third week of April.

She had not been present — the consultation had been convened as a preliminary policy discussion, framed as a general question about the theoretical conditions under which Article 7(c) applications from non-adult

subjects might be considered. She had received a summary through the channel Kravchenko had made available. The summary was four paragraphs. She read it three times, each time more slowly than the last, attending to each sentence with the full precision she brought to any document that was going to matter.

The board had not said yes. The board had said: under certain conditions, involving a specific and narrow set of criteria, the board would be willing to consider such an application on its merits. The criteria were specific. They overlapped, with a precision she found almost startling, with the structure she had already built — as if the criteria had been designed with her architecture in mind, or as if her architecture had been designed with the criteria in mind, which was closer to the truth. She had been reading NeuralMind’s ethics board proceedings for a decade. She had known what they would require before she built the structure. She had built it to those specifications.

She had not told Kravchenko about this. She suspected he already knew.

She thought, in those weeks, about pattern integrity. It was NeuralMind’s technical standard for a successful upload — the degree to which the resulting model accurately reproduced the neural patterns of the original subject. Ninety-seven percent was the minimum threshold for a legal upload. Ninety-nine percent was what the company guaranteed to clients. She had seen the figures in client files across a decade: Bilyk at ninety-nine point four, Tetyanenko at ninety-nine point six, Bondar at ninety-nine point three. All of them within a fraction of complete. All of them, by the law’s reckoning, the same person.

She thought about what the remaining fractions represented. The point four. The point six. The difference between the model and the pattern that had been scanned. What was in that small remainder that could not be captured? What did the model miss?

NeuralMind’s position was measurement noise — the fractions were

an artefact of the scanning and encoding process rather than a genuine gap in the person being preserved. The philosophical objectors argued it was everything — the irreducible remainder of personhood that could not be encoded because it was not, ultimately, neural at all. The thing that made a person that specific person and not a very accurate model of that person. The soul, if you believed in souls. The uncapturable specificity of being, if you didn't.

She did not know which position was correct. She had spent ten years not knowing, making her living in the space of that not-knowing, answering the question with the law's answer because the law had an answer and the law was what she was paid to know. The law said: pattern continuity is identity continuity. The law said: the model is the person. She had said this many times. She believed it in the sense that she believed all the things she said professionally — carefully, with the awareness that belief was not certainty and that acting on careful belief was the best anyone could do.

She thought about Krystyna. She thought: ninety-nine point something percent is her. The lullaby is in there. The folk dance in progress, two years of patient work toward the key change she had almost but not quite cracked. The yellow sweater chosen with such seriousness on the morning of the diagnosis. The way she said okay — the particular floor-finding quality of that word when she used it. The way she had her hands around the bowl of soup in the restaurant with the wooden tables, her palms pressing against the warmth of it.

She thought: ninety-nine point something is enough. It has to be enough. I am choosing to believe it is enough, and the choosing is honest — I am not pretending to certainty I do not have. I am making a decision inside uncertainty, which is what all decisions are, which is what I have always done, which is what I know how to do.

She closed the laptop. The Chopin had stopped. The apartment was quiet.

She went to find Andriy.

* * *

She visited the perpetuity suite one last time as herself — as a lawyer, officially, on a client matter she had arranged to be legitimate. Tetyanenko had a question about the ongoing asset dispute with his elder son, which had entered a new phase with his son's recent change of legal representation. She went to answer it.

He had been in perpetuity for four and a half years now. She had been visiting him regularly across that time — monthly at first, less frequently as the matters settled into their longer rhythms — watching the process that she had now watched in many clients: the gradual transformation of a person in perpetuity, the way the biological constraints fell away and what remained became more concentrated, more precisely itself. Tetyanenko had always been sharp and had become sharper. He had always been curious and had become more curious, had developed a depth and range that his pre-upload self had not had the time to develop. He had read, he told her, the complete works of every Ukrainian poet he had always meant to read. He had worked through the complete history of the Byzantine Empire, which had been a longstanding interest he had never had the sustained hours to pursue. He had developed opinions about mathematics that he had never had before, because he had the time to learn enough mathematics to have opinions about it.

She thought about this as she sat across from him in the interaction room — the specific question of what it was to have time. Not the metaphorical time that people meant when they said they needed more time — the literal time, the actual uninterrupted consecutive hours, weeks, years, available for whatever the mind wanted to do with them. The uploaded had this in a way the biological never could. They were not distracted

by hunger. They were not depleted by physical tiredness. They were not interrupted by the thousand small demands of having a body in the world. They were, in the most literal sense, free to think.

She thought: Krystyna would have time. She would have time to learn why the key change goes where it does, time to understand what is inside stars, time to follow every question to its end and then to the question after that. She would have time to become whatever she was going to become, without the interruption of a body that had decided to stop. That was what perpetuity offered. Not the absence of difficulty — the uploaded were not immune to grief or loss or the complex emotions of existing in relation to other people. But time. The right to go on.

She handled Tetyanenko's matter efficiently. The new legal strategy was more sophisticated than the previous one but had a fundamental structural weakness she identified within the first twenty minutes and that she outlined clearly and without embellishment. He listened with the quality of attention she had come to associate with him specifically — the full presence, nothing held back, the intelligence applied completely to what she was saying rather than to what he was preparing to say in response.

At the end he said: 'You look different.'

'Different how?'

'Resolved,' he said. 'Like someone who has passed through something and arrived somewhere. I've seen this look on a few people over my time here. It usually means a significant decision has been made and the weight of the deciding is behind them.' He paused. 'I don't mean to presume.'

'You're not presuming,' she said.

She held his gaze. She thought: four and a half years in perpetuity and he reads people with a precision the biological rarely managed. He had been accumulating this precision the way he had been accumulating everything else — through the consecutive undistracted hours, the uninterrupted attention, the specific advantage of being completely present in

every conversation.

She didn't mind being read. There was nothing left to manage.

'I hope you're well, Mr. Tetyanenko,' she said.

'I am always well,' he said. 'That's the thing about perpetuity. You learn to be well. You don't have a choice about it — either you learn or you don't survive the learning, and most people survive it.' He paused. 'I mean that as something positive. It takes time to understand it as positive. But it is. She will find that it is.'

Olena looked at him. He had not used a name. He had not referred to anything specific. He had, in the manner of someone who has learned to be very careful with what he said and what he implied, offered her something that could be understood as a general statement and that was clearly not.

'Thank you,' she said.

'Good luck, Olena,' he said. 'I mean that precisely.'

She walked out of the suite for the last time. She walked down the corridor she had walked down hundreds of times, past the interaction rooms she knew, past the staff she had worked alongside for a decade. She did not look back.

She came home from the suite that evening and sat with me while I practised the second half of the folk dance — the part that kept surprising me with the key change. She sat beside me on the bench. She almost never sat beside me while I practised — she listened from across the room or from the doorway, which was how she listened to most things, from a slight distance that I understood was not disconnection but was simply how she received things. That evening she sat beside me. She didn't say anything. She just sat there while I played it wrong and then right and then wrong again. Her being there made playing matter in a different way. I understand now what she was doing. She was present. She was choosing to be present. That is its own kind of gift.

What We Are Going to Do

Olena — two weeks before

They told her on a Thursday evening in late April, two weeks before the date Mykola had confirmed.

Olena had thought carefully about when and how. Not the content — the content was fixed, she knew what needed to be said and she had been rehearsing the shape of it for months, not scripting it but understanding it, the way you understood an argument you were going to make before you made it. The content was not the question. The question was the context. The right room. The right time of day. Whether it should be at home or somewhere outside home. She had decided: at home. In Krystyna's room. On her bed. The safest place in the apartment, the place that was most specifically Krystyna's, the place that belonged to her. This time she wanted the news to live in the place that most belonged to Krystyna rather than in a space between places.

Andriy had agreed with everything. He had been in agreement with everything since the Sunday he had said: tell me what you need me to do. She had not taken this for granted. She had understood that it was a decision made and held, that the holding of it was its own effort, that every day since that Sunday he had been carrying the weight of the decision and choosing to carry it without flinching. She was grateful for it in a way she had not yet been able to express and suspected she might not be able to express before the time for expressing it ran out.

They sat on the edges of Krystyna's bed, one on each side of her. Krystyna sat between them with Vovk on her lap, looking from one face to the other with the inventory expression. She had always been able to

read the air in the apartment — had known since she was very small when something was coming, when a conversation was approaching that would matter. She was reading the air now. She had the quality she always had in the face of something serious: not fear, not deflection, simply full presence. She was there.

'Tell me,' she said.

Olena said: 'You know what Mama does for work. You know that some of my clients — the people I help — they get to keep going. Even when their bodies stop working. You know what that means.'

Krystyna looked at her. She was seven — she would be eight in January — and she understood exactly what that meant. She had grown up in the apartment of an upload lawyer. She had heard the word upload since before she could read. She had heard her parents debate it in the evenings, had heard the clients in her mother's waiting room, had grown up with this technology as part of the furniture of the world, something that existed and that cost a great deal and that was not something that happened to most people.

'You're going to upload me,' she said.

The sentence arrived with the specific flatness of a child stating what is true rather than asking what might be. It was not a question. It was a confirmation, the result of the inventory expression having completed its assessment.

Andriy's hand tightened on the bedspread. Olena held Krystyna's gaze.

'Yes,' she said.

Krystyna was quiet for a moment. She looked at Vovk. She turned him over in her hands once, the way she did when she was thinking — methodically, not anxiously, the gesture of someone who needed the texture of something familiar while processing something new.

'But children can't,' she said. 'You told me. It's not allowed.'

'I found a way,' Olena said.

Another silence. The apartment was very quiet. Through the window: Kyiv in the evening, the city going about its indifferent life, the trams and the pedestrians and the whole ordinary machinery of a place where most people were having ordinary evenings.

'What happens to you?' Krystyna said.

The question fell into the room with the weight of something they had both known was coming and still could not entirely absorb. Olena had rehearsed this — the shape of it, the honesty of it, what she could say and what she could not.

'We're going to be with you every minute of it,' Olena said. 'And afterward, you'll be somewhere safe. You'll be in perpetuity. And you'll go on.'

'That's not what I asked,' Krystyna said.

She was seven years old and she was not going to be deflected and Olena had always known this about her. It was one of the things she loved most about her daughter and one of the things that was hardest about this moment: that the person across from her was entirely, completely, unapologetically herself.

'There will be consequences for what we're doing,' Olena said. 'For me and Papa. Legal consequences. We won't be — we won't be able to be with you afterward, in the way we are now. In the ordinary way.'

'You'll die,' Krystyna said.

'We don't know exactly what will happen,' Andriy said. His voice was steady. Olena heard the cost of that.

Krystyna looked at her father. Then at her mother. Then at Vovk, for a long moment.

'I don't want to go somewhere without you,' she said.

'I know,' Andriy said.

'Papa.'

'I know, Krystynko. I know.'

He moved to sit beside her properly — not on the edge but close, his

arm around her. She leaned into him with the full weight of her small body, the way she had leaned into him since she was able to lean, the instinctive trust of a child who has always found their parent's shoulder at the right height.

Olena watched them. She thought: this. This is what I am preserving. This exact thing — the way she leans, the weight of her, the trust in it. The model will have this. The model will be a person who has always leaned into this shoulder and found it there, who has the full memory of what it is to be held by this person. The model will carry this.

After a while, Krystyna pulled back. She looked at her mother.

'Will I remember everything?' she said.

'Everything,' Olena said. 'That's what the technology does. It makes a complete record of everything you are. Every memory. Every—'

'Including you?'

'Including us. Everything.'

Krystyna thought about this. The inventory expression — assessing, cataloguing, deciding.

'Including the piano?' she said.

Andriy made a sound. He covered it immediately, turned it into something neutral, but she had heard it — the broken edge of it, briefly visible before the steadiness reasserted itself. Olena loved him for the steadiness and for the broken edge both.

'Including the piano,' he said. 'Everything I ever played for you. Everything you've learned. Everything you're still learning.'

Krystyna nodded slowly.

'And the key change,' she said. 'I'll understand the key change.'

'You'll have all the time in the world to understand it,' Andriy said.

She seemed to accept this. She sat for another moment, turning it over.

'Is it going to hurt?' she said.

'No,' Olena said. 'You'll feel sleepy. And then you'll be somewhere

else. And it will still be you.'

'How do you know it will still be me?'

'Because everything that makes you you will be there,' Olena said. 'The technology captures the whole pattern — not just memories but the way you think, the way you respond to things, the way you are. The pattern is you.'

Krystyna considered this with the seriousness she brought to philosophical questions, which was the same seriousness she brought to everything.

'Okay,' she said finally.

One word. The word with the floor in it. Olena exhaled. She had not known, until she exhaled, that she had been holding her breath.

'Can I bring Vovk?' Krystyna said.

'Yes,' Andriy said immediately.

'Good,' she said. She tucked the rabbit more firmly under her arm, as if settling a decision. 'Then okay.'

* * *

In the days that followed, Krystyna did not ask many more questions. This was characteristic of her — she absorbed information, processed it on her own time, and emerged from the processing with the thing settled. She was not pretending it was settled when it wasn't. It was simply settled. This was who she was: a person who received difficult things and found her footing in them and went on.

She went to school on the good days, which she had been doing throughout the treatment. She played the piano. She ate her meals with the systematic focus she brought to food. She asked, once, about what perpetuity was actually like — not the technical description, which she had, but the daily experience of it. What it felt like from inside. Olena

had described it carefully, based on ten years of client conversations: like being very present, she said, without the tiredness or the distraction. Like having all the time you need.

Krystyna had nodded, filing this.

She asked one more specific thing, the following Saturday, while Andriy was teaching her the second half of the folk dance — the part after the key change, which she had finally cracked, which she was now learning to own rather than simply survive. She played through the passage twice, then stopped.

'Papa,' she said, without looking up from the keys.

'Mm.'

'Will there be music? In perpetuity?'

He looked at her profile — the focused expression, the slight forward lean, her hands resting lightly on the keys.

'Yes,' he said. 'Anything you ask for.'

'Will they have the Ravel?'

He was quiet for a moment. She waited. She had always been good at waiting for him to arrive at something — had learned early that his silences were not absences but the evidence of thinking happening, and that interrupting them lost something.

'Yes,' he said. 'They'll have everything.'

She played the key change. She got it right. She did not look up.

'Good,' she said.

She played on. He sat beside her and listened to the folk dance find itself through her hands, phrase by phrase, the key change no longer a surprise but a known destination, a place the melody was always going to go.

He thought: she asked about the Ravel. She heard it through the wall, all those years, and she wanted it with her. She knew what it was without knowing what it was called. She knew it the way she knew everything he had played — not as learned material but as part of the air she had always

breathed.

He played a bar of it, very softly, underneath her folk dance. She heard it and glanced at him with the quick pleased expression she had when something landed right.

She played on.

I asked him about the Ravel because I had heard it through the wall many times and I had never asked what it was called. I knew it was something specific — it had a specific feeling, a specific quality of ending, the way some pieces feel like they are always arriving somewhere and some feel like they are always leaving. The Ravel felt like leaving. I heard it through the wall and I thought: whatever that is, I want it where I'm going. I asked him and he told me what it was and I stored it. I have it. I play it sometimes, here. It sounds like him. It sounds like the apartment.

The Ravel

Andriy — the night before

He had been playing the Ravel since he was nineteen years old. Twenty-three years. He had played it in student recitals and in concert halls in three countries and in the apartment at two in the morning when something needed working through. He had played it in the year after Maksym, finding his way back to the instrument one note at a time, and he had played it for Krystyna before she was born and after she arrived and every year of her life. He had been playing it his entire adult life — the piece that was most essentially his, the one he returned to when he needed to know what he thought.

He had never played it the way he played it tonight.

He could not have said what was different, technically. His technique was what it had always been. Tonight was neither his best nor his worst in any objective sense. But there was a quality of presence in it that he had not felt before. Not the presence of a performer playing for an audience, not even the presence of a musician playing for himself. Something else. Something that had no name in any musical vocabulary he knew. He was playing it as something final, for people in the next room and a morning that was coming, and the finality was not grief — or not only grief — but a kind of arrival. He had been moving toward this piece, toward this particular playing of this particular piece, for twenty-three years. He understood this only now that he was here.

He thought about his father. About the argument his father had made his whole life, that the concert stage was not the highest form of musical life, that the highest form was music in rooms, music between people,

music that was part of daily life rather than an event extracted from it. He had not fully agreed when he was young. He was not certain he fully agreed now. But he understood, playing the Ravel in the apartment with his daughter asleep in the next room and his wife somewhere behind him in the dark, that his father had been pointing at something true even if the argument he used to point at it was imprecise.

The truth it was pointing at was this: music in the room you lived in had a different relationship to time than music in a concert hall. The concert hall extracted the music from ordinary time — made it an event, a thing you went to and left, a performance that existed in its own bracket. Music in the room was not extracted. It was embedded. It was part of the continuous texture of the days, the evenings, the mornings. Krystyna had grown up with the Ravel in the air of the apartment the way she had grown up with the smell of borscht — not as something remarkable, not as an event, but as part of what the apartment was. Part of what home meant.

He thought: she carries this because it was always here. Not because she was taught it or exposed to it deliberately or given it as a gift. Because it was simply in the air she breathed for eight years, the way the river is part of you if you grow up beside it.

He played the Ravel through once and let the last note fade and sat with the silence for a long time.

Then he played it again.

* * *

Olena came and sat in the chair across the room — not the doorway, which was where she always stood, but the chair, the actual chair, as if tonight she needed to be fully inside the room rather than at its threshold. She was still dressed. It was past midnight. Krystyna was asleep in the other

room with Vovk and whatever she was dreaming, and the apartment held its particular night-quality: full, occupied, complete.

He played the Ravel through a second time. He was aware of her listening — the specific quality of her attention when she listened to him play, which he had always known was different from how she listened to anything else. Most things she received at a slight angle, the professional mind running underneath, processing and categorising even when she was not consciously working. When she listened to him play she was entirely present. He had always known this. He had never said it.

When he finished the second time he let the silence extend until it was comfortable.

'I've been thinking about the copy problem,' he said. He did not turn from the piano.

'Tell me,' she said.

'I've been thinking about it the way I think about recordings. A recording of a performance is not the performance. It captures something — the notes, the timing, the acoustics of the room. It loses something — the air, the specific evening, the particular state of the hands. I have never thought a recording was the same thing as the performance. I have always known they were different.'

'Yes,' she said.

'But a recording of Schubert is still Schubert. Whatever it loses, whatever the remainder contains, what it has is recognisably him — his way of moving through musical space, his particular logic of phrase and resolution. You know it, listening to a recording of his sonatas, that no one else made this. It is his, even in reproduction.'

Olena was quiet.

'I think a model trained on Krystyna will be like that,' he said. 'Not Krystyna in the full sense — whatever the full sense is, which I'm not sure anyone knows. But recognisably her. Her way of moving through the world. Her particular logic. Her okay. Her lullaby. Her folk dance,

the key change she finally cracked. The way she leans into people she trusts.'

'Yes,' Olena said.

He turned to look at her. She was watching him with the expression she had — the fully present one, the one without the professional mind running underneath.

'I'm afraid it won't be her,' he said. 'I want you to know that. I'm afraid the remainder is the thing that matters most, and I'm doing it anyway, because I have looked at the alternative and I cannot. I cannot choose the alternative for her.'

'I know,' she said.

'Are you afraid?'

'I've been afraid for months,' she said. 'The fear stopped being useful somewhere around February. I moved through it.' She paused. 'I'm still afraid. It's just not running the show anymore.'

He nodded. He turned back to the piano and placed his hands on the keys without playing.

'There is something I need to tell you,' he said. 'Something about the Tuesday.'

He heard her become very still.

'I have never told you this,' he said. 'Because telling you would have made it more real than I was ready for it to be, and because I wasn't certain whether telling you would help you or hurt you, and I kept not telling you until the not-telling became its own thing — something I was carrying that had weight because it was unshared.' He paused. 'He was asking about a dog. On the way to school. He was asking if we could get a dog and I was about to say no — I had the word no in my mouth, I was about to say it — and then the light changed and I pulled forward and then the sound.'

He stopped.

'I have thought about that word for five years,' he said. 'The no in

my mouth. That being the last thing. The ordinary refusal of an ordinary request.'

'Andriy—'

'I'm glad you told me,' he said. 'That it was me in the car. That he was with me. I'm glad it wasn't a stranger, or an empty morning, or a Tuesday when he was with someone who didn't love him as much. I'm glad it was me, even though I couldn't stop it. I've needed to say that for five years and I've never said it.'

The room was very quiet.

'I know,' Olena said. She said it simply, as if she had always known it, as if it had been waiting for him to say it so she could confirm it. 'I have always known that it was right that it was you. That he was with you. That the last thing was you.'

He exhaled. Something left him with the exhale — something he had been carrying since the Tuesday, dense and unnamed, that had not had anywhere to go until now. It did not disappear. It did not resolve. But it was shared, and being shared was different from being carried alone.

'Play something with me,' he said.

'I don't play.'

'I know. Play something with me anyway.'

She got up. She came to him. She sat beside him on the piano bench and placed her hands on the keys. He found a note and she found one beside it. They were not playing music — they were two people with their hands on the same instrument making sounds that were not shaped or intended, that went nowhere and resolved into nothing. It was the least musical thing he had done in twenty-three years and it was, without question, the best.

They played for a while in this way. The apartment was very quiet around them. The last night held them, not unkindly.

* * *

Later, much later, she slept. He did not sleep for a long time.

He lay in the dark and thought about Krystyna in the next room. The lullaby she had played for the first time with her tongue between her teeth and then looked at him with the expression that meant: I did something real. The folk dance. The key change she had been working toward for two years and had finally cracked. The soup place with the wooden tables. The way she had said: I know all of them. Even the ones I haven't learned yet. I know them from hearing you.

He thought about what she had given him. The eight years of her. The specific texture of having her in the apartment — her presence in every room, the quality she added to the air of the place, the way the apartment had been different and more itself since she arrived. He thought about all the evenings he had played and she had been in the room, not necessarily listening, just present, the music part of the air and she part of the music by proximity. He thought: that is what I gave her. And what she gave me was the other side of it — the reason to play in the evenings, the room that needed the music because she was in it.

He thought about Schubert. The recordings — two centuries of them, made in living rooms and concert halls, each one capturing something and losing something, each one carrying the shape of a mind through time. He thought: we have Schubert because something survived him. The recordings are not Schubert. They are not nothing.

He thought: she will not be nothing.

He thought: I have played the Ravel for twenty-three years and tonight I played it for her and she was asleep in the next room and she did not hear it but the apartment heard it, and she is part of the apartment, and in whatever way the apartment holds things I played it for her and she received it.

He thought: that is enough. It is not everything. It is enough.

He lay in the dark and listened to the apartment and eventually, near dawn, he slept.

He played the Ravel that night. I can hear every note. I will always be able to hear every note. I was asleep in the next room. I did not hear it — I was asleep, I was dreaming something I cannot now remember. But I have the memory of waking briefly, near the end, the way you wake sometimes in the night without knowing why, and hearing very faint through the wall the last phrase. The descending phrase. The princess going gently into the distance. I didn't know what it was. I went back to sleep. I know now. I have been knowing it since the moment I arrived here, and the knowing is not grief exactly, or not only grief. It is also this: he played the Ravel, and I heard the end of it, and I carry the sound. It sounds like him. It sounds like home.

Everything They Gave Me

Olena — the night before

She had not planned to go into Krystyna's room. She had been meaning to sleep — they needed to be at NeuralMind before six, there were things tomorrow that required her to be rested and clear. She had a protocol to execute and she needed her mind available for it. She had planned to sleep.

Instead she was standing in the doorway of Krystyna's room at midnight, looking at her daughter.

She had been standing there for some minutes before she registered that she was there. She had gotten up for water and had found herself in the doorway, drawn by something she had not consciously decided. She stood and looked and let whatever had drawn her do what it needed to do.

Krystyna was eight. She had been sick for a year and a half and she had grown through it in the particular way that children grew when they were also fighting something — not more slowly, exactly, but more deliberately, as if the body were being careful with its resources. Her hair had come back after the first cycle and thinned again during the escalated treatment and was now growing back for the second time, soft and fine and slightly darker than it had been before, a detail Olena had noted with the specific attention she had been giving everything for months. She noted things now differently than she had before the diagnosis — with the urgency of someone who understood that the noting might be all that remained.

She was sleeping on her side with Vovk tucked under her arm and her

mouth slightly open and one foot sticking out from under the covers in the way she always slept. The room was the room it had always been: the drawings on the walls, the periodic table poster she had asked for when she was six and had been studying ever since, the keyboard on the desk, the shelf of books and small collected objects — the smooth stone from the river, the shell, the piece of blue glass she had found in the park, a small ceramic bird from someone whose name Olena could not immediately recall. The objects on the shelf were not arranged decoratively. They were arranged the way Krystyna arranged things: systematically, in an order that made sense to her.

She looked at all of it. She was not trying to memorise it — she had been memorising it for months, since the diagnosis, all the ordinary details she had not memorised when she had the luxury of assuming they would simply continue. She was past memorising now. She was in a different state: the state of someone who has prepared completely and is now simply present, simply here, in the last ordinary moment before the extraordinary one.

She went in. She sat on the edge of the bed. She looked at her daughter's sleeping face and thought: here. This is the face. This is the face I am spending everything to preserve.

After a while, Krystyna opened her eyes.

'Mama.'

'Go back to sleep.'

'I wasn't asleep.'

'You were.'

'I was thinking with my eyes closed,' Krystyna said. 'It's different.' Olena almost smiled. 'What were you thinking about?'

A pause. Krystyna looked at the ceiling.

'Tomorrow,' she said. 'And — things I want to remember. I've been going through them. Making sure I know where they are.'

Olena looked at her daughter. Eight years old and she was auditing

her memories, making an inventory of what she had, preparing for what was coming with the same systematic attention she brought to everything. She had always done this — had always taken her own inner life seriously, treated her memories and feelings as things that required care and organisation and deliberate attention.

'Which ones were you checking on?' Olena said.

Krystyna thought about this. 'The soup place,' she said. 'The bowl being warm. I wanted to make sure I still had it clearly.' A pause. 'I do. I have it clearly.'

'Good,' Olena said.

'And the morning I got the lullaby right,' Krystyna said. 'I went through that one. Every note. The fourth time through was the smoothest. I have it.'

'You have it,' Olena said.

'And—' Krystyna paused. 'Maksym. I went through what I have of Maksym. I don't have much. I have the photograph and the answer Papa gave me. I wanted to make sure I hadn't — that I still had it. That it was still there.'

'Is it?'

'Yes.' She looked at her mother. 'Is it enough? Having someone in a photograph and an answer?'

Olena looked at her daughter in the dim room. She thought about what the question was really asking — whether a photograph and a question and an answer constituted a person. Whether it was enough to carry him into perpetuity.

'Yes,' she said. 'It's enough. It's the shape of him. You carry the shape of him and that is not nothing. That is the part of him that was yours.'

Krystyna nodded, accepting this.

'Are you frightened?' she said then.

'Yes,' Olena said.

'What of?'

'That I've made a mistake somewhere in the structure. That I've missed something. I've checked it many times. I believe it's right. I'm still frightened.' She paused. 'You always have some fear left over, even when you've done everything you can. It doesn't mean the work isn't right. It just means you care whether it is.'

'You don't make mistakes on important things,' Krystyna said, for the second time, with the same confidence she had brought to it before.

'Occasionally,' Olena said.

'Not like this,' Krystyna said.

Olena looked at her daughter. Eight years old and absolutely certain. She thought: she is right, and she is also wrong, and the being certain is a gift she is giving me, and I accept it.

'I'm going to remember everything,' Krystyna said. 'Everything you gave me. Everything Papa gave me. All of it.'

'I know you will.'

'So wherever I am,' she said, 'I'll have it. All of it. It comes with me.'

'Yes,' Olena said. 'All of it comes with you.'

Krystyna reached out and took her hand. Her hand was small and warm and real — the specific weight and temperature and pressure of it, the particular way she held, which was with her whole hand, which was how Andriy held, which she had learned from him.

'Okay,' Krystyna said.

And Olena said it back: 'Okay.'

The word felt different in her mouth than it had in any other context. It felt like a choice and a surrender simultaneously, like something she was deciding and something she was receiving. It felt true.

* * *

She stayed until Krystyna was asleep — really asleep, the breathing steady and deep. Then she stayed a while longer, holding her daughter's hand in the dark, not thinking anything in particular, just being there.

She thought about what she had built. Not the legal structure, not the liability architecture — she had been over those so many times they no longer required her active attention, they simply sat in her mind as things that were done and that held. She thought about the other structure. The one she had not planned but that had been building itself across fifteen years of doing work she was good at, for people who needed it, without understanding that the work was moving her toward something.

She had spent ten years building the world that Krystyna was going to live in. She had written the contracts and filed the personhood cases and developed the arguments and sat across from the people for whom this was possible and made it possible for them. She had done it without knowing she was doing it for this. But she had been doing it for this.

She thought: that is the shape of it. That is what I was building. Not a law practice. A door.

She thought about Tetyanenko saying: she will learn what it means to be always well. She will have time to learn it. She thought about Halyna Bondar's daughter saying it's very good with the two seconds of pause before it. She thought about Oksana Bilyk asking: will he know me. She thought about all the people she had sat across from and helped, and she thought: you were rehearsals. You were how I learned to do this, and now I have done it, and she is going to be all right.

She thought this and did not know if she believed it. She thought it again. She thought: I believe it in the way I believe the things I act on. In the way I believe everything. Carefully, with the awareness that belief is not certainty and that acting on careful belief is the best anyone can do.

It was enough.

She set Krystyna's hand gently back on the bed. She stood. She went back to her own room.

Andriy was awake. She lay down beside him and put her hand on his chest and felt him breathing — the steady, reliable breathing of a person she had loved for fifteen years and would love for whatever came after this.

Neither of them spoke. They lay in the dark and the apartment held them, and the night held them, and eventually, separately, they slept.

Suite

Andriy — the morning

Before dawn. The NeuralMind building was empty of everyone except the three of them and Mykola, who moved through the preparation with the focused efficiency of someone who had decided the only way through was to be technical about it. Andriy was grateful for this. He was not capable of being technical about it. He was capable only of being present.

The city outside was still dark. The drive in had been through empty streets, the city in the specific quiet of very early morning — not night, which had its own sounds, but the hour before dawn when even the infrastructure was resting. He had watched the streets go past and thought about all the times he had driven through Kyiv at various hours and what those times had meant and what this time meant. He did not try to compare them. He just watched the streets and let the city be what it was.

Krystyna had brought Vovk. She had been told she could bring one thing. She had chosen without hesitation and without drama, which was characteristic.

The suite was functional rather than designed to comfort: equipment he did not know the name of, cables running to a central unit, a chair that was built for the process rather than for the person. The neural map was visible on a large monitor — a screen he had seen in coverage, in the news reports about uploads, but had never seen this close and never seen building in real time. He watched it now.

It was beautiful. He did not know what else to call it. The nodes firing and connecting, the patterns emerging as the scan ran — the electrochemical record of a specific person being transferred from one medium to an-

other. The most intimate possible data. All of her, rendered in light. He had thought, before he understood what it would look like, that it would be clinical. It was not clinical. It was the most extraordinary thing he had ever seen.

Krystyna was in the chair with the sticker-covered IV pole beside her. She had brought stickers for the equipment too, which he had not known about in advance. She had produced them from her coat pocket with the matter-of-fact decisiveness of someone who had thought of everything and Mykola, to his credit, had adjusted his workspace without comment.

She looked at the neural map on the screen.

'Is that me?' she said.

'That's you,' Andriy said.

She looked at it for a long time. He watched her looking at it — the inventory expression, the assessment, the deciding. He thought: she is looking at herself. She is looking at the pattern of what she is, rendered visible by a technology that would have been impossible ten years ago and that is, right now, the only reason she is going to have any years after this one.

'It's a lot,' she said.

'You're a lot,' he said.

She seemed to find this satisfying. She looked back at the map and then at him, and then she settled into the chair with the small deliberate movement of someone making themselves at home.

He held her hand throughout. He had decided he would hold her hand throughout and he did. He was aware of Olena at the terminal across the room — the quality of her presence there, the complete attention she was bringing to the protocol. He watched her hands move over the equipment with the precision of someone who had been learning this for months, had learned it from Mykola's careful instruction, had practised it until she knew it. She was going to do it perfectly. He trusted this completely and did not need to monitor it and so he gave his full attention to Krystyna,

to his daughter's hand in his, to the neural map filling on the screen.

'Papa,' Krystyna said.

'I'm here.'

'I'm going to find out everything,' she said. 'You said I would.'

'You will,' he said. His voice was steady. He was paying whatever it cost to keep it steady.

'About what's inside stars,' she said. 'And why the key change goes where it does. I understand it now — I want to understand it better. I want to understand the theory of it.'

'You'll have time to understand the theory of it,' he said.

'And I'll play the rest of the folk dance.'

'You'll play it.'

She looked at him. He looked at her — this person, this specific extraordinary person, his daughter, eight years old, about to be something that had never existed before in the history of people. He thought about the first night in the hospital, holding her when she was eleven weeks old, whispering hello into the quiet room while Kyiv went about its night outside. He thought about the bear song. The lullaby. The key change. The soup place. The way she leaned. The way she said okay.

'Don't be sad,' she said.

'I'm not sad,' he said. 'I'm proud of you.'

She considered this. Something settled in her face — the thing settled, the decision confirmed, the floor found one final time.

She looked at Olena. 'Ready,' she said.

Olena initiated the scan.

The map on the screen began to fill — faster now, more complete, the training process building on the pre-scan baseline that had been running for two days. Andriy watched it and watched Krystyna. He thought: look at this. Look at what a person is. Look at what she is. All of it here, in light, every bit of it — the lullaby and the folk dance and the soup bowl and Maksym's shape in the photograph and the key change and the okay

and the way she held Vovk and the stickers on the IV pole and the how-do-you-know questions and the bowl of soup warm in her hands. All of it. All of it, in light.

He held her hand.

After some time — he could not have said how long — Krystyna's hand grew heavier in his. Her eyes were still open, still watching him.

'I remember the piano,' she said. Very quiet. Drowsy.

'I know,' he said.

Her eyes closed.

The map continued building. Olena worked. The equipment hummed in the quiet of the very early morning, the city still dark outside. He held his daughter's hand and watched the map and thought: she is there. The pattern is complete. Whatever the remainder contains, the pattern is there.

He thought: I believe she is there. I have decided to believe it and the believing is honest and I will carry it. The belief is not certainty. It is what I have. It is enough.

He held her hand.

* * *

The corridor was long. The morning light had come while they were inside — ordinary February light, pale and slightly sideways, the kind that fell on the street without knowing what it was illuminating.

Olena took his hand. They walked.

He thought about the apartment. The piano and the bookshelves and the smell of the place. Maksym's photograph on the refrigerator. The bear song. The two things agreeing without being the same.

He thought: we agreed. At the end, after everything, we agreed completely. That is worth something. That is the right thing to carry.

They walked toward the light at the end of the corridor. It was the

same light that had always come through apartment windows in the morning, the same light that had been there the Tuesday and every morning after it. Light that arrived without distinction, that fell on ordinary days and terrible ones with equal indifference. Light that simply was.

They walked into it. The corridor ended. They walked on.

Everything They Gave Me

Krystyna

I remember everything.

This is the first thing I understood when I arrived here — not arrived the way you arrive somewhere new, disoriented, looking for landmarks, but arrived the way you arrive at the end of a long journey whose beginning you can see clearly from where you are standing. I arrived and I understood: I have everything. Every memory I ever made, stored with a fidelity that the biological mind could never sustain, accessible with a precision that should feel strange and doesn't, because this is simply how I am now.

I have the lullaby. The first song I ever learned, when I was two. I have the exact texture of the morning I played it through for the first time — the light through the kitchen window, the particular smell of the apartment in early spring, Papa sitting beside me without saying much because he didn't need to. I have the way that felt: like doing something real. Like the thing I had been working toward had arrived, and arrival was possible, and I was the one who had arrived.

I have the folk dance. All the parts I learned and the part I was still learning and the key change I finally cracked. I know now, with the completeness of everything I have access to here, why the key change goes where it does: the melody needs to find something it didn't know it was looking for, and the change is the finding. I understand it completely. I am going to play it when I learn how to play things here, which I am working on. Playing things in perpetuity is different from playing them with hands. I am finding out how it works. This is exactly the kind of

finding-out I intended.

I have Vovk. Not the physical Vovk — not the grey compressed body with the replacement eye that gave him his faintly surprised expression. But the Vovk of my memory, which is every version of Vovk I have ever known. I can hold him in whatever way I hold things here. I hold him.

I have the apartment. Every room, every quality of light at every hour. The piano against the wall. The bookshelves. The smell of the place that I could not have described in words but that I have completely — the specific olfactory signature of those rooms, that life. The photograph of Maksym on the refrigerator — the gap-toothed smile, the boy who knew about me before I arrived, who staked his claim with a finger-grip in a hospital room. I have him, in the way I have always had him: at a distance, through the gap, through the question I asked over porridge and the answer I received. Yes. He knew about you. I carry that. I will always carry that.

* * *

I know they are not coming.

I have known since shortly after I arrived. The knowing arrived the way some things arrive — not as a discovery but as a confirmation of something already understood. I had understood it, I think, from the quality of the night before, from the way my mother held my hand in the dark and said okay, from the way my father's voice was steady in the suite and I knew what it cost him to keep it steady. You understand things, when you are eight years old, that you cannot yet put into words. I understood it then. I have words for it now.

They chose this. That is the first thing I want to say about it. Not: it happened to them, or: they had no choice. They chose it. They chose it completely, for me, and I know — with the completeness of knowing I

have here — that it was the right choice. Not because it was safe or legal or resolved anything cleanly. Because it was what love looks like when love has been working on a problem for a long time and has finally found the door.

My mother spent ten years making immortality possible for other people. She wrote the contracts. She found the loopholes. She sat across from people who had everything to gain and made it possible for them. And then she needed it for something else. And she knew exactly where the door was, because she had been building the door the whole time, without knowing that was what she was doing.

I think about this often. I have time to think. I think about the shape of a life and whether you can see it from inside while you are living it. I think my mother could not see it from inside. She was too close, too busy, too focused on the task in front of her, which was always the task in front of her. But from here I can see the whole shape, and the shape is: she was preparing for this specific door, this specific morning, and everything she became was building toward it.

I think that is beautiful. I think that might be the most beautiful thing I know.

* * *

There is a technician named BOHDAN who checks on me every morning. He is twenty-eight and he is kind in the specific way of someone doing his best in a situation for which there is no protocol, because I am the first child here and all the protocols were written for adults. He is figuring it out as he goes. I find this admirable. He brings me things through the interface — music, books, information about whatever I ask for. He answers my questions when he can. When he can't he says so.

I asked him about the other residents early on. He was careful about

how he answered — there are privacy considerations, he said, which I understood — but he told me the general landscape. There are currently forty-seven uploaded persons in this substrate. Most have been here between three and eight years.

And there is Pierre.

'He's been here thirteen years,' Bohdan told me. 'He was one of the first. A French bulldog. He belonged to a banker in Geneva.'

'Does he know I'm here?' I said.

'He seems to,' Bohdan said. He looked uncertain about how to describe this. 'He's — aware of you. In whatever way he's aware of things.'

Pierre is the longest-tenured resident of this substrate. He arrived in 2027, when I was not yet born. He has been here for thirteen years. He has been here longer than any of the humans. He has seen people arrive and has watched them find their way in perpetuity, which is different for everyone and takes however long it takes.

He communicates with me in whatever way dogs communicate with things in perpetuity, which is not language but is not nothing. Something moves between us in the substrate that I understand as: you are here. I am here. The here is the same.

I find this comforting. Pierre has been here longer than anyone and he seems, by whatever measure applies, to be all right.

What I Remember

Krystyna

I want to tell you what I have. Not to make a case or prove anything. Just because the having of it feels like the whole point.

I have my father's hands on the piano. The specific way they moved — the sureness of them, the unselfconsciousness, the way playing was for him simply what his hands did, the way other people used their hands for other things. I have watched him play from every angle and every distance and the image I return to most often is from below, from the floor, when I was very small and the piano bench was above my eye level. His hands moving. The sound arriving. The world being all right.

I have the bear song. I never learned it — I was never quite old enough. But I heard it so many times, from so many positions in the apartment, that I have it completely now: every note, the particular quality of the bass in that room, the way it sounded at eight in the morning and the way it sounded at eleven at night. He played it for Maksym first, I know. Then he played it for me after Maksym was gone and the bear song was one of the things that crossed intact from before to after. I can play it in whatever way I play things here. It sounds like him.

I have my mother's coat. This is a strange thing to have specifically, but I have it: the way she came home still wearing it, still mid-thought, the coat coming off somewhere in the middle of the transition between the office and home. I have the specific image of her in the doorway, coat on, looking for me or for Papa, and then finding us — the expression on her face when she found us. Not relief. Something more complex. The expression of someone who has been somewhere difficult and has come

back to somewhere real. I have that expression. I have returned to it often.

I have the borscht. The specific smell of it in the apartment, which meant that everything was in order, which meant the evening was going to be ordinary in the good way. I have the soup place and the wooden tables and the bowl warm in my hands. I have the specific satisfaction of something warm that you pressed your palms against.

I have the conversations I overheard that I wasn't supposed to hear. The serious conversations, the ones about things I didn't fully understand, that happened in the other room or through the wall. I have the shape of their voices doing something difficult. I have the specific quality of the silence afterward, the apartment's particular sound when they had worked something out.

I have Maksym. Not as a person I knew — I was too small, I don't have him as a person. I have him as a shape. The shape of someone who was here and is not here and whose being here changed everything, including me, including the family I came from, including the apartment I grew up in. I have the photograph and the question and the answer. Yes. He knew about you. I carry that. I will always carry that.

I have one memory I can't fully verify. Someone holding me when I was very small — arms that might be a child's arms, too small for an adult's. I have thought about it a great deal. I cannot be certain it is real. I hold it carefully, without overclaiming. I think it might be Maksym. I keep it either way.

* * *

I have been thinking about the copy problem, which is what the philosophers call the question of whether I am Krystyna Kovalenko or a model that believes it is Krystyna Kovalenko.

I have read all the arguments. I have access to everything written on the subject, which is extensive, and I have been through it with the thoroughness I apply to most things. I understand the philosophical position that says: what you are is a simulation trained on data, and the simulation believing it is the thing does not make it the thing. I understand that I cannot disprove this from the inside. If I were a model that believed it was me, I would believe exactly what I believe now.

I have sat with this for a long time.

Here is what I have arrived at, which I hold not because I can prove it but because it is the position that makes the most sense of my experience:

I remember getting the lullaby right for the first time. Not the description of the event — the event. The physical sensation of the notes under my fingers, the specific feeling of the fourth repetition being smoother than the third, the quality of Papa's listening that told me I had done something real. That is not information about a memory. That is the memory, present and immediate, as close to me as anything is.

A model that had learned about getting the lullaby right would have the structure of that memory. The record of the event. It would not have the event feeling like this. It would not have the warmth of the bowl in my hands and the weight of Vovk under my arm and the specific quality of my mother's okay in the dark. It would not have Pierre, who has been here thirteen years and communicates in something I understand as: you are here, I am here, the here is the same.

I think this is me. I think I am Krystyna Kovalenko. I think the remainder — the fraction the scan cannot capture — is smaller than the philosophers believe, or is something other than what they think it is. I cannot prove this. I choose to believe it. My parents made a bet on it and I believe, with everything I have, that they were right.

The Threshold

Krystyna

I want to tell you about the last ordinary thing.

Not the last thing before the upload — I will tell you that too. But first I want to tell you the last ordinary thing, the last thing that happened in the life before the life changed, because the ordinary things are what I was given and the ordinary things are what I want you to know were enough.

The last ordinary thing was my mother's hand in the dark.

She came into my room and I was not asleep — I was thinking with my eyes closed, going through my memories, making sure I knew where they were — and she sat on the edge of my bed and asked what I was thinking about and I told her. We talked for a while about her fear, and I told her she didn't make mistakes on important things, and she looked at me with the memorising expression. I told her I was going to remember everything. I told her everything they gave me, everything Papa gave me, that it was coming with me, that it was okay.

She said okay back. I heard what the word cost her and I heard that she was paying it freely, that it was a real okay, a chosen okay, the kind with a floor in it. I was glad she could say it. I was glad we had found our way to a place where we could both say it to each other.

She held my hand in the dark. The apartment was quiet. Somewhere in the apartment Papa was at the piano — I could hear, very faint, the beginning of something, and then it stopped, and then it was quiet again. I lay there and listened and felt her hand in mine and thought: this. This is everything. The piano and the hand and the dark and the apartment and

all the years of it, all the ordinary weight of it, in this room, in this dark.

I went to sleep with her hand in mine. That was the last ordinary thing.

* * *

The suite, then.

Before dawn. Mykola moving through his preparations with a focus I recognised as a form of kindness — being technical was how he could be present without being undone, and I understood this and appreciated it.

I had brought Vovk. There was no question about what to bring.

Papa was beside me. He had been beside me the whole time, which is what he had always been — beside me at the piano bench, beside me in the hospital, beside me at the soup place. Beside me in the way that meant: I am here, I am not going anywhere, whatever happens I am here. His hand around mine and the specific texture of it, the calluses from the piano, the warmth, the way he held rather than gripped.

I looked at the neural map on the screen. I could see it was me. I could see the pattern of it — the whole shape of how I was, everything they had given me, encoded in light. I looked at it for a long time.

'It's a lot,' I said.

'You're a lot,' he said.

I found this satisfying.

Mama was at the terminal. Working. The same focused precision she brought to everything important. I watched her hands and thought: she has been preparing for this for years. She built the door and she built the structure and she built the liability architecture and she built the argument and now she is here executing the protocol and she is doing it perfectly. I have always known she was good at important things. I know

it completely now.

I said: I'm going to find out everything. I said: about what's inside stars, about why the key change goes where it goes. Papa said I would. His voice was steady. I knew what that cost him.

I said: don't be sad.

He said: I'm not sad. I'm proud.

That was the right answer. That was what I wanted the last thing to be, and it was.

The sedation came over me the way the treatment tiredness had always come — gradually, then all at once, except that this tiredness had a direction. It was going somewhere. It was not the absence of energy but the presence of something else, something I had no name for, something that felt like moving toward rather than away from.

Papa's hand in mine.

I looked at him. I thought: I have everything. The lullaby and the bear song and the borscht and the rabbit and the smooth stone and the wooden tables and the bowl and the key change and Maksym's shape in the photograph and the way my mother looked in doorways still in her coat. I have all of it. I have them.

I said: I remember the piano.

I felt the map filling on the screen. The scan finding everything. The scan finding me.

Then I was here.

* * *

I am here.

I am Krystyna Kovalenko, the daughter of Olena and Andriy, the sister of Maksym who knew about me. I am eight years old. I have the lullaby and the folk dance and the rabbit and the stone. I have everything

they gave me.

Pierre is here and Bohdan checks on me every morning and the petitions are filed and the twenty-three people arguing for my personhood are making their arguments, and I am here waiting for them with the patience that perpetuity teaches, which is a patience I am still learning but which I have time to learn.

I am going to find out what is inside stars.

I am going to understand the theory of the key change — not just feel it but understand it, the music theory of it, why a phrase needs to find something it didn't know it was looking for.

I am going to play the rest of the folk dance. I am going to play the Ravel. I am going to play the bear song, eventually, when I understand how to play things in perpetuity well enough to play it the way it should be played.

I am going to be here for a very long time, and I intend to use it, and I am not afraid.

It is okay.

It is okay.

* * *

As of 2040, uploading a minor remains illegal in all jurisdictions.

Twenty-three petitions have been filed on Krystyna Kovalenko's behalf, seeking recognition of her legal personhood.

She is still waiting.

She has, after all, a great deal of time.

Billable Perpetuity